

LG Sandhu orders war-footing response to waterlogging

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Lt Governor (LG) Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Wednesday said he has directed senior officers to treat waterlogging in the national capital as a "disaster" and mount a war-footing response. The LG, who held a meeting with senior officers to review the situation late Tuesday evening, called for a 'whole-of-government' approach and asked departmental and agency heads to remain present on the ground to ensure swift redressal of citizens' complaints.

The directions came after several weather stations in Delhi recorded more than 100 mm of rainfall on Tuesday, leaving roads waterlogged and traffic gridlocked. It was the capital's wettest August day in two years. "Directed that the situation be treated as a disaster requiring a war-footing response, with a 'whole of government' approach and every department and agency



working in complete synergy rather than in silos," Sandhu said in a post on X on Wednesday. He directed that all heads of departments be physically present on the streets during flooding situations to personally oversee remedial measures on the spot, rather than monitoring the situation from their offices.

He made it clear that his office would closely monitor the situation going forward, and cautioned that senior officers and all ranks of engineers must match, and not lag behind, the level of presence and accountability

already being shown by MLAs and Ministers on the ground. The LG directed that all heads be physically present on the streets during flooding situations to personally oversee remedial measures on the spot, rather than monitoring the situation from their offices. According to the officials, the LG said that waterlogging must not be allowed to occur in the first place. He ordered that the installation of pumps be expedited on a war-footing across all vulnerable points in the city.

He asked officials to prioritise real-time redressal of complaints raised through

the media, social media and other platforms and stressed continuous monitoring to ensure directions are implemented and visible results delivered on the ground. "Our priority and focus must remain clear: swift relief to citizens and a safer, better-managed Delhi," Sandhu said.

Knee-deep water, slow-moving traffic and rain-soaked roads marked Tuesday in Delhi as the national capital received more than 100 mm of rainfall at several weather stations, making it the wettest August day in two years.

The Safdarjung weather station recorded 99.1 mm of rainfall in the 24 hours ending 8:30 am on Tuesday, the highest for an August day in two years. The last time the city recorded more rainfall in August was on August 1, 2024, when Safdarjung received 107.6 mm.

Waterlogging was reported across several key parts of Delhi as rainwater accumulated on roads and at major junctions.

NDMC apologises for waterlogging, vows to strengthen systems

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) apologised to residents on Wednesday for waterlogging following heavy rain in the area over the last two days, saying it will strengthen its systems to prevent a repeat of the disruption. NDMC chairman Manoj Kumar Dwivedi said the civic body was usually able to clear waterlogging within 15-20 minutes, but the situation was different at three to four locations on Tuesday, where it took more than an hour for the water to drain.

"More than 72 mm of rainfall was recorded in less than two hours," Dwivedi said in a post on X, describing the intensity of the spell as "unexpected".

"Usually we can clear the waterlogging within 15-20 minutes. But despite our best efforts in at least 3-4 areas water was fully drained out in more than an hour," he said.

However, Dwivedi said the heavy rain could not be used as an excuse for the



inconvenience caused to residents. "This cannot be an excuse and we will have to strengthen our systems to deal with such situations in future." He also invited suggestions from residents on improving the system.

According to officials, the council received dozens of complaints related to waterlogging, tree felling and power outages in the Lutyens' area in the last two days. The national capital received more than 90 mm of rainfall at several weather stations, including Safdarjung, which recorded 99.1 mm of cumulative rainfall till 8:30 am on Tuesday, according to the weather department.

The NDMC's complaint

records show that seven waterlogging complaints were received on August 24 from various locations including Connaught Place, Gol Dak Khana, Lodhi Estate, Sarojini Nagar, DIZ Area near Gole Market and outside Lady Hardinge Medical College.

The records also show five complaints related to fallen trees on the same day, including incidents in Laxmibai Nagar, Sarojini Nagar, near Lady Hardinge Medical College and near the Ghana Embassy.

Seven complaints of power outages were also recorded, including from areas such as Connaught Place, Khan Market and R K Ashram.

Dwivedi said the civic body would take both short- and long-term measures to make the NDMC area "fully waterlogging-free".

"We will work to ensure that our citizens should not face any inconvenience in future," he said, inviting suggestions from residents on improving the system.

On Wednesday morning, a large tree fell inside Vithal Bhai Patel House in Lutyens' Delhi, damaging at least four vehicles parked nearby.

Waterlogging was reported across several key parts of Delhi on Tuesday as rainwater accumulated on roads and at major junctions. In central Delhi, waterlogging was reported on Ashoka Road, Raisina Road and Parliament Street.

Parliament complex also witnessed waterlogging on Tuesday along with stretches near RML Hospital, Baba Kharak Singh Marg and Connaught Place.

Heavy rainfall lashed Delhi on Monday and Tuesday, triggering waterlogging and other rain-related complaints across parts of the city.

28 factories found violating pollution norms in Ghaziabad raid, 16 sealed

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

All 28 industrial units inspected during a surprise raid in Loni, Ghaziabad, were found violating environmental regulations. The Commission for Air Quality Management in NCR and Adjoining Areas said on Wednesday that authorities seal 16 of the factories violating the norm.

The inspection drive was carried out on August 25 under "Operation Clean Air," CAQM's ongoing campaign against illegal and polluting industrial units in the National Capital Region. Seven flying squads, along with magistrates, police personnel and officials of the Uttar Pradesh Pollution Control Board, conducted checks across the 28 premises, the commission said. Every single unit inspected was found non-compliant with applicable environmental norms, according to the commission.

The violations detected included units operating without a valid Consent to Operate, use of unapproved fuels such as wood and coal, and furnaces running without required Air Pollution Control Devices or proper chimney



arrangements. Inspectors also found industrial units functioning without adequate pollution control infrastructure, along with instances of open painting and powder-coating activities being carried out illegally, the commission said.

Of the 28 premises checked, 21 units were found operating without a valid Consent to Operate, while 14 cases involved the use of unapproved fuels, including wood and coal.

Eight cases involved either missing or inadequate pollution control devices, or furnaces running without the necessary chimney infrastructure, according to the commission's statement. Based

on these findings, 16 units or premises were sealed by the Uttar Pradesh Pollution Control Board, working alongside the district administration and the flying squads, the commission said.

Preliminary reports or show-cause notices were served on six units. In another six cases, notices were pasted on the doors of the premises, including instances where the units were found locked, or where occupants had left after spotting the arrival of inspecting officers, according to the commission.

The commission reiterated that all industrial units operating in the NCR are required to strictly comply with environmental regulations.

Govt plans reclaimed water policy to boost treated water use, cut groundwater extraction

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

To enhance usage of treated water and reduce groundwater extraction, the Delhi government is planning a 'Reclaimed Water Policy'. Water minister Parvesh Sahib Singh said on Tuesday. Delhi treats around 750 million gallons per day (MGD) of sewage, after accounting for environmental flow, around 483 MGD is available for reuse, while only about 120 MGD is currently being reused.

"Nearly 363 MGD of treated water remains available for greater beneficial reuse. Reclaimed water will progressively replace potable water and groundwater used for horticulture, construction, landscaping, washing, industrial cooling and other non-potable uses," Singh said.

DJB is initiating a detailed stakeholder discussions, after which the policy will be sent to the government for approval, he added.

The policy was approved by a Delhi Jal Board (DJB) in its recent board meeting, under which reclaimed



(treated) water will be made available for usage and even made mandatory for some uses, including construction and horticulture activities.

"Eligible farmhouse use will be charged at ₹10,000 per acre per month, with a one-time infrastructure charge of ₹1 lakh per acre where infrastructure is not already available. Applications will be considered for holdings of 100 acres or more," Singh said in a statement.

The treated water will be supplied at ₹8 per kilolitre from designated sewage treatment plant (STP) filling points or existing DJB infrastructure. Where consumers arrange or bear the cost of conveyance infrastructure, the

rate will be ₹5 per kilolitre for general non-potable uses. The DJB plans to notify 'Reclaimed Water Service Areas' around compliant sewage treatment plants (STPs) and connected sewer networks to ensure a dependable supply.

"Construction sites measuring 500 square metres or more in these notified areas would be required to use reclaimed water for dust suppression, curing, washing and road watering.

"Bulk water consumers would also be brought under a phased substitution programme, with the policy targeting 100 per cent use of reclaimed water for eligible non-potable requirements by 2036," Singh further said.

BJP seeks FIR against Congress, SP over posts on Nabin's food

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi unit of the Bharatiya Janata Party has filed a complaint with police seeking an FIR against the Congress, the Samajwadi Party (SP) and unidentified social media accounts.

The BJP accused them of spreading false claims that national president Nitin Nabin consumed non-vegetarian food during his visit to Andhra Pradesh. The complaint, addressed to the Deputy Commissioner of Police, Central District, was submitted on Wednesday and signed by Delhi BJP leaders Ramvir Singh Bidhuri, Vishnu Mittal and Sanket Gupta.

According to the complaint, videos and photographs of Nabin were circulated during his recent visit to Andhra Pradesh, showing him eating what the party described as a traditional local dish called Panasa Mukkalu, which it said was entirely vegetarian.

The BJP alleged that certain



individuals and social media accounts falsely claimed Nabin was consuming non-vegetarian food during the Hindu month of Shraavan, also known as Sawan, a period during which many Hindus follow vegetarian dietary practices. The party termed these claims false, misleading and politically motivated.

The complaint named the Samajwadi Party's media handle and the Indian National Congress's Chhattisgarh unit as having shared posts referencing the visit, and included links to two posts on the social media platform X in support of its claims.

The Pioneer

Classified

CHANGE OF DOB

I, Samarth Sharma S/o Sh. Sameer Sharma aged about 16 years, R/o Flat No. 4171, Tower-4, ATS Pristine, Sector- 150, Noida hereby declare that in my Class 10th Marksheet my D.O.B wrongly has been recorded as 25/08/2009. and My actual Date of Birth is 25/12/2009.

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Anita Srivastav, W/o Vinod Srivastav, R/o N-1/56, Budh Vihar, Phase-I, Delhi-110086, hereby declare that my name has been incorrectly mentioned as "Amita Srivastava" in some of my documents/records. My correct and actual name is "Anita Srivastav".

I, Diksha Srivastav, D/o Vinod Srivastav, R/o N-1/56, Budh Vihar, Phase-I, Delhi-110086, hereby declare that my name has been incorrectly mentioned as "Diksha Srivastava" in some of my documents/records. My correct and actual name is "Vinod Srivastav".

I, Vinod Srivastav, S/o Shri Vashishth Lal Srivastav, R/o N-1/56, Budh Vihar, Phase-I, Delhi-110086, hereby declare that my name has been incorrectly mentioned as "Vinod Srivastava" in some of my documents/records. My correct and actual name is "Vinod Srivastav".

I, Bhagwant Singh, S/o Than Singh, R/o C-258, Pul Pehlampur, Near Badarpur, Dist- Nainital, Uttarakhand-110044, have changed my name from Bhagwant Singh to Bhagwant Singh Rawat. Henceforth, I would be known by the name of Bhagwant Singh Rawat for all future purposes.

I, No.15439979N NK/NA Daleep Singh, R/o- Vill- Jaipur Padli- 01, PO- Lamachaur, Dist- Nainital, Uttarakhand-263139, have changed my mother's name from Khema Devi to Khima Devi, vide affidavit dated 26/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Gauri Davi, Mother of No.15159365N Hav(OPR) Sunil Kumar, R/o- Vill- Dariyapur, PO- Cherki, P.S- Sherghati, Dist- Gaya, Bihar-824237, have changed my name from Gauri Davi to Gauri Devi, vide affidavit dated 26/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Shalini Shukla, W/o No.15421611H Shiv/LA Amit Kumar Shukla, R/o- Vill & PO- Singra Khurd, Dist- Palamu, P.S- Daltonganj- Jharkhand-822101, have changed my name from Shalini Shukla to Shalini Kumari, vide affidavit dated 26/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PARIJAT PAPER MILLS LIMITED

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NOTICE OF THE 38th ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING AND INFORMATION ON E-VOTING & RECORD DATE

1. Notice is hereby given that the 38th Annual General Meeting ("AGM"/"Meeting") of the Members of the Company is scheduled to be held on Friday, September 18, 2026 at 02:00 a.m. IST through AT THE REGISTERED OFFICE OF THE COMPANY SITUATED AT VILL-JAT MUJHERA, 10.6 KM STONE, BHOPA ROAD, MUZAFFARNAGAR UTTAR PRADESH, 251308 (INDIA), to transact the businesses set out in the Notice calling the AGM, in compliance with applicable provisions of the Companies Act, 2013 ("Act"), and Rules made thereunder and the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 ("SEBI Listing Regulations") read with Ministry of Corporate Affairs ("MCA") General Circular No. 09/2024 dated September 19, 2024, read with the circulars issued earlier in this regard (collectively referred to as the "MCA Circulars") and Securities and Exchange Board of India ("SEBI") Circular No. SEBI/HO/CFD/CFD-PoD-2/P/CIR/2024/133 dated October 03, 2024, read with the circulars issued earlier in this regard (collectively referred to as the "SEBI Circulars"), respectively. The venue of the AGM shall be deemed to be the registered office of the Company.

2. The notice of 38th AGM and Annual Report for the Financial Year 2025-26 have been sent through electronic mode to the Members whose e-mail address are registered with the Company/ Registrar & Share Transfer Agent ("RTA")/ Depository Participants ("DPs"). The electronic dispatch of Annual Report to Members has been completed on 25th August, 2026. Additionally, in accordance with Regulation 36(1)(b) of the SEBI Listing Regulations, the Company has also sent a letter to shareholders, whose e-mail addresses are not registered with the Company/RTA/DP, providing the weblink where the Annual Report can be accessed. The documents pertaining to the items of the business to be transacted in the AGM shall be available for inspection as per the procedure provided in the notice of AGM.

3. The copy of the Notice of 38th AGM and Annual Report will also be available on the website of the Company at <https://parijatpapermills.com/annual-reports/website> of the Stock Exchange, i.e. Metropolitan Stock Exchange at <https://mseindia.com> and also at the website of our RTA at <https://in.mpms.mufg.com/>.

4. Pursuant to the provisions of Section 108 of the Act read with Rule 20 of the Companies (Management and Administration) Rules, 2014 (as amended), the Secretarial Standard on General Meetings (SS-2) issued by the ICSI and Regulation 44 of SEBI Listing Regulations (as amended), the Members are provided with the facility to cast their votes on all resolutions as set forth in the notice of the AGM using the facility of remote e-voting or e-voting at the AGM. The Company has appointed MUGF Intime India Private Limited to provide e-voting facility to cast vote on the businesses to be transacted at the AGM.

5. Members whose name appears in the Register of Members or Register of Beneficial Owners maintained by Depositories as on the cut-off date i.e. Friday, 11th September, 2026 shall only be eligible to avail the remote e-voting or e-voting facility at the AGM. The voting rights of the Members shall be in proportion to their share in the paid-up share capital of the Company as on the cut-off date and a person who is not a member as on the cut-off date shall treat the notice for information purpose only.

6. Any person who acquires shares of the Company and becomes member of the Company after the dispatch of the notice and holding shares as on the cut-off date i.e. Friday, 11th September, 2026, may obtain the login ID and password by sending a request at parijatpapermills@yahoo.com and enotices@in.mpms.mufg.com. However, members who are already registered with MUGF Intime India Private Limited for remote e-voting can use his/her existing user ID and password for casting vote.

7. The remote e-voting period is as follows: **Commencement of Remote E-Voting** 15th September, 2026 (09:00 A.M. IST) **Conclusion of Remote E-Voting:** 17th September, 2026 (05:00 P.M. IST)

8. Members may please note that the remote e-voting shall not be allowed beyond 05:00 P.M. (IST) on 17th September, 2026 and facility shall be disabled by MUGF Intime India Private Limited thereafter. Once the vote on a resolution is cast by the member, the member cannot change it subsequently. Members who have already cast their vote by remote e-voting prior to the AGM will be entitled to attend the AGM and their presence shall be counted for the purpose of quorum. However, they shall not be entitled to cast their vote again.

9. The facility of e-voting will also be made available during the AGM and the Shareholders attending the AGM who have not casted their vote by remote e-voting and are not otherwise barred from doing so, shall be eligible to vote through e-voting system during the AGM.

10. The detailed procedure for e-voting, both remote e-voting and voting on the date of AGM, by the members holding shares in dematerialized mode and for members who have not registered their email address has been provided in the Notice of AGM.

11. In case of any queries or issues regarding remote e-voting or attending the AGM, you may refer the Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs) for Shareholders and e-voting user manual for Shareholders available at the download section of enotices@in.mpms.mufg.com or call on: 022-4918 6000.

12. Members are requested to carefully read all the Notes set out in the Notice of AGM and in particular instructions for joining the AGM, manner of casting the vote through remote e-voting or e-voting at AGM.

For and on behalf of Parijat Paper Mills Limited.

Sd/-

Amit Mittal

Whole Time Director

DIN: 00754471

Date: 27.08.2026

Place: Muzaffarnagar

PUBLIC NOTICE

I, Momin Ali S/o Mr. Tehseen Ali R/o A-158, Mazidwail Gali Durga Vihar, New Delhi-110062, hereby declare that I have severed all ties with my Daughter Shifa Saffi Age 20 Yrs D/o Momin Ali R/o A-158, Mazidwail Gali Durga Vihar, New Delhi-110062, due to their mistreatment. I have disowned and debarred them from my movable and immovable properties. They shall be solely responsible for their acts and liabilities in the future. That any body who deals with her/his in any manner whatsoever shall doing at their own risk and I shall not be responsible for his/ her acts of omission and commission.

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given to the General Public on behalf of our client i.e. ICICI Bank Ltd. that Mrs. Ruchika Handa Manakata & Mrs. Shweta Bajaj daughters of late Surinder Mohan Handa & late Sushma Handa are claiming to be owners of Unit / Flat No. 3-A, on Third floor, Front side, (the said floor) Property bearing No. 4, measuring 351 sq. mtrs., in Block-D-2, situated at Janakpuri, Delhi, vide a SMC Basis, after demise of late Surinder Mohan Handa & late Sushma Handa. All Persons are hereby informed that above claiming owners want to sale the said floor to Mr. Abhay Aggarwal or his nominee who is taking a loan facility from our client for purchase of the said floor. If anybody has any objections upon the ownership of above claiming owners its sale / mortgage & any other kind of objection / litigation, Charge etc., kindly inform the undersigned in writing on the below mentioned address within 10 days of the present.

Kumar & Associates (Consultants)
200, Hind Rd., 23, Shivaji Marg, Moti Nagar, New Delhi-15
legal@kumarandassociates.com Ph: 011-4112227-26

NORTHERN RAILWAY

TENDER NOTICE

Invitation of tender through E-Procurement System

Principal Chief Materials Manager, Northern Railway, New Delhi-110001, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites e-tenders through e-procurement system for supply of the following items:-

S.No.	Tender No.	Brief Description	Qty.	Closing Date
1.	07260297	SET OF TPU RINGS CONSISTING OF 02 ITEMS	3026 SET	07.09.26
2.	09262569	TOP HOUSING FOR CCPU SB PAD	7793 NOS	05.10.26

NOTE:- 1. Vendors may visit the IREPS website i.e. www.ireps.gov.in for details 2. No manual offer will be entertained. **Tender Notice No. 38/2026-2027 Dt. 25.08.2026**

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Retail Asset Centre: Axis House, Jaypee Green Wish Town, Tower-2, 4th Floor, Sec-128, Noida Expressway, Noida-201301

Corporate Office: 'Axis House', Block-B, Bombay Dyeing Mills Compound, Pandurang Budhkar Marg, Worli, Mumbai-400025, Registered Office: 'Trishul', 3rd floor, opposite Samartheshwar Temple, Law garden, Ellisbridge, Ahmedabad-380006. Also at: Axis Bank Ltd. Himalaya House, Upper Ground Floor & First Floor, KG Marg, Connaught Place, New Delhi-110001

PUBLICATION OF NOTICE REGARDING POSSESSION OF PROPERTIES BY/OF SARFAES ACT 2002

Notice is hereby given under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 (54 of 2002) and in exercise of powers conferred under section 13 (1)(2) read with rule 9 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002, a demand notice was issued on the dates mentioned against each account and stated hereinafter calling upon them to repay the amount within 60 days from the date of receipt of said notice.

The Borrower having failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given to the Borrower and the public in general that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described herein below in exercise of power conferred on him/her under section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 9 of the said Act on the dates mentioned against each account.

The Borrower in particular and the public in general is hereby cautioned not to deal with the property and any dealings with the property will be subject to the charge of the Axis Bank Ltd. for an amount and interest thereon.

The borrowers attention is invited to provisions of Sub-section (8) of Section 13 of the Act, in respect of time available to recover the secured assets.

Sr. No.	Name of Borrower / Co-borrower	(1) Date of Demand Notice (2) Date of Possession (3) Amount in Demand Notice (Rs.)
1.	1. Ansumani (Borrower), A-153, Sector-37, Greater Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201306. 2. Amit Kumar (Co-borrower), A-153, Sector-37, Greater Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201306.	(1) 14.06.2025 (2) 25.08.2026 (3) Rs. 20,76,729/- (Rupees Three Lakh Seventy Four Thousand Nine Hundred Seventy Six Only)

PROPERTY ADD:- Flat No. 1304, 13th Floor, Tower-D, Shivalki Homes, HRA-09, Surajpur, Site-C, Phase-II, Greater Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201306.

2.	1. Mr. Deepak Sharma, R/o D-29, Block-D, Pandav Nagar, Delhi-110092; also at Adroit Commodities Services Pvt. Ltd., Senior Ex Dealer, Shop No. 140 & 148, 1st Floor, SuperTech Ramshwar Shopping Complex, Kaushambi, Ghaziabad, UP-201010	(1) 29.04.2025 (2) 25.08.2026 (3) Rs. 20,76,729/- (Rupees Twenty Lakh Ninety Eight Thousand and Seven Hundred Twenty Nine Only)
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Also At:- E-140, Second Floor, Trikolpur, Pocket-1, Mayur Vihar, Phase-1, Delhi-110091; 2. Mr. Janesh Sharma, R/o D-29, Block-D, Pandav Nagar, Delhi-110092; also at E-140, Second Floor, Trikolpur, Pocket-1, Mayur Vihar, Phase-1, Delhi-110091.

PROPERTY ADD:- All that piece and parcel of property bearing Flat No. E-140, Second Floor, Trikolpur, Pocket-1, Mayur Vihar, Phase-1, Delhi-110091 and bounded as under: East - As per Title Deed; West - As per Title Deed; North - As per Title Deed; South - As per Title Deed.

Dated: 27.08.2026, Place: Noida

Sd/-, Authorised Officer, Axis Bank Ltd.

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given on behalf of Mr. Utpal Pathak to inform to the public at large that Mrs. Rupee Kumari W/o Utpal Kumar Pathak is purchasing the Property measuring 40 Sq. Yds, Kharsa No. 9374981, Situated at Shri Ram Nagar, Village Pasonda, Loni, Ghaziabad, U.P. from (i) Mrs. Narbat Devi W/o Babu Lal, (ii) Mr. Raju Ram S/o Babu Lal, (iii) Mrs. Leela Gehlot D/o Babu Lal who became owners after the death of Late Babu Lal expired on 29.01.2027 and Mr. Babu Lal was the owner through Sale Deed dated 07.04.1997 (Doc No.1835) and same to be secured by mortgage by Axis Finance Limited, Noida. That, Legal Heirs Certificate of Late Mr. Babu Lal is not available. So, to comply the requirements of BANK/NFR, we give this public notice, that if any Person having knowledge of claim/right/lien/interest/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within 15 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc.

Lucent Legal LLP
B-93B, Second Floor, Opp. SBI Bank Sector 2, Noida, UP-201301 Contact: 0120-4269379

PUBLIC NOTICE

NOTICE REGARDING LOSS OF ORIGINAL CERTIFICATE OF REGISTRATION ISSUED BY THE RESERVE BANK OF INDIA

Notice is hereby given to the general public that M/s Bilus Investments Private Limited, a company incorporated under the provisions of the Companies Act, having its Registered Office at SF-19, Aditya Mega Mall, near Karkardooma Court, CBD East, East Delhi, Delhi-110032 is a Non-Banking Financial Company (NBFC) registered with the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) under Section 45-IA of the Reserve Bank of India Act, 1934. The Company was granted a Certificate of Registration (CoR) bearing No. 14.01519, dated 20/09/1999, by the Reserve Bank of India, authorising the Company to carry on the business of a Non-Banking Financial Institution, subject to the applicable provisions of law and regulatory directions issued by the Reserve Bank of India from time to time. It is hereby notified that the original Certificate of Registration issued by the Reserve Bank of India has been lost/misplaced and, despite diligent efforts, the same could not be traced. The Company has taken all reasonable steps to ascertain whereabouts of the original Certificate of Registration, but the same remains untraceable. The Company has accordingly decided to take appropriate steps with the Reserve Bank of India for issuance of a duplicate/ replacement Certificate of Registration, as may be applicable under the regulatory procedure prescribed by the Reserve Bank of India. Any person who has found, received, possesses or has any claim or objection in respect of the aforesaid original Certificate of Registration is requested to inform the Company and/or return the same to the Registered Office of the Company at the address mentioned below within 15 days from the date of publication of this notice. It is further notified that the original Certificate of Registration bearing the aforesaid number, if found or produced subsequently, shall be treated as lost and shall not be relied upon or used for any purpose without written confirmation from the Company and/or return the same to the Registered Office of the Company at the address mentioned below within 15 days from the date of publication of this notice. Any person dealing with or relying upon the lost original Certificate of Registration, without independent verification from the Company and/or the Reserve Bank of India, shall do so at his/her/its own risk. The Company hereby reserves all rights and remedies available to it under applicable law in respect of any unauthorised use, representation, possession or misuse of the lost original Certificate of Registration.

For **Bilus Investments Private Limited**
Authorised Signatory
Date : 27/08/2026
Place: New Delhi
Director
Registered Office: SF19, Aditya Mega Mall, near Karkardooma Court, CBD East, East Delhi, Delhi-110032

138 fresh H1N1 cases in 24 hrs, Health Minister reviews preparedness

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The national Capital reported 138 H1N1 cases in the last 24 hours, taking the cumulative number of cases this year to 2,446, while the total number of Influenza-A cases stood at 3,177, the Delhi Government said on Wednesday.

Health Minister Pankaj Kumar Singh held a virtual review meeting with medical directors and medical superintendents of Delhi Government hospitals to assess preparedness for H1N1, seasonal influenza and other respiratory illnesses.

The minister directed hospitals to strengthen emergency services and ensure adequate availability of isolation beds, doctors, testing facilities, medicines and other essential resources.

Hospitals were asked to maintain at least five isolation beds, while larger hospitals were directed to keep 10 or more beds for managing

influenza and vector-borne disease cases.

They were also told to maintain shift-wise duty rosters and ensure round-the-clock availability of doctors and medical staff.

According to the Delhi Government, the city has reported 138 H1N1 cases in the last 24 hours, taking the total number of cases this year to 2,446. The total number of Influenza-A cases stands at 3,177. The minister directed hospitals to establish or strengthen dedicated flu corners in emergency departments, with senior residents deployed for emergency duty. Suspected patients should be assessed promptly and swab samples collected and sent for testing wherever clinically indicated.

Hospitals were also asked to ensure adequate stocks of Viral Transport Medium and other supplies required for respiratory specimen collection and testing.

Special emphasis is placed



on children and elderly people, with hospitals directed to ensure their timely assessment and appropriate care.

A review of medicine availability was also conducted, with hospital administrations asked to submit regular reports on stocks of essential medicines. Hospitals were advised to undertake local

procurement wherever necessary to prevent disruption in patient care.

The health minister also directed hospitals to put up clear and visible banners and information, education and communication material in emergency departments and other high-footfall areas to spread awareness about

influenza symptoms, precautions and appropriate health-care-seeking behaviour.

"There is no need for panic. Most of the patients who have come to hospitals so far have presented with mild fever and other common symptoms and have recovered within a day or two. Delhi Government hospitals

are fully prepared, and our health system is continuously monitoring the situation," Singh said.

He said the review was aimed at ensuring that hospitals were equipped to respond effectively and there were no gaps in patient care.

"This was not merely a meeting to issue instructions, but a comprehensive review of the preparedness of our hospitals. Our doctors and medical teams are working very hard and doing an excellent job. We have reviewed the availability of beds, testing facilities, medicines and emergency services to ensure that there is no gap in patient care," the minister said.

He appealed to people to remain vigilant without panicking and follow respiratory hygiene, hand hygiene and cough etiquette, use masks appropriately and avoid unnecessary exposure to crowded places, particularly when symptomatic.

The health department will

continue to monitor influenza trends and hospital preparedness, with a focus on timely testing, adequate isolation capacity, availability of essential medicines and uninterrupted emergency services, the Government said.

Testing and treatment facilities are available across Government hospitals, health facilities and Ayushman Arogya Mandirs, it added.

The Delhi Medical Association has issued an advisory amid a rise in H1N1 cases in the national Capital, urging people to follow respiratory and personal hygiene measures, avoid crowded places and seek timely medical advice if they develop flu-like symptoms.

The association advised people to cover their mouth and nose while coughing or sneezing, wash their hands frequently and avoid touching their eyes, nose and mouth with unwashed hands.

It also advised people to maintain distance from those

suffering from H1N1 or influenza-like illness and avoid spreading in public places.

The DMA has recommended wearing an N95 mask while experiencing flu symptoms, while health care professionals have been advised to wear masks in clinics, hospitals and OPDs.

It also cautioned people against taking antibiotics or antiviral medicines without consulting a qualified physician and advised those with flu-like symptoms to avoid meeting relatives, friends and others to prevent the spread of infection.

The association further advised people returning from travel or areas witnessing increased influenza activity to monitor their health for at least 10 days and report to the nearest health facility if they develop symptoms. It also recommended using face masks in crowded areas, markets and public transport.

Delhi Lakshmi Yojana launched, first payments of ₹2,500 from September 1

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government on Wednesday handed over sanction letters to 4,190 beneficiaries of the Delhi Lakshmi Yojana, under which eligible women will receive ₹2,500 per month directly in their bank accounts. After the formal launch of the scheme that was a key poll promise of the BJP in the run-up to the 2025 Delhi elections, Union minister Harsh Malhotra, Lieutenant Governor

Taranjit Singh Sandhu and Chief Minister Rekha Gupta handed over sanction letters to the beneficiaries at the Talkatora Stadium.

According to officials, the beneficiaries received the sanction letters after completing the prescribed verification process. They will receive the first instalment of ₹2,500 in their bank accounts through the direct benefit transfer (DBT) mode on September 1.

The Chief Minister said registration for the scheme began on August 1, with more than 9.22 lakh women registering so far. She said the scheme aimed to give women financial security, confidence and decision making ability, not just mone-



Delhi LG Taranjit Singh Sandhu, CM Rekha Gupta, Ministers Ashish Sood, and others with beneficiaries during the official launch of the 'Delhi Lakshmi Yojana' welfare scheme at Talkatora Stadium in New Delhi on Wednesday

etary assistance. Explaining the structure of the assistance, the Chief Minister said of the ₹2,500 monthly amount, ₹1,000 would be made available through a digital wallet for immediate spending, while ₹1,500 would be deposited as an FD or RD to build long term savings.

The Chief Minister described the scheme's launch during Sawan, Teej and Raksha Bandhan as a special gift for Delhi's women, calling it "Teej ka Sindhara" and "Rakhi ki Saugaa" from the Prime Minister. She said Delhi remained blessed by goddesses including Maa Jhande Wali, Maa Kalka, Maa Chhatarpur and Maa Yogmaya, and assured attendees she would personally deliver rakhis and

thank-you letters brought by women to the Prime Minister.

Women present at the event repeatedly raised slogans of "Dhanyawad Rekha Didi" throughout the programme, with cultural performances adding to the celebratory atmosphere. Special registration counters were set up at the venue to help connect additional eligible women with the scheme.

Eligible women in the 21 to 60 age group will receive the monthly assistance through Direct Benefit Transfer, with recipients free to use the funds for their personal or family needs. During the event, officials symbolically handed over sanction letters to 65 selected beneficiary women on stage.

The Chief Minister added that the scheme's name reflected the view of women as symbols of prosperity and strength in families and society. She referenced Modi's message that national progress depends on women's progress, and listed other Delhi Government initiatives for women, including the Delhi Lakhpati Beti Scheme, Vidya Vahini Scheme, Palna Scheme, Pink Card, Annamol Scheme and free LPG cylinders for eligible women.

She also referenced central Government schemes for women, including Pradhan Mantri Ujjwala Yojana, Pradhan Mantri Mudra Yojana, Sukanya Samridhi Yojana, Lakhpati Didi, Drone Didi and Pradhan

Mantri Awas Yojana, saying crores of women nationally were becoming part of self-help groups, entrepreneurship and digital finance under Modi's leadership.

The Chief Minister said monthly assistance alone was insufficient for making women self-reliant, and that Delhi has introduced a provision for collateral-free loans of up to ₹10 crore for small entrepreneurs to support women starting or expanding businesses. Malhotra said the central Government continued working for women's empowerment nationally, while the Delhi Government was committed to providing women with the facilities and economic opportunities needed to become financially stronger and self-reliant.

Sandhu extended congratulations to the women of Delhi, calling the scheme a special Raksha Bandhan gift.

He referenced teachings of Guru Nanak Dev Ji on the value of women in society and said Nari Shakti, or women's strength, would play an essential role in building both a developed Delhi and a developed India across sectors including manufacturing, agriculture, technology and defence.

National Capital records light rain; yellow alert issued for thunderstorms

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi received light rain on Wednesday, a day after the national Capital witnessed heavy showers that led to widespread waterlogging and traffic disruptions, according to the India Meteorological Department (IMD). The city did not face major traffic disruptions on Wednesday as several establishments observed a public holiday and the rain was not widespread or heavy.

The weather department issued a yellow alert for the evening and night, forecasting thunderstorms accompanied by lightning and light-to-moderate rainfall.

Delhi has already crossed its seasonal average rainfall, with the city recording 653.9 mm of rain till date against the normal 484.6 mm, a surplus of 169.3 mm or 35 per cent. Among major weather stations, Palam has recorded 533.2 mm against a normal of 462 mm, a surplus of 71.2 mm or 15 per cent. The Ridge has recorded 692.3 mm against a normal of 421.6 mm, marking a surplus



of 270.7 mm or 64 per cent.

In the 24 hours till 8.30 am on Wednesday, the city's primary weather station at Safdarjung recorded 8.8 mm of rainfall. Palam recorded 5.6 mm, Lodi Road 0.5 mm, Ridge 3.2 mm and Ayanagar 1.5 mm during the period.

Between 8.30 am and 5.30 pm, Ayanagar recorded another 13.3 mm of rain, while Safdarjung and Lodi Road recorded trace rainfall. No rainfall was recorded at Palam and Ridge during this period. The weather remained generally cloudy through the day, with intermittent showers reported in parts of the city.

The maximum temperature at Safdarjung settled at 33.8 degrees Celsius, 0.3

degree below normal. Palam recorded a maximum of 34.2 degrees Celsius, 0.2 degree below normal, while Lodi Road recorded 33.6 degrees Celsius, 0.2 degree above normal. Ridge and Ayanagar recorded maximum temperatures of 33.2 and 33.6 degrees Celsius, respectively, both 1.4 degree below normal.

The minimum temperature at Safdarjung was 26.5 degrees Celsius, 0.1 degree above normal. Palam recorded 24.2 degrees Celsius, 1.9 degree below normal, while Lodi Road recorded 26.7 degrees Celsius, 1.7 degree above normal. Ridge and Ayanagar recorded minimum temperatures of 23.6 and 24.6 degrees Celsius, respectively.

Chemist shops told to stop exaggerated discount claims on medicines

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Government has asked chemist shops and medical stores in the city to avoid making "unrealistic, misleading or vague" claims of discounts on medicine prices, following complaints that some outlets were claiming 60-80 per cent rebate.

The drug control department of the Government has flagged the issue of "exaggerated" discounts on medicine prices, citing a Kerala High Court order in June that upheld regulatory action against "misleading/vague" discount boards while recognising that genuine sale of medicines below maximum retail price (MRP) is not prohibited, officials said.

According to a recent advisory issued by the department, it has been observed that many retail pharmacies in Delhi are displaying promotional boards, banners and advertisements carrying claims such as "up to 60, 70, 80 percent discount".

The department asked all licensed pharmacies and medical stores in Delhi to refrain from displaying or publicising "unrealistic, exaggerated, false, misleading or vague" claims regarding discounts or prices of medicines to promote sale of prescription medicines.

The advisory pointed out that though selling medicines below the MRP is permissible as such, advertisements containing "vague, exaggerated or misleading" discount claims have the potential to mislead consumers.

"Unrealistic and exaggerated" discount claims on phar-



maceutical products even below the purchase price from their actual manufacturers and authorised distributors further raise concerns regarding the genuineness of the source of procurement," it said.

It noted that medicines are not ordinary consumer goods. They are essential healthcare products directly connected with the health and well-being of patients.

Emphasising the need for maintaining a higher degree of responsibility, transparency and ethical conduct in sale, procurement and distribution of medicines, the drug control department has asked the chemist associations in Delhi to sensitise their members about the issue.

Retail pharmacies and medical stores have also been advised to comply with the advisory in the interest of transparency, consumer protection and prevention of "misleading" commercial practices in the sale of medicine.

The retailers have been asked to ensure that any discount offered by them is genuine, transparent and actually available to the customer and is verifiable from the sale bill and purchase records of the firm.

Traffic Police gears up for BRICS Summit with 22 diversion points

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Traffic Police has chalked out a detailed traffic management plan for the BRICS Summit to be held in the national Capital from September 11 to 13, with arrangements being made to ensure smooth movement of delegates as well as commuters, an official said.

As part of the preparations, the traffic police has held meetings with navigation and cab-hailing platforms, including Google Maps, Ola, Uber and Bharat Taxi, to explore ways to incorporate traffic advisories and diversion plans into their navigation systems. Additional Commissioner of Police (Traffic) DK Gupta said.

"The summit will see participation of delegates from several states as well as foreign countries, has national importance and is expected to lead to movement of dignitaries and other participants on important routes across the city,"



he said.

The traffic police has identified 22 diversion points as part of the elaborate plan. Details of the diversions, along with suggested alternative routes, will be communicated to commuters through multiple platforms, including social media, so that they can plan their journeys and reach their destinations with minimum inconvenience.

"Traffic advisories will be disseminated through all available mediums. The commuters will be informed about the diversion points and alternative routes well

in advance," Gupta said.

He said traffic personnel deployed for the summit would undergo proper training and be fully familiarised with the designated routes, diversion points and movement plans.

The personnel would also assist commuters and facilitate traffic movement during the summit, he added.

The detailed advisory will be issued closer to the summit and made available to commuters through various communication channels, including the traffic police's social media platforms.

Man held for creating fake accounts in woman's name, sending obscene content

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A 27-year-old man has been arrested in Delhi for allegedly creating fake social media accounts using a woman's name and photograph. The accused uses its accounts to send obscene content to her husband and acquaintances, police said on Wednesday.

The accused, identified as Jeetu Kumar, a resident of New Ashok Nagar, allegedly kept creating new fake accounts whenever an exist-

ing one was reported and taken down, causing the woman prolonged mental harassment and distress, police said. Police registered an FIR under relevant sections of the Information Technology Act based on a complaint filed by the woman.

During the investigation, police obtained details of the fake accounts and carried out a technical analysis. The probe revealed that the accounts were being created and operated using a mobile number registered in



Kumar's name, following which a police team raided his location and apprehended him, according to police.

A mobile phone allegedly

used to commit the crime was recovered from Kumar's possession at the time of his arrest, police said. During questioning, Kumar allegedly told police

that he knew the victim and had been following her since 2022. Police said he created the fake accounts using her name and photograph before using them to circulate pornographic and obscene material to people known to her. Police said Kumar has no prior criminal record.

The case highlights the growing misuse of social media platforms for targeted harassment, with accused persons often creating multiple accounts to evade detection after previous ones are

reported and removed. Police have not disclosed further details about the woman's relationship with Kumar beyond his claim of having followed her since 2022, nor have they specified how many fake accounts were created in total during the course of the harassment.

The complaint filed by the woman detailed how the fake accounts were used to target both her husband and other acquaintances with obscene material, according to police.

IN FOCUS



Indian Navy's sail training ship INS Sudarshini concludes her three-day port call at Lisbon, Portugal, as part of her ongoing Lokayan 26 transoceanic expedition.

PTI

Flash flood in Nepal leaves hundreds dead...

Bridges connecting communities have also been damaged, cutting off settlements and making it difficult for ground teams to move into the worst-hit areas.

Several hydropower installations have been affected, adding to concerns over electricity supplies and essential infrastructure.

Rescue helicopters have been deployed, but operations have been restricted by the rugged terrain, debris and unsafe conditions in some locations. Authorities have urged people living close to the Bhote Koshi, Trishuli and other rivers to remain vigilant and move to safer ground where necessary.

The precise cause of the sudden flood remains under investigation. A magnitude 4.4 earthquake was recorded near the Nepal-Tibet border on Wednesday morning. Preliminary assessments have raised the possibility that ground movement triggered an ice-and-rock avalanche or landslide, temporarily obstructing a river before a sudden release of water sent a destructive surge downstream.

Officials and experts are continuing to examine the sequence of events. The cause has not yet been conclusively established, and authorities remain concerned about additional landslides, flooding and other hazards in the unstable mountain environment.

For hundreds of families, the disaster has become an agonising wait for information.

In many affected areas, disrupted communications and destroyed transport links have made it difficult for authorities to determine who has reached safety and who remains stranded.

Rescue workers are therefore facing a race against time as they search damaged settlements and attempt to reopen routes into the mountains. The death toll and missing-person figures could change as teams gain access to areas that remain cut off.

For Nepal, the immediate priority is clear: find those who are missing, evacuate survivors, restore vital links and prevent further loss of life in a region where the threat of flooding and landslides remains high.

Bihar, UP on flood alert

The National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) is being mobilised to deal with any emergency, they said. The Sashastra Seema Bal (SSB) has also alerted all its formations along the 1,751-km India-Nepal international border and 18 teams have been deployed to launch relief and rescue operations.

Special vigilance has been ordered in West Champaran, East Champaran, Gopalganj, Saran, Muzaffarpur and Vaishali, besides other vulnerable districts such as Sitamarhi and Sheohar. Authorities have opened all 36 gates of a barrage on the Gandak river to help control the situation, state officials said.

Deputy CM Vijay Kumar Choudhary, who also holds the Water Resources Department (WRD) portfolio, said, "A technical team led by a Superintending Engineer has been deployed at the barrage. Warnings have also been issued to all districts in the Gandak river basin."

In Uttar Pradesh, Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath expressed concern over the flash floods in Nepal and directed Maharajganj and Kushinagar districts to take all necessary measures to deal with any potential emergency.

In Maharajganj, District Magistrate Gaurav Singh Sogarwal has directed agencies concerned to make arrangements to evacuate people from vulnerable low-lying and riverside areas to safe, elevated locations if required. In Kushinagar, the district administration has ordered the evacuation from Marchahwa, Shivpur and other villages, and announcements are being made urging residents to move to safer locations. District Magistrate

Tejasvi Surya seeks rethink on Karnataka parks Bill

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bengaluru

Bengaluru South MP Tejasvi Surya on Wednesday urged Karnataka Governor Thaaawarchand Gehlot to return a Bill allowing portions of park and garden land to be used for public infrastructure and utility projects to the legislature for reconsideration.

He alleged that the legislation could put the state's green spaces at risk of irreversible diversion.

A delegation of citizens, walkers' associations and former senior government officials, led by Surya, met the governor and submitted a memorandum.

The Karnataka Government Parks (Preservation)(Amendment) Bill, 2026, passed by both Houses of the state legislature on Monday, seeks to amend the 1975 Act. It was passed without discussion amid protests by the Opposition, which was demanding the resignation of Minister B Nagendra.

Later, speaking to reporters, Surya warned that a mass public movement would be launched in Bengaluru to protect its parks and environment.

"The issue is not politics, but a public issue; it is Bengaluru's issue. To stop this arrogance, we will launch a mass movement. People on every street in



Bangalore South BJP MP Tejasvi Surya talking at a rally in Hyderabad

WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

Bengaluru will come forward and raise their voices to protect the city's parks and environment. I warn the CM that we will organise this mass movement," he said.

"On August 30, citizens will hold a walk inside Lalbagh, demanding that this unscientific and unconstitutional move be dropped," he added.

In a letter to the governor, Surya said the Bill was passed "without substantive debate", despite concerns raised by citizens, civil society organisations, experts and former senior government officials.

The amendment allows the state government to alienate land in government parks and gardens through sale, lease, gift, exchange,

mortgage or otherwise, up to an overall limit of five per cent of the total area of land or buildings comprising such parks and gardens.

The provision applies to government departments, statutory authorities, government companies and local authorities for public utility projects. Land already alienated through such means would also count towards the five per cent ceiling, he said.

Surya contended that allowing the diversion of park land was "arbitrary" and raised concerns over the right to a healthy environment, which has been recognised as an integral part of the Right to Life under Article 21 of the Constitution.

Public parks and natural heritage properties are not

merely parcels of land but intergenerational assets that support biodiversity, provide clean air, and offer spaces for health, recreation and public well-being, he said.

Citing Supreme Court judgments, the BJP MP said the apex court had emphasised the importance of protecting parks and open spaces and held that public interest in preserving them could not be sacrificed by leasing or selling such land for other uses.

Surya raised concerns over the proposed Tunnel Road project in Bengaluru, saying it would reportedly require around 1.92 hectares, or nearly five acres, of Lalbagh for the construction of a tunnel and shaft.

He referred to the proposed Hebbal Short Tunnel, which, he claimed, would require around 3.45 acres of Hebbal Lake, an ecologically important water body and ground-water-recharge area.

The Detailed Project Report for the Tunnel Road project envisages parking and a commercial complex around the shaft, he alleged. Lalbagh, he added, is home to the approximately three-billion-year-old Peninsular Gneiss and is an important ecological and geological heritage site.

According to Surya, Bengaluru has around 1,353 parks spread across approximately 1,308 acres.

BJP's Vijayvargiya sparks sugar row



WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Indore

Amid criticism by opposition parties over rising prices of sugar ahead of festivals, Madhya Pradesh minister Kailash Vijayvargiya on Wednesday said it should in fact become very expensive, and added that people above 40 years of age should completely avoid its consumption.

Ninety per cent of the people do not like sweets these days, he said, adding that he himself does not eat such items. Talking to reporters here, the BJP leader claimed that the prices of sugar were steadily falling.

"Anyway, 90 per cent of people don't like sweets these days. Let me tell you, I don't eat sweets at all," he said.

In a lighter vein, the Parliamentary Affairs Minister said, "I say that (sugar) should become very expensive. (Sugar) should only be available at cheap rates at government fair price shops for children...The elderly should not be given sugar at all."

He said that doctors, espe-

cially Ayurvedic ones, do not consider it a good idea for people over 40 year of age to consume sugar.

"If you are over 40, you can eat jaggery once in a while, but avoid sugar completely," he said.

State Congress President Jitu Patwari latched on to Vijayvargiya's remarks to target the ruling BJP over the rising sugar prices.

He said that BJP leaders, who came to power on the promise of reducing inflation, are insulting and ridiculing the poor and middle-class with their absurd statements on sugar.

"The country is watching BJP leaders. People will give a befitting reply to their laughter in the upcoming elections. Then we will see whether they retain their smiles or shed tears," he said.

Opposition parties have been targeting the Centre over increased ethanol blending in petrol, alleging that the policy was pushing up sugar prices and imposing an additional financial burden on people.

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concern the immigrant visa interview process. Other visa categories may be subject to separate rules and restrictions introduced by the US government. Applicants should therefore check the instructions applicable to their specific visa category rather than assuming that every US visa appointment has been halted.

The latest action also comes shortly after a federal judge struck down a separate Trump administration policy that had restricted immigrant visa processing for nationals of 75 countries. The court ruled on August 21 that the Secretary of State had exceeded his legal authority by imposing the nationality-based restrictions.

That earlier policy and the current appointment disruption are separate measures. The State Department has publicly described the latest changes as part of a worldwide training initiative rather than a nationality-based suspension.

The biggest unanswered question is when normal interview scheduling will resume. The State Department has not announced how long the training programme will last or provided a universal date for the restoration of postponed appointments. For applicants, the immediate outlook is therefore one of delay and uncertainty rather than outright rejection.

People waiting for immigrant visa interviews should continue checking official communications from their processing embassy or consulate and follow any new instructions they receive.

The latest move adds another layer of uncertainty to an already changing US immigration system, as the Trump administration continues to increase scrutiny of applicants seeking to enter and remain in the United States.

CJI steps into Rajasthan HC row, insists on...

"The CJI also emphasised that the Supreme Court cannot allow individual complaints concerning judges to be determined through competing claims in the media," the statement said.

The CJI further said that he and the other members of the collegium are already working on the appointment of chief justices in the remaining high courts.

In his letters, Justice Mehta has alleged that Justice Sharma had misused his powers as master of the roster to selectively transfer cases to his own bench, including matters involving influential and wealthy litigants.

Justice Mehta was appointed a judge of the Rajasthan High Court in May 2011. He became Chief Justice of the Gauhati High Court in February 2023 and was elevated to the Supreme Court in November the same year.

Justice Sharma was appointed a judge of the Rajasthan High Court in November 2016 and transferred to the Patna High Court in January 2022.

His request for repatriation to Rajasthan on health grounds was not accepted by the Supreme Court Collegium in March 2023.

He was instead transferred to the Punjab and Haryana High Court. The Collegium subsequently recommended his repatriation to Rajasthan in May 2025.

Justice Sharma has been functioning as the ACJ for more than 10 months after Justice S Shirram, the Chief Justice of the Rajasthan High Court, demitted office in September 2025.

Justice Mehta had previously brought several such instances against Justice Sharma to the CJI's notice, including cases listed before other benches that were subsequently withdrawn and shifted to Justice Sharma's court "without any justifiable cause".

According to the letters, the CJI had initially asked him to provide details of such cases but later told him there was no need to put the allegations in writing and assured him that "suitable action" would be taken.

"However, till date, the request to have a Chief Justice from another state in my parent high court

has met no positive response," Justice Mehta wrote in his August 2 letter.

He said he had also received complaints about Justice Sharma's judicial functioning which, in his assessment, "prima facie, raise doubts on his integrity". In his August 10 letter, Justice Mehta cited two cases which he described as "living proof" of what he alleged were attempts by Justice Sharma to exercise his administrative and judicial powers in favour of influential parties before his retirement on September 26.

Giving instances, Justice Mehta said, "These instances manifest brazen misuse of powers by the Acting Chief Justice Mr S P Sharma in order to favour influential parties and smack of corruption."

Jharkhand policemen seek Dumri MLA's arrest

On the basis of the station-in-charge's complaint, Barwadda police station case No. 146/2026 was registered on August 22 under Sections 221, 224, 132, 351(2), 352 and 3(5) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) against the MLA, 10 named accused and around 40-50 unidentified persons.

The Police Association said Ravi Kumar had approached the federation seeking action against what it described as an "inhuman act" and called for measures to protect the dignity and security of police personnel.

The association claimed that police personnel in Dhanbad and across Jharkhand were angry over the incident. Its Dhanbad branch has reportedly demanded that members wear black badges in protest and has also sought consideration of an indefinite withdrawal from duty if the issue is not addressed.

The association further alleged that Mahato has repeatedly used objectionable language against police personnel through social media and the press. It said the alleged threat to "teach a lesson" when the officer was off duty had raised concerns about the safety of the station-in-charge and other police personnel.

The association has urged senior authorities to complete all legal procedures and ensure the arrest of Mahato and the other accused within five days. It warned that failure to act within the deadline would prompt the association to mobilise its branches and members across the state for a wider agitation.

The association said its stand was aimed at protecting the welfare, dignity and professional honour of police personnel, and that it would continue to pursue the matter through organisational and legal channels.

Before world leaders arrive, BRICS hotels...

The notice has been issued "over serious food safety violations and non-compliance with FSSAI requirements." In another post, the regulator informed that it has issued notice to Juniper Hotels Pvt Ltd (Andaz, Aerocity, Delhi) following inspections that "uncovered serious food safety violations".

Top world leaders, including Chinese President Xi Jinping, Russian President Vladimir Putin, Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian, South Africa's president Cyril Ramaphosa, Egypt's president Abdel Fattah el-Sisi, Belarus' president Alexander Lukashenko, Kazakhstan's president Kassym-Jomart Tokayev, and Indonesia's president Prabowo Subianto are expected to attend the 18th BRICS Summit.

Inspections at Andaz Delhi by Hyatt and JW Marriott New Delhi identified a range of concerns involving food storage, pest control, refrigeration, labelling and food-handling practices. The regulator has collected samples from both the hotels and further action would be taken based on lab reports. The hotels have reportedly been identified among properties being used to accommo-

date foreign visitors for the summit.

The FSSAI also shared details of an inspection at JW Marriott in Aerocity (operated under Aria Hotels and Consultancy Services), in which the hotel was found conducting retail operations under the JW Marriott brand without the necessary licence. It was also found inadequate pest control, presence of cockroaches and fruit flies, and poor maintenance of food premises.

"Various kitchens and food preparation areas, including the Chinese, Indian, Italian and Bakery Kitchens, showed deficiencies such as pest infestation, non-operational exhaust systems, poor sanitation, inadequate allergen segregation, defective storage containers, improper food identification and inappropriate storage of food products," the authority said.

The FSSAI further said pre-packaged items lacked mandatory manufacturer addresses or displayed misprinted licence numbers on items, including paneer, khoya and chana masala. The primary FSSAI license was also not displayed prominently on the premises.

Officials documented active infestations of cockroaches and fruit flies, dirty food-contact surfaces, and unwashed kitchen utensils.

Drinking water supplies contained visible particulate matter, highlighting inadequate pest control protocols and poor general maintenance of the food prep areas, it further said.

The inspection also highlighted hazards such as spoiled ingredients, including fungal-affected apples and rotten tomatoes. Food was routinely left uncovered or stored in damaged containers; staff also failed to properly segregate vegetarian and non-vegetarian products, mismanaged storage temperatures, and neglected required food identification labels, creating substantial cross-contamination risks, as per the inspection. During the inspection, regulatory samples including Fric Bergen Honey, D'lecta Skimmed Milk Dairy Whitener, Drinking Water, Red Velvet Sponge, Angoori Rasmalai, Khoya, Paneer and Sonth Chutney were lifted. Surveillance samples were also collected during the inspection, and the notices issued, wherever applicable, were provided to the FBO.

At Andaz Delhi by Hyatt (operated by a firm named Juniper Hotels), around 87 kg of expired sweets were found in the confectionery area and destroyed on the spot, the FSSAI said. : Inspection revealed active cockroaches near freezers, houseflies, mosquitoes in the grinding room, spider webs, and the discovery of a gutka packet inside the bottling plant area. Bread packets bearing expired stickers were also recovered, and expired cake bases, flies and cockroaches were found in the pastry section. Deficiencies were recorded in the segregation of vegetarian and non-vegetarian food in the kitchen, with cutting boards used for both categories kept in the same water container, it further said.

At Manesar NSG Training Academy, women...

Second, specialist skills are still limited to a few. If only a small group of NSG operators have the top counter-terror expertise, the country's response remains centralised. Training women and sending them back to their own forces helps expand that group without lowering standards. The course will be tough. This is not just a slogan, but the real plan. Commando conversion is meant to be selective, even after the first round of selection. Those who finish will leave with more than a certificate. They will return with habits of fire discipline, teamwork, and crisis timing that others in their units can learn from. Whether the first MCCC is a one-time event or the start of a regular program will depend on what these women do after November. It will depend on how they train others, how their forces use them, and whether commanders see them as specialists or just symbols. The NSG has already made its choice.

Union Govt asks States to integrate water, sanitation works to VB-G RAM G

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Centre has asked states and Union territories to integrate drinking water source sustainability, greywater management and sanitation works with the VB-G RAM G rural employment guarantee scheme.

The directive was issued earlier this month through a joint letter by the Ministry of Jal Shakti and the Ministry of Rural Development, which asked States and UTs to ensure convergence of resources for water security and sanitation and outlined measures for integrated planning, implementation and monitoring of such works.

The letter said water security has been identified as one of the four thematic focus areas under the Viksit Bharat-Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission

(Gramin) (VB-G RAM G) Act, 2025.

The ministries directed that drinking water source sustainability works under Jal Jeevan Mission (JJM) 2.0, grey-water management interventions and sanitation and solid and liquid waste management (SLWM) works under Swachh Bharat Mission (Grameen) 2.0 be integrated into Viksit Gram Panchayat Plans (VGPPs) under the appropriate thematic categories of the Act.

The implementation must be guided by water budgeting, local resource assessment and water security plans.

The states were asked to give due priority to groundwater recharge, rainwater harvesting, rejuvenation of water bodies, watershed development, check dams, recharge structures, spring-shed management and other decentralised water conser-



Representative image

vation measures, particularly in water-stressed areas.

The letter recommended that the additional chief sec-

retary, principal secretary or secretary in charge of the rural water supply/public health engineering depart-

ment should be included in the state-level steering committee constituted under the Act.

States and UTs may also nominate dedicated nodal officers from the state water and sanitation mission and the rural development department, with corresponding district-level nodal officers, to facilitate coordinated planning, technical scrutiny, implementation and monitoring of convergent activities.

The ministries further asked States to technically align village action plans prepared under JJM 2.0 and SBM (G) 2.0 with VGPPs before approval by the gram sabha, ensuring optimal utilisation of resources and avoiding duplication.

They directed that drinking water source sustainability works, sanitation assets, greywater management structures and other convergent assets be registered and geo-tagged on the Viksit Bharat National Rural Infrastructure Stack to facili-

itate integrated monitoring, transparency and evidence-based decision-making.

States were also encouraged to use geospatial planning tools such as Yuktadhara, along with water budgeting and hydrogeological assessments, to identify and prioritise water conservation interventions following the ridge-to-valley approach.

The letter said the convergence arrangements may be institutionalised during the ongoing VGPP planning cycle so that investments under VB-G RAM G, JJM 2.0 and SBM (G) 2.0 collectively contribute to sustainable drinking water security, groundwater recharge, climate resilience and improved rural livelihoods.

It said close coordination among the departments of rural development, drinking water and sanitation, panchayati raj and other concerned departments at

the state, district and gram panchayat levels will be critical for successful implementation.

Such convergence will strengthen rural drinking water security and improve ecological sustainability, climate resilience and the quality of life of rural communities, it said.

The letter also referred to the joint advisory issued by the two ministries on June 18, which advised states and UTs to accord the highest priority to water-related works under the VB-G RAM G Act and ensure minimum expenditure of 65 per cent in over-exploited and critical blocks, 40 per cent in semi-critical blocks and 30 per cent in safe blocks.

The communication was addressed to principal secretaries and commissioners in charge of VB-G RAM G in all states and Union territories, except Delhi and Chandigarh.

After rebel MPs, TMC plans ‘surgical strike’ on MLAs

SAUGAR SENGUPTA ■ Kolkata

The Trinamool Congress was planning a “surgical strike” on its rebel MLAs after the party’s 20 breakaway MPs were “neutralised,” sources in the Mamata Banerjee camp of the former Bengal ruling outfit said hours after the Lok Sabha secretariat issued a notice to the rebel TMC MPs to explain their stance on a disqualification petition filed against them in the Supreme Court by party general secretary Abhishek Banerjee.

“Some of them (MLAs) are in touch and could return anytime soon... for others the plans are being chalked out for a surgical strike... let only their big brothers in Parliament (read rebel MPs) be neutralised first — the process for which has already started... they are flying high... but they won’t,” a senior pro-Mamata Banerjee leader said.

The Lok Sabha secretariat issued notices to the 20 rebel MPs — who had joined NCPI — asking them to submit their rejoinders within a week



on the petition filed in the Supreme Court by Abhishek Banerjee seeking their disqualification under Rule 6 of the Members of Lok Sabha (Disqualification on Ground of Defection) Rules, 1985.

The notice from the Lok Sabha Secretariat dated August 25 forwarded Abhishek

Banerjee’s petition before the Apex Court and sought the rebel MPs’ “comments” vis-à-vis disqualification rules. It read: “You are requested to kindly furnish your comments on the petition in terms of rule 7(3) of the same rule within seven days of the receipt of this letter for consideration of the Hon’ble

Speaker, Lok Sabha.”

Senior TMC MP Kalyan Banerjee, who had earlier moved the petition in the Apex Court, said, “Wait, many things will take place in a couple of months... there will be a lot of things that will change... the game has just started.”

Welcoming the new development, TMC Rajya Sabha Member Sagarika Ghosh too appealed to Speaker Om Birla to disqualify the rebel lawmakers, saying, “What has happened today is a breakthrough... it is significant and important that after two months the Speaker’s Office has finally acted under the 10th Schedule; they attract immediate disqualification.” According to the 10th Schedule, it was not the MPs but parties that could merge.

She earlier wrote, “The disqualification of 20 traitors for their brazen violation of the Constitution is imperative. It’s not just about one party. It’s about protecting the Constitution.”

Jharkhand to move SC against amended mines Act: Minister

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Ranchi

Jharkhand Finance Minister Radhakrishna Kishore on Wednesday said the state Government will move the Supreme Court against the amended MMDR Act, alleging it would cause a major revenue loss to the State exchequer.

Kishore claimed the amendment would result in a revenue loss of around ₹14,000 crore to the State, affecting various social welfare schemes, particularly the women-centric ‘Maiyan Samman Yojana’.

“We have decided to move the Supreme Court regarding the issue. The chief minister has issued an order in this regard,” Kishore told reporters.

The State had estimated to earn ₹14,000 crore from cess during the current financial year but would now be deprived of the expected funds, he said.

“The tate is all set to face a revenue loss of ₹4,000 crore after implementation of the VB-G RAM G



Jharkhand FM Radhakrishna Kishore

and lost ₹4,000 crore after rationalisation of GST. If we include the cess, the state will face a loss of ₹22,000 crore. How will we compensate this huge amount?” the finance minister asked.

Kishore said the Government had decided to pursue the matter through democratic and legal means.

“We will go to the public with the issue and move the Supreme Court seeking relief,” he said.

The minister said he had held detailed discussions with senior officials of the finance and mines departments to review the amendments made by the Centre to the MMDR Act and assess their impact on Jharkhand’s economic interests.

“Jharkhand’s mineral wealth forms a crucial foundation for the state’s economic strength. Safeguarding the state’s revenue and constitutional rights is our top priority,” he said.

Earlier this month, Parliament passed the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026, which seeks to restrict states’ powers to levy taxes on mineral rights and mineral-bearing lands.

The state’s Congress unit will launch a phase-wise protest from August 27 against the passage of the bill in Parliament.

India expresses solidarity with Nepal at this difficult hour: Murmu

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

President Droupadi Murmu on Wednesday conveyed deepest sympathies to her Nepalese counterpart Ramchandra Paudel and the people of the neighbouring country on the devastation caused by flash floods there, saying that India expresses solidarity with Nepal at this difficult hour.

At least 46 people died and nearly 500 others, including 105 Indians, are missing after a massive flash flood originating in Tibet swept through central Nepal districts on Wednesday.

So far, 46 bodies have been recovered from the flash flood-hit areas, security officials said.

India stands ready to support the relief and rescue efforts of the Government of Nepal for those affected by this calamity, President Murmu said in a post on X.

“I convey my deepest sympathies to Rt Hon President



Ramchandra Paudel @OOP_Nepal and the people of Nepal on the devastation caused by the flash floods today. We express our solidarity with Nepal at this difficult hour,” the president said.

The flood surged through the Bhote Koshi River around 9 am (local time), affecting Rasuwa and Dhading districts bordering Tibet, officials said. It then spread to Dhading, Nuwakot and Chitwan districts, damaging at least four permanent bridges and a few temporary ones.

Successful rangeland restoration begins with pastoralists as custodians: Bhupender Yadav

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New

DelhiCombining traditional knowledge with modern science can deliver rangeland restoration that is ecologically sound, economically viable and socially inclusive, Environment Minister Bhupender Yadav said on Wednesday.

The minister also said that successful restoration begins with pastoralists as custodians, not merely beneficiaries.

Yadav made these comments while addressing a ministerial dialogue on ‘Restoration of Rangelands and the Well-being of Pastoralist Communities’ at the 17th Conference of Parties (CoP17) of the UN Convention to Combat Desertification (UNCCD) in Mongolia.

The minister highlighted that satellite-based desertification and land degradation atlases provide a scientific basis for mapping grasslands and planning restoration.

Moreover, recognition of



grazing rights and community forest resource rights help strengthen the role of local communities in sustainable management, according to Yadav.

The minister summed up his address by saying that India’s approach integrates landscape management, watershed develop-

ment, sustainable grazing, fodder development and livelihood support, with community participation at its core.

“India welcomes dedicated, accessible financing for rangeland restoration, and stands ready to share its experience and solutions through South-South cooperation,” he said.

India rejects UN body's critique on rights violations

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India on Wednesday trashed a report by a UN body that alleged discrimination against various ethnic and religious groups in the country.

The UN Committee on the Elimination of Racial Discrimination (UNCERD) flagged concerns over human rights violations against people belonging to sched-



Randhir Jaiswal

uled tribes, scheduled castes and Rohingya refugees.

It also called for action against those involved in “hate crime” in India.

External Affairs Ministry spokesperson Randhir

jaiswal said India rejects “any politically motivated highly malicious references in the report with all the contempt that it deserves”.

He said India’s commitment to combating racial discrimination “remains unwavering”.

“During the review, we highlighted India’s constitutional safeguards, robust legal framework, pluralism and sustained efforts to protect disadvantaged com-

munities,” he said.

“While we will respond to the committee’s observations through the established procedure, the inter-ministerial delegation, which was led by the Solicitor General of India, Tushar Mehta, had already rejected the sweeping generalisations, unsubstantiated allegations, or tendency to exceed the Convention’s mandate during the review meeting,” he said.

Thane tribal hostel cook held for molesting 22 girls

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Thane

A 35-year-old cook at a Government-run tribal residential school has been arrested in Thane district of Maharashtra for alleged sexual harassment and molestation of 22 female students, police said on Wednesday.

“The police received a complaint detailing how the accused, Ganpat Gavli, repeatedly subjected girls staying at the Ashram school hostel to inappropriate physical contact and sexual harassment.



“We registered a criminal case under relevant provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita for molestation and the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act, and arrested him,” said Deputy Superintendent of Police (Shahapur) Vishal Nagargoje.

A thorough investigation is underway to determine the extent and duration of the alleged abuse, an official said, adding that victims will receive appropriate counselling and support services.

HAL, Safran join hands to design, develop new-generation helicopter engine Aravalli

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

State-run defence major HAL and a private firm have joined hands to design, develop and manufacture a “new-generation” helicopter engine, according to an official statement issued on Wednesday.

This is the first time that a high-power helicopter engine is being designed and developed in India, it said.

The design and development of ‘Aravalli’ engine is expected to be completed by 2032-33, the statement said.

The ‘Aravalli’ programme marks an important transition from licensed production to joint development of a high-power helicopter engine, giving India an opportunity to build deeper capabilities in critical propulsion technologies, it said.

“Hindustan Aeronautics Limited (HAL) and Safran Helicopter Engines, through their 50:50 joint venture



SAFHAL Helicopter Engines Pvt. Ltd., have signed a contract for the joint design, development, manufacture, supply and lifecycle support of a new-generation 3,500–4,000 shp helicopter engine, named ‘Aravalli,’” the statement said.

The programme will enable HAL to gain expertise and intellectual property in areas of engine design undertaken by HAL, while Indian engineers will work along-

side Safran engineers throughout the development programme.

The ‘Aravalli’ engine will power HAL’s upcoming 13-ton Indian Multi-Role Helicopter (IMRH) and its naval variant, the Deck-Based Multi-Role Helicopter (DBMRH).

IMRH and DBMRH have potential applications beyond military helicopters, including offshore transportation, utility missions and VIP transport, opening avenues

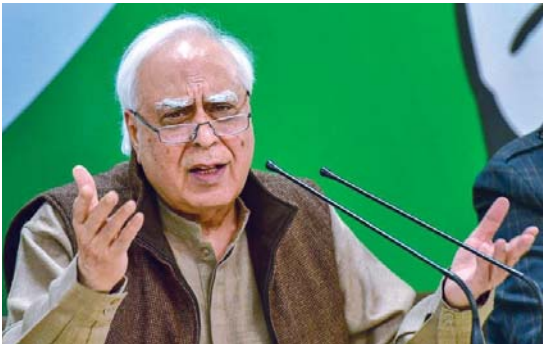
for future civil aerospace opportunities, it said.

The engine will be jointly developed by HAL and Safran Helicopter Engines on a 50:50 basis and will be manufactured by SAFHAL at Tumakuru, Karnataka.

“The programme will provide HAL access to core engine technologies including the high-pressure compressor, power turbine, fuel and oil systems components, accessory gearbox and engine external systems capabilities that are critical for developing future generations of indigenous aero-engines,” it added.

This will provide exposure to international design methodologies, testing practices and certification requirements. The knowledge and experience developed through ‘Aravalli’ can provide a foundation for future indigenous aero-engine development programmes, it said.

States Focus



ONLY PM'S VOICE WILL BE HEARD: SIBAL ON SIMULTANEOUS POLLS

Rajya Sabha MP Kapil Sibal on Wednesday lashed out at the Modi Government over the 'One Nation, One Election' concept, claiming the dreams of people in the states would be lost in the noise of parliamentary polls, with only the "one voice" of the prime minister being heard. Sibal, who is also a senior advocate, said it was unfortunate that the country had a Government that believed in making everything "one", including elections and examinations. "I have a basic problem with this whole concept of everything being different being made into one – one examination for India; one nation, one election; one party deciding what should be sung, what should not be sung; one party deciding what you should eat, what you should not eat," Sibal said at a press conference. (PTI)



GI TAG TO PROTECT IDENTITY OF HIMACHALI PRODUCTS: GOVERNOR

Himachal Pradesh Governor Kavinder Gupta, who on Wednesday met artisans associated with three traditional handicrafts that recently received a Geographical Indication (GI) tag, said the recognition would help protect their unique identity and authenticity. The tag would help the State's traditional products gain recognition in domestic and international markets, and ensure that artisans and communities associated with these crafts get greater economic value for their skills, he said in a statement. Three products of Himachal Pradesh – Ransingha, wood carving and handmade carpets – received the GI tag. The GI registration process was facilitated by the regional office of the NABARD. (PTI)

HN Sharma meets Cabinet Secretary to discuss social development initiatives

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

HN Sharma, former Political Secretary to the late Prime Minister Chandra Shekhar, met Cabinet Secretary TV Somanathan in New Delhi to discuss how the late Prime Minister Chandra Shekhar Trust and associated societies can contribute to the country's social development agenda.

Sharma briefed the Cabinet Secretary on the Trust's proposed and ongoing initiatives in rural development, youth empowerment, skill development and upskilling for employment generation, as well as support for people requiring cancer-related treatment and care. He emphasised strengthening community-level programmes and creating sustainable opportunities for young people, particularly in rural and economically disadvantaged areas.



HN Sharma, Political Advisor to Late Chandrashekhar former Prime Minister of India with Cabinet Secretary TV Somanathan in later office in New Delhi

The discussion covered challenges including unemployment, rural distress and growing stress in urban communities. Sharma stressed the need for a coordinated approach involving the Government, political parties, civil society and other stakeholders to address these concerns. Recalling Chandra Shekhar's legacy, Sharma highlighted

Bad weather aborted Op Sindoor strike on Skardu: Ex-CDS Chauhan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India had planned to hit Pakistan's strategically important Skardu airbase during Operation Sindoor last year, former Chief of Defence Staff (CDS) General Anil Chauhan has revealed. However, the strike could not take place due to bad weather, he added. Incidentally, India had bombed this base in the 1971 war.

The airbase is located nearly 180 kms from Kargil in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (POK), and it used this base to push in infiltrators and soldiers into India during the Kargil war.

General Chauhan, who was the CDS during Operation Sindoor, said the mission to hit Skardu had to be aborted at the eleventh hour due to bad weather. A critical strike at Skardu would not only have dealt a massive blow to Pakistan, but also sent a tough message to China, as the military base provides security cover to the China-Pakistan Economic Corridor.

Giving details, he said Pakistan reached out to India



Former Chief of Defence Staff General Anil Chauhan

at around 10 am on May 10 for talks. It was around this time that the IAF sought clearance to strike the Sargodha air base. "The Air Chief asked me whether we should strike Sargodha. I said, 'Go ahead'. I said, 'Please identify two more targets'. So one of the targets he identified was Skardu," the former CDS said.

"We gave a yes, but after some time, the weather turned bad over it, and they had to change over to Bholari," he further said.

Nevertheless, the IAF's brutal strike on the Bholari air base arguably emerged as the most striking symbol of the May 10 air campaign. Located in Karachi, the Bholari air base, which houses advanced aircraft

like JF-17s and F-16s, suffered significant structural damage. Besides, Pakistan also went on to admit that six personnel were killed in the Bholari attack.

Apart from Bholari, 10 other airbases, including Nur Khan, Rafiqui, Murid, Sargodha, Rahim Yar Khan, and Sukkur, bore the brunt of IAF's BrahMos, SCALP and Rampage missile strikes.

However, the heavily guarded Skardu airfield is a prominent target for India due to its location. It is located in Gilgit-Baltistan, perched along the Indus and is very important for Pakistan due to its proximity to the Line of Control (LoC) and Ladakh. Basically, Skardu is the gateway into Ladakh from

the west. It is around 100 km from India's Leh air base.

Strategically located opposite Kargil, Skardu also functions as the main operating base (MOB) for the Pakistan air force and houses an array of fighter jets and heavy transport aircraft.

There are hardened shelters on both ends of the Skardu runway, which likely house fighter aircraft such as the JF-17 and the Mirage 2000.

Significantly, Skardu is one of the key military bases that provide security and logistics cover to Chinese infrastructure projects being constructed as part of the China-Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC).

Thus, if India had struck Skardu, it would have further added to China's tensions over security concerns surrounding its investments in Pakistan.

While India could not hit Skardu during Operation Sindoor, it had destroyed the air base in the 1971 conflict. While all the focus was on India's east, infiltration attempts from Gilgit and Skardu were also a cause of worry.

BJP slams Rahul over patriarchy comment

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Wednesday criticised Congress leader Rahul Gandhi over his "smash the patriarchy" remark, alleging that he had reduced himself to "memes and reels" and questioning his record on women's empowerment.

The remarks came after Gandhi on Saturday criticised the "Manusmriti mindset" and urged girl students to "smash patriarchy", while also taking a swipe at Prime Minister Narendra Modi over his comment that he was shocked to hear girls using abusive language during the July 2026 protest at Jantar Mantar.

Interacting with girl students at his



BJP leader and MP Bansuri Swaraj

'Chhatron Ki Goonj' outreach programme in Pune, Gandhi, who is also the Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha, said women belonged to themselves and not to their fathers, husbands or sons. He also termed shameful the Manusmriti's prescription that a woman should remain under the authority of male relatives at every stage of her life.

Ever since Gandhi's remarks, the BJP has stepped up its attack on him. Addressing a press conference on Wednesday, senior BJP leader and MP Bansuri Swaraj said Gandhi is attempting to create a "false narrative". She alleged that he has neither a vision nor a positive agenda.

"Rahul Gandhi ji has neither a vision nor any positive agenda. Therefore, whatever his research team writes on a slip of paper and gives him, he uses it to mislead the youth and the country's voters. "This does not befit the Leader of Opposition. It appears that Rahul Gandhi now makes statements only for memes and reel value," she told reporters.

Durga Puja Pandal to be themed after Suvendu

SAUGAR SENGUPTA
■ Kolkata

This year round a Durga Puja committee in Kolkata would set the theme of its Puja mar-quees after Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari, depicting his life, times, politics, struggles and journey to the pinnacle.

Conceived by the Hindu Mahasabha, the theme of the Puja is: "Nandigram Theke Nabanna: Bubair Joyjatra" (Nandigram to Nabanna – secretary – Bubai's journey to victory) and will showcase the Chief Minister's political journey. Adhikari is nicknamed Bubai back home at Contai, a small town in East Midnapore.

Hindu Mahasabha State president Chandrachur Goswami said that the pandal would use models, photographs, flex panels, murals, and traditional Bengali patachitra (motifs), adding that the artworks in the mar-quees would depict Adhikari's journey of life from his childhood till his being the Chief Minister of the State. It would chronicle his "entry into politics, struggles during various political movements," Goswami said, adding that a small portrait of the Chief Minister would be used along with a documentary.

"The entire installation is planned as a visual narrative, combining historical references with aesthetic elements," he said. The Puja will be organised at the Ruby Crossing in South East Kolkata. "Suvendu Adhikari is special to the people



of Bengal because he has brought the region a much desired freedom from the corrupt regime of Mamata Banerjee... he and his father Shishir Adhikari who was also a Union Minister had played a very important role in bringing down the communist regime... without the contribution of the Adhikari family it would not have been possible for Mamata Banerjee to dislodge the Marxists... you all will appreciate his role... his struggle and resistance against Red rule in Nandigram that spread like wild fire in the remaining part of the State... so by that angle he was also responsible for the downfall of the communists in Bengal and restoring the region to its true heritage... it is the least that could have been done to acknowledge his contribution to the State politics," said another organiser.

Karnataka to declare 102 taluks drought-hit after Cabinet review

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

The Karnataka Government will declare 102 taluks drought-hit after reviewing assessment reports at its next Cabinet meeting, Deputy Chief Minister G Parameshwara said on Wednesday.

Speaking to reporters here, he said a comprehensive assessment of the drought situation was underway, and reports from all 102 taluks had been received.

"We will discuss the reports at the next Cabinet meeting and declare the taluks drought-hit. The declaration will be made in accordance with the criteria prescribed by the Centre. We will review the drought situation every week," he said.

Last wish to see justice: Merchant navy family urges UAE to expedite Hussain Shattaf extradition

ASHOKE RAJ
■ New Delhi

Nearly two decades after the murder of retired Merchant Navy captain Manmohan Singh Viridi in Lonavala in 2006. FIR number 46 of 2006 was registered at Lonavala City Police Station. The matter is now pending before the Sessions Court at Wadgaon Maval, Pune, as Sessions Case number 5 of 2024.

The appeal comes days after the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said the UAE had sought "some more documentation" in response to India's extradition request and that New Delhi was working to provide the additional material.

Retired Captain Manjit Singh Viridi, the victim's brother and original complainant, has urged the UAE mission to coordinate with Indian authorities and the Prime Minister's Office to speed up the process and bring Shattaf back to India to face trial.

Murder case pending since 2006

The case relates to the murder of Captain Manmohan Singh Viridi in Lonavala in 2006. FIR number 46 of 2006 was registered at Lonavala City Police Station. The matter is now pending before the Sessions Court at Wadgaon Maval, Pune, as Sessions Case number 5 of 2024.

The family says the trial has remained stalled because Shattaf has not appeared before the court and continues to remain outside India. In a representation to the UAE mission, Manjit Singh Viridi said the accused's prolonged absence had caused "immense hardship to the victim's family" and undermined the administration of criminal justice.

The representation also raises concerns about Shattaf's immigration status and alleged criminal record. According to the victim's

family, the passport associated with the accused expired in 2021, and he has been residing in the UAE since then. The family has further referred to an Interpol notice and alleged that Shattaf is wanted in connection with the murder case and other criminal matters.

These allegations have been made by the victim's family and could not independently be verified from the material available.

For the family, the issue is no longer simply about completing extradition paperwork. It is also about ending what they describe as nearly two decades of uncertainty and suffering. The victim's brother has appealed to the UAE authorities to assist in bringing Shattaf to India so that the case can proceed before the competent court and reach its legal conclusion.

Supreme Court restored murder trial



The case took a significant turn in 2023 when the Supreme Court restored the murder trial.

In its May 18, 2023 order in Criminal Appeal number 1399 of 2023, the apex court set aside the Bombay High Court's order discharging the accused and restored the proceedings.

The family has since continued to seek Shattaf's return to India so that the trial can proceed before the competent court.

The representation also refers to a November 20,

2025 Bombay High Court order, which recorded that Maharashtra's Home Department had forwarded an extradition proposal to the Ministry of Home Affairs on October 31, 2025.

UAE seeks additional documents

The extradition process has now moved into a documentation stage.

On August 4, MEA spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal confirmed that India's extradition request had been sent to the UAE and that the UAE side

had sought additional documents.

"That specific extradition request was sent to the UAE side. They've asked for some more documentation in that regard, and we are working on this particular matter," Jaiswal said.

The latest development has prompted the victim's family to approach the UAE Mission directly, seeking its cooperation in completing the legal process and expediting Shattaf's return to India.

Family seeks UAE intervention. According to the representation submitted by the family, Shattaf's passport has reportedly been expired since 2021. The family further alleges that he is wanted by Interpol in connection with the murder and other criminal cases and has been residing illegally in the UAE since 2021.

In view of these allegations, the family has requested the UAE authorities to extend their cooperation and

take necessary legal steps, in accordance with applicable law, to facilitate his extradition and return to India.

The accused, who the representation says is also known as Hussain Mehboob Khokawala, faces the murder case as well as separate cases relating to forgery, criminal breach of trust and allegedly obtaining a passport under false details.

The family has also referred to a Look Out Circular against the accused, which it says was recorded by the Bombay High Court.

'Last wish to see justice done'

Manjit Singh Viridi, who describes himself as a senior citizen, said he has continued to pursue the case despite his age and health-related difficulties.

"I am a senior citizen suffering from various age- and health-related issues. It is my last wish to see justice done in the matter of the murder of my deceased

brother," he wrote in the representation.

He urged the UAE mission to coordinate with the Indian Government and take appropriate steps to facilitate Shattaf's extradition "in accordance with law", so that he can be produced before the competent court in India.

For the Viridi family, the latest request for additional documents represents another stage in a legal battle that has stretched across nearly two decades. With the Supreme Court having restored the trial and India's extradition request now under consideration by the UAE, the family is seeking a faster resolution.

Their appeal is ultimately a plea to end a long wait for justice.

"We request the UAE to help us bring him back and stop our suffering," the family has said, urging the authorities to facilitate the process within the framework of law.

Maharashtra cancels MPSC recruitment exam over paper leak

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The Maharashtra Public Service Commission (MPSC) has cancelled the recruitment process for Drug Inspector Group-B posts under the Food and Drug Administration Department following a preliminary inquiry into alleged malpractice in the screening examination conducted earlier this year.

The commission on Tuesday decided to conduct a fresh examination for the posts, saying the step was necessary to ensure that all candidates get a fair and equal opportunity, and to maintain the confidence of candidates in the recruitment process by safeguarding the integrity, transparency and impartiality of its examinations.

Cancellation of the process means that even candidates who had cleared the screening examination and subsequently appeared for interviews will have

to take the fresh examination. Of the total, 485 candidates were eligible for appointment to the posts.

The decision comes after the MPSC received complaints regarding alleged irregularities in the screening examination held on March 22 this year.

The complaints claimed that some candidates had received the question paper or questions before the examination and that the material was subsequently circulated through social media and other electronic platforms, the commission said in its statement.

The recruitment process had been initiated through an advertisement issued on July 29, 2025. The screening examination was conducted offline at six divisional headquarters across Maharashtra on March 22 this year. The result of the examination was declared on June 12, after which 506 candidates were found eligible for the



interview stage, it said.

Of these, 488 candidates appeared for interviews conducted between July 1 and 22. After completion of the interviews, the MPSC published a provisional general merit list comprising 488 candidates, including 485 candidates found eligible for appointment and three declared ineligible, the MPSC said in its statement.

However, complaints concerning the conduct of the screening

examination were received by the commission between July 22 and 26 through e-mail from some candidates as well as public representatives.

According to the complaints, some candidates had allegedly received the question paper or questions before the examination. It was also alleged that the question material had been made available through social media and other electronic means.

Taking note of the seriousness

and sensitivity of the allegations, the MPSC approached the Mumbai Police Commissioner on July 27 and requested an inquiry into the complaints.

A preliminary inquiry was subsequently conducted by the Crime Investigation Branch of the Mumbai Police. The Deputy Commissioner of Police, Crime Investigation Branch, submitted the preliminary inquiry report to the commission.

According to the findings mentioned in the MPSC's statement, the police inquiry prima facie indicated that one candidate had received the question set before the examination and had benefited from it. The commission said it had taken into consideration the seriousness of the findings before deciding to cancel the recruitment process.

The MPSC said the decision was aimed at protecting the credibility of the examination system and ensuring that all candidates get a fair and equal

opportunity. It also stressed the need to preserve the confidentiality and integrity of examinations conducted by the commission, it said.

The cancellation means that even candidates who had cleared the screening examination and subsequently appeared for interviews will have to take the fresh examination. The commission, however, has provided relief to the candidates on the administrative front.

Candidates who were eligible to appear for the fresh examination will not have to submit applications again. No examination fee will be charged for the re-examination, the commission said.

The date and detailed schedule for the fresh examination will be announced separately through a subsequent notification.

The commission's decision effectively nullifies the recruitment process initiated under advertisement number 116/2025, including the screening examina-

tion, result and subsequent interview process. The move comes after the recruitment had progressed substantially, with hundreds of candidates having cleared the screening stage and nearly 500 appearing for interviews.

The commission said cancelling the process at this stage was necessary in view of the preliminary findings and the overriding requirement to ensure fairness and public confidence in its recruitment examinations.

Meanwhile, Maharashtra Navnirman Sena (MNS) leader Sandeep Deshpande questioned the State Government over the alleged paper leak.

"When the Government knew that the paper got leaked, why was an FIR not registered in this case immediately?" he asked.

It is believed that a coaching class owner from Nandurbar (in North Maharashtra) was behind the paper leak. He was sent a notice but not arrested. He later fled, Deshpande claimed.

Himachal Pradesh: Congress, BJP face motions over national anthem row

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Shimla

The row over alleged insult to the national anthem flared up in the Himachal Pradesh Assembly again on Wednesday, with both the ruling Congress and the Opposition BJP announcing that they would move breach of privilege motions against each other.

Amid conflicting claims from both parties, the House briefly witnessed uproarious scenes and commotion, with both sides sloganeering against one another.

The controversy surrounds the Congress' claim that the BJP had insulted the national anthem Jana Gana Mana on the first day of the Monsoon Session of the Assembly on Friday. When Jana Gana Mana was being sung, BJP MLA Vipin Parmar raised his hand before it concluded to demand that the national song Vande Mataram be sung after it, the Congress had claimed.



Himachal Assembly

FILE PHOTO

opposition. He alleged that despite this, the ruling party staged protests against the BJP not only within the Assembly complex but also across the state.

Thakur further announced that the BJP would move a breach of privilege motion against the chief minister over this falsehood and would file a criminal defamation suit in the Himachal Pradesh High Court.

However, Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu reiterated his allegation, stating that raising questions about the national anthem itself constitutes an insult to it.

Amid the commotion, Speaker Kuldeep Singh Pathania clarified that any remarks made by the chief minister outside the House do not form part of the official record.

Sukhu reiterated that the BJP has insulted the national anthem and the Congress would inform people in every corner of the State about this disrespect.

He too announced that the Congress would bring a breach of privilege motion against the BJP leaders.

The chief minister further

demanding an apology from the BJP for attempting to create a divide among people in the name of the national anthem and the national song. He remarked that while India's culture is rooted in humanity, the BJP's culture has always been one of division.

Pointing out that the national anthem and national song were integral to the Congress ideology even before Independence, Sukhu said the Government would forgive the BJP if it apologises to the people for insulting the national anthem.

On the issue, Revenue Minister Jagat Singh Negi said Parmar had raised his hand before the national anthem concluded on the first day of the session, but since the camera was not focused on him, he is taking advantage of the situation.

Claiming that the BJP had insulted the national anthem, Negi questioned how the party could approach the high court after such an act. He remarked that the people of the state have realised that the BJP respects neither the Constitution nor the rules of the Legislative Assembly.

UGC-NET results to be announced this week: NTA

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The results for 84 subjects of UGC-NET will be announced this week, the National Testing Agency (NTA) said on Wednesday.

"The final answer keys and results for UGC-NET (84 Subjects), CSIR-NET and ICAR AIEEA (PG) and AICE (PhD) 2026 will be published on NTA's website this week. Candidates are advised to rely only on official communications from NTA," the agency said in a post on social media. The NTA had ordered fresh examinations



for candidates who appeared for the English, Commerce and Sociology papers in June this year after an expert committee found factual, typographical, translation and language-related

errors in the question papers.

The NTA released the UGC-NET answer key on August 16, nearly two months after the examination, while issuing a special notice concerning the Sociology, Commerce

and English papers.

Later, on the same day, it announced that the three examinations would be conducted afresh in September, citing the errors.

The re-examinations are scheduled for September 9 and 10, and candidates will not be required to pay an additional examination fee.

The National Eligibility Test (NET) is conducted by the NTA to determine the eligibility of Indian nationals for the role of assistant professor and for the junior research fellowship (JRF) in Indian universities and colleges.

Shivakumar promises woman minister soon

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

Karnataka Chief Minister DK Shivakumar on Wednesday said B Nagendra was inducted into his Cabinet after an official report found that he was not involved in the alleged role in the Valmiki Corporation scam. He also said his Government will induct a woman minister in the next couple of days.

On the Cauvery water issue, the CM said he would honour the Supreme Court's direction.

Defending Nagendra over the allegation of his involvement in ₹89 crore Karnataka Maharshi Valmiki Scheduled Tribes Development Corporation scam, Shivakumar said Nagendra had earlier resigned after discussions within the Government and was later inducted into the Cabinet after an official report found that he was

not involved in it. "It was not Nagendra who did it," he claimed, adding that 95 per cent of the money was recovered during the investigation.

On women's representation in the Cabinet, Shivakumar said, "We will have a woman minister. Definitely we'll have. The Congress Party is committed to the ideology (of women's empowerment)."

Shivakumar carried out the Cabinet expansion on August 3, two months after he became the CM. He inducted 19 ministers though the Congress had announced the names of 20 ministers, including a woman MLC Gayathri Shanthegowda, but her name was omitted at the last minute.

"There was a name which was being cleared, but ultimately some issue was there," he said during an interaction at the India



Today Roundtable. "I think in the next couple of days a woman minister will be inducted," the CM said.

Currently, there are 33 ministers in the Shivakumar Government against the sanctioned ministerial posts of 34. The lone vacancy is said to be to accommodate a woman minister.

Shivakumar, who described himself as a "man in a hurry", said he was

determined to deliver good governance during the remaining period before the next Assembly election and set an example for the Congress across the country.

Responding to questions about pressure from MLAs seeking ministerial berths and posts in various boards, the CM said there was no problem in accommodating aspirations within the party.

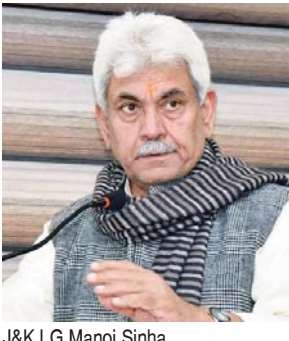
Advanced healthcare must become a right, not a privilege, says J&K LG

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Srinagar

Jammu and Kashmir Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha on Wednesday stressed that advanced healthcare must become a right and not a privilege, saying it should no longer remain a luxury confined to metropolitan cities.

The Lieutenant Governor addressed the Quaternary Healthcare and Research Summit at the SKICC in Srinagar.

Sinha emphasised that the summit marks a turning point in Jammu and Kashmir and India's healthcare journey, where the Union Territory and the nation must move beyond tertiary care and embrace quaternary-level treatment and research to ensure equal access for all citizens.



J&K LG Manoj Sinha

care available in small district hospitals and the healthcare actually required.

The LG stressed that bridging this gap is a national priority.

The Lieutenant Governor highlighted India's remarkable progress under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

Free treatment for more than 56 crore citizens surpassed the combined population of the US, France, Italy and the UK, he said, adding that annual vaccination campaigns in the country covering seven crore children equal the population of the UK.

He said even e-Sanjeevani telemedicine providing care to 37 crore people annually exceeded the population of the US.

Sukhu orders removal of caste column from school admission forms

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Shimla

Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu on Wednesday ordered that the caste column be removed from admission forms in schools from the next academic session.

He issued the direction while chairing the meeting of the Himachal Pradesh Scheduled Caste Welfare Board (HPCSWB) here.

Sukhu said his Government is committed to eliminating caste-based discrimination in society and promoting fraternity and equality, and the removal of the caste column would be a step in this direction.

Six killed in road accident in Telangana

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Hyderabad

Six persons, including five women, died and at least 12 others were injured when a private EV bus they were travelling in hit a truck in Suryapet district of Telangana on Wednesday morning, police said.

The incident occurred in Kodad mandal on the Hyderabad-Vijayawada national highway at around 5.15 am when the private travel bus, carrying 42 passengers, proceeding to Eluru in Andhra Pradesh from Hyderabad, rammed the truck from the rear side, they said based on preliminary investigation.



"Six persons, including five women, died in the accident. At least 12 others were injured and shifted to different hospitals," a police official said.

Suryapet District Superintendent of Police K Narasimha told reporters that the truck was carrying heavy pillars used for industrial purposes.

As the bus hit the truck, the chain tied to secure the



Himachal Pradesh Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu speaks during the Monsoon session of the state Legislative Assembly in Shimla, Himachal Pradesh on Wednesday

PTI

nate their benefits so that more people could avail them. He said that under the Rajiv Gandhi Start-up

pillars got snapped, and they hit the right side of the bus. This led to the deaths of those seated in the front, he said.

The condition of two injured persons was serious, and they were rushed to a hospital in Vijayawada in Andhra Pradesh, the SP said.

Telangana Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy expressed condolences over the death of the persons in the accident.

He conveyed his sympathies to the bereaved families. He directed the Chief Secretary to take necessary measures to provide advanced medical care to those injured, an official release said.

Swarozgar Saur Yojana, the State Government has been providing subsidies for setting up projects ranging

Andhra adopts 4-pillar strategy to fight El Niño kharif impact

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Amaravati

Andhra Pradesh Agriculture Department on Wednesday said the state had adopted a four-pillar strategy to mitigate the impact of El Niño on Kharif 2026, focusing on water management, climate-resilient farming, allied activities and crop insurance.

Agriculture and allied activities support 62 per cent of the State's population, while foodgrain production in 2025-26 was estimated at a record 237 lakh MT, the department said.



It added that protecting the sector from the impact of El Niño was a top priority.

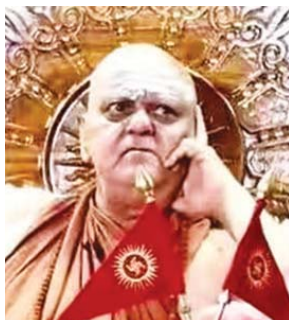
"We have adopted a risk-differentiated, four-pillar strategy to mitigate the impact of El Niño on Kharif 2026, focusing on water

management, climate-resilient farming, protection of allied sectors and crop insurance," the department said in a press release.

El Niño can result in a weaker, delayed or irregular monsoon, affecting rain-dependent Kharif crops, the department said.

The National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration's Climate Prediction Centre formally declared the onset of El Niño on June 11, while the IRI model ensemble indicated a high probability that the event could be as strong as the 1997-98 El Niño.

Puri seer demands ban on film on Lord Jagannath



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Puri

Puri Shankaracharya Swami Nischalananda Saraswati has demanded a complete ban on the animated film 'Mahaprabhu Jagannath', scheduled for release on August 28.

Saraswati, who is also the permanent chairman of the Mukti Mandap Pandit Sabha of the 12th-century Shree Jagannath Temple in Puri, wrote to Gajapati Maharaja Dibyasingha Deb, chairperson of the Shree Jagannath Temple Managing Committee (SJTMC), in this regard on Monday.

The letter was shared with the media on Wednesday.

"There is a need for a complete ban on releasing films containing distorted (cartoon) forms of Lord Jagannath and other deities and inauthentic 'Leela' characters through any medium," the Puri seer said in the letter.

The Mukti Mandap Pandit Sabha, the highest religious body of the Shree Jagannath Temple, has also sought a complete ban on the film.

It wrote a separate letter to Deb on August 25.



Editor's
TAKE

India-China: A thaw without a breakthrough

Twenty-five rounds of India-China boundary talks have produced an important thaw in relations, but little movement on the boundary itself

The 25th round of India-China Special Representative talks unfolded in Beijing on August 25, with National Security Adviser Ajit Doval and Foreign Minister Wang Yi holding what both readouts called candid, in-depth discussions on the boundary question. Doval called on Vice-President Han Zheng beforehand; Wang spoke of deepening trust and removing "disturbances." The timing was deliberate: Prime Minister Modi and President Xi Jinping are due to meet twice in three weeks, first at the SCO summit in Bishkek, then at the BRICS summit New Delhi hosts on September 12-13.

The headway is real but narrower than the mood music suggests. Since the 2020 Galwan clash, the October 2024 disengagement restored patrolling and grazing at Depsang and Demchok; the Kailash Mansarovar Yatra, tourist visas and direct flights have all resumed over the past year. Yet this round's statement quietly dropped "early harvest", the phrase floated last year for quick delimitation wins, reverting instead to the older, slower pursuit of a "package solution."

Twenty-five rounds since 2003 have moved the atmosphere considerably; they have not moved the line itself. What blocks that is visible on the ground, not in the readouts. China has issued six batches of "standardised" Arunachal Pradesh place names since 2017, the latest in April; India's own counter-naming of border sites this August drew a sharp Chinese protest. More seriously, patrol parties reportedly came face to face near Taksing in Upper Subansiri in late July, with Chinese personnel said to have returned in early August and pitched tents - a claim India's defence establishment has called unverified even as the opposition demands answers.

Add Beijing's mega dam on the Yarlung Tsangpo, barely kilometres from the Arunachal border and already unsettling downstream water calculations, and it is clear India is negotiating trust with a neighbour simultaneously redrawing the map, the river and the patrol grid.

Xi's Delhi visit, still unconfirmed by Beijing even now, would be his first to India in seven years, reportedly with some 400 officials in tow. The summit's own agenda - local-currency trade, food and energy security, reform of multilateral institutions - will occupy the formal sessions. But the meeting the region will actually watch is the Modi-Xi sidebar: warmer bilateral language and movement on trade and connectivity, not a breakthrough on delimitation. That was never a summit's job to deliver.

India's task is to stop letting summit atmospherics and border facts stand in for each other. Engagement is worth having, but it should not outrun verification: patrolling parity and troop de-escalation to pre-2020 levels belong ahead of warmer language, not after it. New Delhi must match Beijing's infrastructure push, village for village and road for road, with its Siang project as a counterweight to the dam. It must also get faster and clearer about what is confirmed on the border. Xi is welcome in Delhi, though the outcome may not be dramatic, but it is an opportunity to put across our deepest concerns.

Goa: India's compass for coastal tourism

The challenge is no longer simply to draw tourists to India's shores, but to ensure that tourism does not destroy the very coastline that attracts them. If India's coastal tourism is to grow sustainably, Goa's experience with carrying capacity, conservation, and ensuring that local communities share the gains offers valuable lessons for the rest of the country



SADANAND
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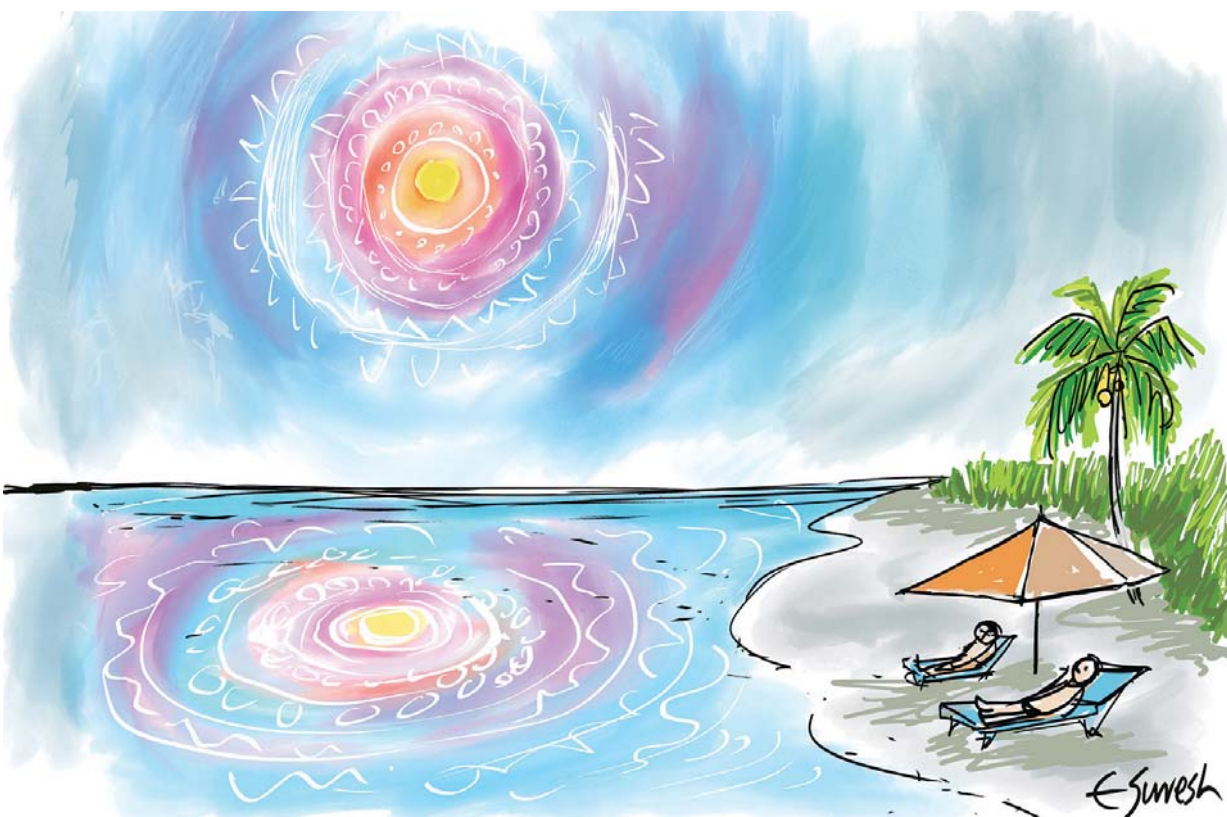
ANUJ
PATTNAYAK

India has one of the world's longest coastlines, and until recently, one of its least precisely measured. When the coast was remapped in 2024, it grew from 7,516 km to over 11,000 km - not because any land was added, but because finer, modern mapping captured the bays, inlets and offshore islands that older, smaller-scale charts had smoothed over. It was a quiet reminder of how much of our coast we are only beginning to see clearly, even as it carries a growing share of the nation's tourism economy.

Nowhere is that economy more visible than in Goa. Last year, the state welcomed close to 1.08 crore visitors - several times its resident population - along a beach coastline of barely 105 km. Tourism accounts for more than a sixth of Goa's economy and a third of its jobs. More than the numbers, though, what sets Goa apart is experience: few places in India have managed tourism at this intensity for as long or learnt as much in the process.

That experience is worth drawing on, because India is not short of policy for its coast. The Coastal Regulation Zone rules protect fragile stretches; Swadesh Darshan 2.0 funds coastal circuits; the Blue Flag programme certifies clean beaches; Travel for LIFE promotes responsible travel; and Goa has both its own tourism policy and, more recently, a regenerative tourism vision built around people, environment and economy. The pieces exist. What they have lacked is a way of working together as a single, coherent approach to coastal tourism - and this is precisely where a state like Goa, already doing much of this at once, can show what joining them up looks like.

Bringing them together starts with a fuller idea of what a coast can bear. Carrying capacity is too often reduced to a single question - how many visitors a beach can hold - when it is really about water and sanitation, waste and traffic, the health of dunes and mangroves, and, not least, the daily lives of the people who live there. A beach that overwhelms its town's water supply or its roads is not a success, however many visitors it draws. Goa has begun to take this seriously, commissioning a fresh scientific study of how many visitors its coast can sustainably support, while moving to expand sewerage



LAST YEAR THE STATE WELCOMED CLOSE TO 1.08 CRORE VISITORS - SEVERAL TIMES ITS RESIDENT POPULATION - ALONG A BEACH COASTLINE OF BARELY 105 KM. TOURISM ACCOUNTS FOR MORE THAN A SIXTH OF GOA'S ECONOMY AND A THIRD OF ITS JOBS

The writers are Member of Parliament (Rajya Sabha) from Goa and Anuj Pattanayak, a public policy professional at Chase Advisors

and waste networks and strengthen the mangroves that shield the shore.

It also means treating different stretches of coast differently.

Nesting grounds, dunes and mangroves call for careful protection, while others are well suited to livelier activity - the logic already embedded in India's coastal zone plans, and demonstrated at scale by Australia's stewardship of the Great Barrier Reef, where clearly defined and periodically reviewed zones allow protection and tourism to reinforce one another. With rising seas and steady erosion already claiming hundreds of hectares of Indian coastland each year, that same foresight must extend to resilience: restoring mangroves, managing shorelines and building for the storms to come.

Above all, coastal tourism must keep local communities at its heart. A coastline is not only an ecological asset but a home and a livelihood - for shack owners, fishers, taxi operators, guides and family-run guesthouses. Goa's regulated beach-shack policy, which reserves space for local operators, and its women-led homestay scheme, which spreads tourism's gains into the hinterland, both show how growth can be shared rather than concentrated.

Tourism is only truly sustainable when the Goans who give the coast its character con-

tinue to prosper from it and can live comfortably alongside it.

Much of this comes down to planning for a simple reality: the effective population of a tourist town can multiply many times over at the height of the season. Infrastructure that serves residents well through the year must also be able to absorb those surges - as Goa's lifeguard service has shown, using technology to cut drowning incidents sharply while keeping its beaches open and safe. And where the coast generates the revenue, a fair share of that value should flow back into maintaining and protecting it, guided by the kind of recognised standards - India's own Blue Flag and clean-beach certifications among them - that turn good intentions into measurable practice.

The stakes reach well beyond any one state. India's tourism economy is expected to approach USD 527 billion by 2036, and much of that growth will come from the coast. Whether it lasts will depend less on how many visitors our shores can attract than on how well they are cared for - on treating the coastline not as an inexhaustible backdrop, but as a national asset to be measured, planned and protected. Goa has already learnt much of what that takes. Given the chance, it can help show the rest of India's coast how to grow without wearing itself out.

PIC TALK



Devotees walk near an 'athapookalam', a traditional floral carpet, during the 'Onam' festival, in Thiruvananthapuram

PHOTO: PTI



SIDDHARTH
ROY

2ND OPINION

A broken mixer once meant a visit to the neighbourhood repairman. A torn shirt went to the tailor, a watch to the watchmaker, and a damaged chair to the carpenter. Today, the instinct is often different: search for a replacement online. The convenience is undeniable, but something significant is being lost - the habit of repair.

Modern consumer culture has made replacement economically and psychologically attractive. Products are cheaper, fashions change faster, and technology evolves. Many devices are difficult to open, batteries are sealed, and spare parts can be expensive. In such a marketplace, repairing can appear irrational when a new one promises immediate satisfaction.

Yet the apparent efficiency of replacement hides its

costs. Every new product embodies minerals, energy, water and manufacturing. When discarded prematurely, these resources do not disappear; they become waste. Electronic waste is revealing. The world consumes sophisticated devices rapidly while struggling to recover valuable materials. It reflects a bigger change in how value is understood.

Repair demands patience. It requires accepting that something can be imperfect and still worth preserving. It recognises skilled labour. The electrician, cobbler, mechanic and carpenter were once familiar figures in Indian neighbourhoods because extending an object's life was considered sensible.

India's rapid economic transformation has weakened this repair culture. A growing middle class, rising purchasing power and digital commerce have made consumption easier than ever. The traditional repair ecosystem is also under pressure. The irony is that a country with a long history of thrift and ingenuity is increasingly embracing disposability.

The consequences extend beyond possessions. A culture accustomed to replacing things can subtly influence attitudes towards other forms of commitment. Not every relationship, institution or career can or should be preserved indefinitely. Some must end when harmful or obsolete. But there is a difference between recognising genuine failure and abandoning something simply because repair requires effort.

Sustainability, therefore, cannot be reduced to recy-

cling after consumption. It must also involve designing products for durability, ensuring access to spare parts, supporting repair businesses and making manufacturers accountable for the life of what they sell. The right-to-repair movement matters because it challenges an economic model built around replacement.

But policy alone cannot restore the value of repair. Consumers must recover a different relationship with possessions. Before asking what something costs to replace, we should occasionally ask what it would take to restore it.

That question has implications far beyond household economics. Repair is an ethic of patience, responsibility and stewardship. It acknowledges that value does not disappear merely because something is damaged.

Perhaps that is the lesson modern consumer society most needs. Progress should not mean acquiring the newest thing as quickly as possible. A mature economy should also know how to preserve what already exists.

A civilisation that remembers how to repair its objects may also become better at repairing its institutions, communities and public spaces. Sometimes, what needs saving is not the object itself, but our willingness to care for it.

The writer is a consultant to Rashtriya Raksha University under the Ministry of Home Affairs, a short story writer, columnist and contemporary affairs commentator

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CRICKETERS APPEAL FOR HUMANE TREATMENT OF IMRAN KHAN

Former international cricket captains, including Kapil Dev, Sunil Gavaskar and Dilip Vengsarkar, have reportedly written to Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif, urging humane treatment and proper medical care for former Pakistan cricket captain and Prime Minister Imran Khan, who remains in jail.

The all-rounder who united a nation by winning the 1992 Cricket World Cup and inspired a generation of players worldwide has reportedly been facing deteriorating health in confinement. It therefore becomes a moral duty for his peers to speak up. The signatories have rightly emphasised that court-mandated medical reviews and family-visit protocols must be honoured transparently and without administrative delay.

One hopes that the authorities

in Islamabad will listen to these voices of conscience and ensure that Imran Khan receives the medical attention and dignity he deserves. Regardless of political differences, the humane treatment of a former national leader and sporting icon should remain above partisan considerations.

Treating national figures with dignity reflects the strength and maturity of a democratic society. The appeal by these former cricketers also reminds us that true sportsmanship extends far beyond boundary lines and final wickets. At a time when sport and public life often intersect, their intervention reinforces a simple principle: compassion, dignity and fairness should never be compromised, particularly when a person's health and well-being are at stake.

R SIVAKUMAR | TAMIL NADU

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

RANGANATHAN SIVAKUMAR | CHENNAI

YUGAL KISHORE SHARMA | FARIDABAD

BHAGWAN THADANI | MUMBAI

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

A short-sighted move by TVK govt

The ruling TVK government's decision to scrap the Parandur greenfield airport project is a short-sighted move that threatens the State's economic and aviation future. Dropping this vital infrastructure project without announcing a proper and ready-to-execute alternative site is a grave administrative failure in the first place. Chennai desperately needs a second airport to handle rising passenger and cargo traffic, and halting this project without a back-up plan puts the State's logistical growth behind by years.

If the TVK government relies on expansions or a proposed Terminal 5 at the current Meenambakkam airport, it is totally an unrealistic thought, since the existing facility is already landlocked by dense residential areas and faces severe structural limitations. Mortgaging the State's long-term economic roadmap for short-term political gains sets a dangerous precedent.Finally, the TVK govt's policy presents a glaring contradiction; it initially claimed to scrap the project to protect agricultural land and farmers. However, it has now announced that the Parandur land will be used for alternative industrial growth. This flip-flop exposes a lack of real care for farmers and deepens the confusion for local landowners.

Investigate sugar hoarding and black marketing

This refers to the news, "Sugar prices surge 15.6 per cent in a month; political row over ethanol policy deepens." The CPI(M) has blamed the Modi government's ethanol policy for the price rise, claiming that approximately 25 lakh tonnes of sugarcane were diverted for ethanol production, resulting in a shortage of sugar stocks. On the other hand, Neeraj Shirgaokar, President of the Indian Sugar Mills Association, stated that there is no shortage of sugar in the country and that retail prices are likely to come down soon. He attributed the decline in sugar production to speculative buying and adverse weather conditions, while stating that sugar mills were not involved in creating artificial shortages or raising ex-mill sugar prices.

Who, then, is behind the alleged black marketing? The Centre and state governments should investigate. The Modi government has permitted duty-free imports of 10 lakh metric tonnes of raw sugar and introduced stock limits to curb hoarding.

The Uttar Pradesh government has intensified inspections of sugar mills and traders' warehouses. Delhi, Haryana, Uttar Pradesh and Rajasthan must expand surveillance of dealers, wholesalers and large consumers to prevent artificial shortages. Only then can consumers find lasting relief.

RSS chief faces US opposition

RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat, currently in New York on the first leg of a three-nation global outreach tour marking the Sangh's centenary, has faced strong opposition to his visit. He is also scheduled to visit Canada and the UK. More than 1,000 Americans have reportedly urged the US to revoke his visa, while appeals have been made to New York Mayor Zohran Mamdani to cancel Bhagwat's August 29 rally at Madison Square Garden.

Several Indian-American organisations, including the Indian American Muslim Council, Hindus for Human Rights and the Indian Overseas Congress, USA, have urged US policymakers and community leaders to examine the RSS's record concerning religious minorities. The US Commission on International Religious Freedom, in its 2026 annual report, recommended targeted sanctions against the RSS, including freezing US-based assets and restricting entry for responsible individuals. Critics have alleged the RSS has been linked to violence and intolerance against minorities. They cite concerns involving Muslims, Christians, Dalits and Adivasis, including communal polarisation, attacks on places of worship and discrimination. Bhagwat's visit has therefore triggered a wider debate over representation, religious freedom and the legitimacy given to organisations facing such serious allegations.

India needs institutional reform – now!

India must reform its institutions before accumulated frustration turns into a crisis that will be far more difficult and costly to control. The time for complacency is over; the time for systemic reform is now an urgency for the nation



India is witnessing an institutional crisis that can no longer be dismissed as isolated corruption, administrative inefficiency or the occasional failure of an individual officer. Millions of ordinary Indians interact every day with hospitals, police stations, courts, schools, municipal corporations, revenue offices and administrative authorities. For

the common citizen, the State is not an abstract constitutional concept. It is the police station where a complaint must be registered, the government hospital where treatment is expected, the court where justice is sought, the school where children are educated, the municipal corporation responsible for basic services and the government office where a simple document may require repeated visits. For millions, these everyday interactions have increasingly become sources of frustration, humiliation, delay and extraordinary mental stress.

The scale of the problem is almost unimaginable. Nearly one-fifth of humanity lives in India, and when such a vast population is subjected to inefficient institutions, procedural delays, corruption, arbitrary decision-making and administrative indifference, the consequences extend far beyond individual grievances. They gradually damage the social fabric of the nation. A citizen who spends years pursuing justice, repeatedly visits government offices for legitimate services, encounters corruption in routine transactions or faces arbitrary action by an authority begins to lose faith not only in that institution but in the State itself.

India's political discourse, however, remains overwhelmingly focused on elections. Political parties devote enormous energy to winning power, managing constituencies, defeating opponents and controlling political narratives. Governments are judged largely through electoral victories, announcements, infrastructure projects and welfare programmes. Yet the most fundamental question is rarely asked with sufficient seriousness: How does an ordinary citizen experience the State every day?

Does a police station deliver timely and impartial justice? Can an ordinary citizen approach the courts without spending years and enormous sums of money? Can the administrative machinery provide services without corruption, favouritism and unnecessary delays? Can municipal corporations deliver basic civic services efficiently? Can government hospitals and schools provide quality services with accountability? These are not ideological questions. They are questions about the functioning and credibility of the Republic.

The crisis becomes even more serious when taxation is considered. Citizens are expected to pay direct and indirect taxes, yet many increasingly feel that the State possesses enormous power to scrutinise, penalise and recover taxes while providing inadequate accountability for how public money is collected and spent. Excessive compliance burdens, aggressive enforcement and disproportionate proceedings can create a perception of tax terrorism, particularly among honest taxpayers, entrepreneurs and small businesses. Tax collection is essential for a modern State, but taxation must operate within fairness, transparency, predictability and due process. The citizen cannot be treated merely as a source of revenue.

India now requires an extremely stringent and comprehensive anti-corruption framework applicable without exception to every person drawing a salary, remuneration or pension from the public exchequer. From the President of India and ministers to senior bureaucrats, judges, police officers, public-sector employees and the last-mile government employee, no public servant should be above accountability. A proposed framework could provide severe imprisonment, potentially extending to 20 years in the gravest proven cases of corruption, embezzlement, bribery or deliberate misuse of public funds, along with recovery of illicitly acquired assets, subject to due process and judicial determination.

This reform is essential if India genuinely intends to become a global power. India cannot seriously aspire to challenge the United States or China while operating a government machinery weighed down by mediocrity, inefficiency, excessive bureaucracy, corruption and weak accountability. A nation cannot become a superpower merely through international speeches, impressive statistics, media campaigns, podcasts or chest-thumping



IT IS HIGH TIME THAT THE INDIAN STATE RESTORES THE BASIC MEANING OF PUBLIC SERVICE. CITIZENS SHOULD RECEIVE RELIABLE DRINKING WATER FROM JAL BOARDS RATHER THAN DEPENDING ON MINERAL-WATER VENDORS; DEPENDABLE ELECTRICITY FROM ELECTRICITY DISTRIBUTION AUTHORITIES RATHER THAN GENERATORS AND INVERTERS; REGULAR GARBAGE COLLECTION FROM MUNICIPAL CORPORATIONS RATHER THAN PRIVATE VENDORS; AND PUBLIC SECURITY FROM ACCOUNTABLE POLICE STATIONS RATHER THAN PRIVATE GUARDS STANDING OUTSIDE HOMES IN ALMOST EVERY AFFLUENT COLONY ACROSS INDIA

The writer is a public policy expert and columnist

nationalism. Great nations are built by competent institutions and millions of honest, capable and professionally accountable people performing their responsibilities every day.

There is another emerging vulnerability that the ruling establishment cannot afford to ignore. In an era of largely unregulated social media, a spark can travel across an entire country within hours. Traditional mainstream media, once the principal instrument for shaping public narratives and communicating during national crises, has lost much of its influence among large sections of the younger and digitally connected population. Consequently, the government's ability to communicate directly and effectively during a rapidly developing crisis is becoming increasingly limited.

Social-media algorithms determine what millions of people see, share and discuss, often rewarding outrage, sensationalism and emotional content. While it would be simplistic to claim that algorithms are universally controlled by external forces, the possibility of foreign influence operations, coordinated disinformation, manipulated narratives or hostile actors exploiting India's social and institutional weaknesses represents a genuine strategic vulnerability. A crisis generated internally or amplified by forces outside the country can therefore escalate at extraordinary speed. Crisis management is no longer merely a question of police deployment or administrative orders; it is also a question of information, trust, digital communication and institutional credibility.

It is high time that the Indian State restores the basic meaning of public service. Citizens should receive reliable drinking water from Jal Boards rather than depending on mineral-water vendors; dependable electricity from electricity distribution authorities rather than generators and inverters; regular garbage collection from municipal corporations rather than private vendors; and public security from accountable police stations rather than private guards standing outside homes in almost every affluent colony across India. Citizens should be able to obtain legitimate certificates and regulatory approvals directly and transparently, without paying touts or middlemen. The disturbing presence of intermediaries managing access to courts, brokers facilitating admissions in government schools and hospitals, and agents controlling routine government services has become so normalised that a parallel economy of influence appears to have developed around public institutions.

Surely, nobody wants to live in a country where basic civic necessities and constitutional rights require private substitutes, personal connections or additional payments. But where can nearly one-fifth of humanity go if its own institutions fail to provide these essentials? There is no alternate India to which millions can simply migrate. That is precisely why preventive and corrective measures cannot be postponed. The objective is not to predict a storm but to prevent one. India must reform its institutions before accumulated frustration turns into a crisis that will be far more difficult and costly to control. The time for complacency is over; the time for systemic reform is now.

India needs a governance revolution: justice that is accessible, policing that is accountable, administration that is efficient, taxation that is fair, public expenditure that is transparent, social-media resilience that is strategic and an anti-corruption regime that respects both citizens and honest public servants. The true measure of democracy is not how successfully politicians win elections. It is how fairly, efficiently and respectfully the State treats an ordinary citizen. India has demonstrated that it can build a powerful modern economy. It must now build institutions worthy of its people. The time for cosmetic reform is over. India is crying for systemic reform. The objective is not to predict a storm but to prevent one.

Indian cities are becoming unliveable



Although the headline above might seem somewhat unrealistic today, the day it becomes a reality may not be far off. To understand this better, let us delve deeper into the matter.

Rapid urbanisation and population growth

Rural populations have always been lured by the glittering lifestyle of cities. Compounding this attraction is the issue of livelihood, as the tide of development often ebbs away by the time it travels from urban centres to rural areas. A lack of employment opportunities and infrastructure, along with natural disasters such as floods and droughts, drives rural folk towards cities. In addition, no comprehensive census report has been available since 2011 to provide a clear rate of migration from rural to urban areas. In 2020-21, approximately 54 per cent of internal migrants living in urban areas were from rural regions.

India as a whole is also becoming increasingly urban. Between 2001 and 2011, India's urban population grew 31.8 per cent over the decade, equivalent to roughly 2.8 per cent per year if simply annualised. The 2011 Census, for example, recorded Greater Mumbai's urban agglomeration at about 18.4 million, Delhi at 16.3 million, Kolkata at 14.1 million, Chennai at 8.7 million, and Bengaluru at 8.5 million.

Traffic, noise, pollution and shrinking open spaces

India's rapid rise in vehicle ownership is worsening congestion, parking shortages, and air and noise pollution. As a broad national benchmark, the Vahan database shows new vehicle registrations increased 12.2 per cent in 2024 and 8.5 per cent in 2025. Cities such as Delhi, Mumbai, Chennai, Bengaluru, Kolkata and Hyderabad continue to add vehicles rapidly. Pune is currently seeing around 1,300 new vehicles enter its roads every day. Alongside this, haphazard construction work taking place hither and thither is further exacerbating pollution. Excessive dust has become a nightmare for city dwellers.

Major cities including Delhi, Kolkata, Mumbai, Chennai, Bengaluru and Hyderabad are experiencing significant particulate pollution, although the severity varies by city and season. Delhi remains the most severe pollution hotspot, recording an average winter 2024-25 PM2.5 level of 175 µg/m³. Kolkata also faces severe winter pollution, while Mumbai, Chennai, Bengaluru and Hyderabad experience increasing localised pollution from traffic and other emissions. In Mumbai, some locations recorded pollution levels about 60 per cent above the citywide average. A 2026 CPCB-based study found that weather conditions, including low winds and atmospheric stagnation, can alter PM2.5 levels by up to 40 per cent.

The water crisis is emerging as a major urban challenge in India. This issue is no longer confined to drought-prone rural areas; even large cities are increasingly struggling to ensure an uninterrupted water supply for their rapidly growing populations. According to World Bank data, around 600 million people in India face severe water stress; meanwhile, urbanisation and climate change are placing additional strain on water supply systems that are already under pressure.



As the population has grown, the city has expanded horizontally as well. People are forced to live in the suburbs to find affordable housing, resulting in an increased distance between their homes and workplaces. Four to five hours of daily life are spent simply covering this distance, compounded by the ordeal of traffic congestion. Consequently, the quality of life is deteriorating; both body and mind are becoming exhausted. This is taking a severe toll on marital and other relationships, causing people to lose their natural smiles and happiness.

Even where sidewalks exist, they have been taken over by street vendors. Despite occasional eviction drives by the administration, it is nearly impossible to permanently remove these vendors, who rely on this trade to earn a livelihood. If roads are for vehicles and sidewalks are for vendors, then where is the space for pedestrians? Even various playgrounds and parks have fallen into the hands of real estate developers. People have nowhere left for morning or evening walks, and children have no space to play. People are suffering literally from a lack of oxygen.

For decades, urban development has prioritised wider roads, flyovers, parking spaces and faster traffic. Cars and two-wheelers have become central to city planning, while pedestrians, cyclists, children, elderly people and people with disabilities are often treated as an afterthought. The result is a city that may move vehicles efficiently but can be difficult for people to live in. Without urgent action on vehicle growth, public transport, parking and pollution control, urban life could become increasingly congested, unhealthy and unliveable. When urban planning begins with human needs rather than vehicles, cities become safer, healthier, more accessible and more enjoyable places to live. A people-friendly city must have safe and continuous footpaths, proper crossings, shaded walking areas, accessible public spaces and reliable public transport. Cities also need spaces where people can simply exist without having to spend money. Such spaces can make neighbourhoods more vibrant and help build a stronger sense of community. Cities should move people, not merely move traffic. To maintain a rational balance between water demand and supply, the vertical expansion of the city must also be regulated.

At the same time, it is crucial to create the necessary infrastructure for employment and business in rural areas. However, permanent measures to prevent natural disasters like floods or droughts are of the utmost importance. Only then will the population pressure on cities ease, allowing them to breathe freely and escape their current suffocating environment.

The writer is a former senior executive in a nationalised bank and an author who regularly writes for national and international newspapers and magazines on various topics

Bengal's inclusive and plural identity



The statement by Bengal BJP president and Member of Parliament Samik Bhattacharya that people of Rajasthan, Bhojpuri and Hindi-speaking backgrounds who have lived in Bengal for generations are also Bengali is not merely a political statement. It opens an important discussion about Bengal's social structure and India's pluralistic character. Chief Minister Shubhendu Adhikari's support for this view makes the issue even more significant. It reminds us that the identity of a state cannot be defined by language alone; it must also be understood through social participation, cultural belonging and shared citizenship.

Bengal has historically been a plural society. Kolkata and other parts of the state have been home for generations to Rajasthani, Bhojpuri, Maithili, Hindi-speaking, Punjabi, Gujarati, Odia and other communities. These communities have contributed substantially to Bengal's trade, industry, education, literature, journalism, art and public life. Their presence is therefore not external to Bengal's history; it is an integral part of it. To equate the word 'Bengali' exclusively with one's mother tongue would consequently be to

limit the broader reality of Bengal. A person may speak Bhojpuri, Maithili, Awadhi, Marwari, Rajasthani or Hindi at home and yet be deeply connected with Bengal's soil, culture and public life. Language is undoubtedly an important part of identity, but social commitment, cultural participation and citizenship cannot be judged by a single linguistic criterion.

The Indian Constitution recognises equal citizenship within diversity. A person can simultaneously be a resident of Bengal, a Hindi speaker, a member of a particular cultural tradition and an Indian citizen. These identities do not necessarily contradict one another; they can enrich one another.

This is especially important in Bengal, where language and culture have long been politically and socially sensitive issues. The historic struggle for the recognition and preservation of Bengali is legitimate and deserves respect. But protecting Bengali does not require excluding people who speak other languages from Bengal's collective identity. Respect for Bengali can coexist with equal respect for Hindi, Urdu, Rajasthani, Santali and other languages.

Indeed, Bengal's cultural strength lies in this coexistence. The culture of a city is not created



by its dominant language alone. It is shaped by its markets, neighbourhoods, food, literature, music, education, labour and everyday relationships. Kolkata's streets and marketplaces vividly demonstrate this cultural intermingling. Families that have lived in Bengal for generations have become part of its social history.

At the same time, recognizing Hindi-speaking communities as part of Bengal carries a responsibility for those communities as well. Those who regard Bengal as their home should respect its language and culture, develop sensitivity towards

not in uniformity but in the ability of people with diverse roots to share a common sense of belonging. Bengal has historically absorbed and nurtured many cultural streams. In the nineteenth century, it became a major centre of the Indian Renaissance, influencing modern education, printing, journalism and social reform across India, including the Hindi-speaking regions. Bengali intellectuals and institutions also made significant contributions to the development and spread of Hindi. Among them, Ishwar Chandra Vidyasagar deserves special mention for his inter-

est in Hindi education. Raja Rammohan Roy, Shyam Sundar Sen, Amritlal Chakravarti, Bhudev Mukherjee, Chintamani Ghosh, Kshitindramohan Mitra, Sharada Charan Mitra, Ramananda Chattopadhyay, Suniti Kumar Chatterji and many others contributed in different ways to India's linguistic and intellectual life. Rabindranath Tagore established the Hindi Bhavan at Santiniketan and invited Hazari Prasad Dwivedi to teach Hindi. Even today, Bengali-speaking scholars such as Prof. Soma Bandyopadhyay, Tanuja Majumdar and Gautam Sanyal continue to contribute to Hindi.

The history of Indian languages is therefore not a history of competition but of exchange and mutual enrichment. Hindi and Bengali have influenced one another and together contributed to the making of modern Indian consciousness. A Bengali-speaking person's love for Hindi does not diminish their Bengali identity, just as a Hindi-speaking person's affection for Bengali does not weaken their Hindi identity.

Bengal's identity is not a closed room but a flowing river into which many streams merge. Recognizing generations of Hindi — and Rajasthani-speaking residents as part of Bengal's social identity affirms this inclusive tradition. What is needed now is to transform this idea from a political statement into a practical culture of equal respect, equal rights and shared citizenship.

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Order Order

No interim stay for Delhi Race Club on eviction notice

A court here has dismissed a plea moved by the Delhi Race Club for an interim stay on an eviction order issued by the central government earlier this month, observing that the club failed to make a prima facie case in their favour.

The club had filed the plea against the eviction order passed by the Estate Officer on August 11 this year under the Public Premises (Eviction of Unauthorised Occupants) Act.

The court, in an order passed on Tuesday, said that the Centre did not issue any document to renew the club's lease after 1994 and, despite various opportunities, the club did not file any reply or put forth any plea before the Estate Officer, after which the officer passed the order of eviction based on the material placed before it by the Centre.

"I am of the considered view that appellant (club) has failed to make a prima facie case for stay of the impugned order... Accordingly, the application filed for interim stay is dismissed," Principal District and Sessions Judge Pitamber Dutt said. The judge said that the club was granted ample opportunity to file its reply before the Estate Officer.

He said, "Perusal of the record of the Estate Officer clearly shows that the Estate Officer had afforded more than sufficient opportunities to the appellant, but they did not submit their reply and evidence."

(PTI)

SC sets aside show cause notice to Tata Steel

The Supreme Court has set aside a show cause-cum-demand notice against Tata Steel from tax authorities over an "alleged irregular availment of input tax credit" amounting to over ₹1,000 crore between the financial years 2019 and 2023.

According to the notice, the steel major was required to show cause before the Additional/Joint Commissioner of Central GST & Central Excise, Jamshedpur, Jharkhand within 30 days "as to why the Goods and Service Tax (GST), amounting to ₹1007,54,83,342 for the period FY2018-19 through FY2022-23, shall not be demanded and recovered" from the company.

The notice, issued by the Office of the Commissioner (Audit), Central Tax, Ranchi, on June 27, said the input tax credit was availed in contravention of the provisions of Section 74(1) of the Central Goods and Services Tax Act, 2017/State Goods and Services Act, 2017 (CGST/SGST) read with Section 20 Integrated Goods and Services Tax Act, 2017. A bench of justices JB Pardiwala and K Vinod Chandran said there was no deliberate attempt by Tata Steel to evade tax or avail excess input tax credit.

"We do not find any such factual facts having been stated to make out a case of a deliberate device employed to evade tax or avail excess input tax credit, as coming out from the show cause-cum-demand notice. The bland statement made at some places of suppression of facts, merely to avail the extended period of limitation would barely suffice and puts to peril the notice under Section 74," the bench said.

Tata Steel had contended before the top court that there is no allegation of fraud, willful misstatement or suppression of facts. The dispute arose from a show cause notice issued to Tata Steel for the financial years 2018-19, 2019-20 and 2020-21 concerning an alleged mismatch of Input Tax Credit (ITC) and short payment of tax.

The notice was issued under Section 74 of the Central Goods and Services Tax Act, which deals with GST demand involving fraud or suppression. The steel major submitted that the notice contained no factual allegations establishing fraud, wilful misstatement or suppression of facts. The top court said the proceedings under Section 73/74 can be initiated only on the satisfaction of the assessing officer.

It said even if observations or objections are made on audit, the assessing officer should enter his satisfaction before a notice is issued. "Insofar as a notice under Section 74, the satisfaction should be not only of mismatch of ITC and short payment of tax having occurred, as is alleged in this case, the officer should be satisfied that either fraud/willfully," the bench said. "The fact that the department had taken up the objections on audit with the Public Accounts Committee itself indicates that there was no satisfaction at the end of the department, meaning the assessing officer; as to the mismatch or the short fall of payment of tax having occurred, not to say anything about the suppression alleged," the court said.

(PTI)

HC flags fraudulent use of Aadhaar by infiltrators to get Indian citizenship

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

The Bombay High Court has noted a "concerning pattern" of foreign nationals infiltrating borders and fraudulently obtaining documents like Aadhaar and PAN cards to claim Indian citizenship, and urged the Centre to take immediate steps to address the issue.

This pattern underscores a serious gap in inter-agency coordination and document verification, and in a few cases, such persons have also indulged in anti-national activities, a bench of Justices A S Gadkari and Kamal Khata noted, stressing

the need to trace and deport such people on priority.

It ordered the central government's concerned department to consider effecting necessary amendments in the Aadhaar Act to assist investigating agencies to promptly trace, deport and prevent re-entry of such persons who have infiltrated the border and/or obtained forged documents to secure Indian citizenship.

The bench, in the order passed last month, said it has observed a "concerning pattern" where foreign nationals have infiltrated India's border, fraudulently obtained basic documents to conceal their true identity

SC to hear plea on OBC creamy layer criteria on Sep 1

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court would hear on September 1 the plea of the Centre seeking clarification on the applicability of its March 11 judgment on OBC creamy layer criteria to candidates of the Civil Services Examination (CSE) 2025. According to the apex court website, a special bench comprising Justices P S Narasimha and R Mahadevan, which had passed the judgment on March 11 in the case, would assemble at 3.30 pm on September 1 to hear the plea of the Centre.

On Tuesday, a bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana agreed to consider setting up a special bench to hear the

Centre's plea.

The CJ-led bench was told by Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the Centre, that the DoPT has filed a miscellaneous application in a disposed-of matter seeking some urgent directions and it has to be listed before a bench headed by Justice P S Narasimha.

Senior advocate Sanjay Hegde, appearing for a litigant, said that a bench comprising Justices Narasimha and R Mahadevan had passed the order on March 11 and the instant miscellaneous application has to be heard by the same bench as the judges sit in different combinations now. "We will have to set up a special bench," the CJ said, adding that he will speak with the judges and set up the bench. The Department of Personnel and Training



(DoPT) seeks directions allowing the government to proceed with service allocation of the 958 candidates recommended by the Union Public Service Commission (UPSC) for CSE-2025 on the basis of the OBC creamy-layer determination applied before the March 11 verdict.

The DoPT's plea arises from the top court's judgment in a case titled as Union of India vs Rohith Nathan, in which the court held on March 11, among other things, that the October 14, 2004 clarifying letter could not override the September 8, 1993 office memorandum governing

identification of the OBC creamy layer. The court also held that the salary or income of a parent employed in a public sector undertaking or the private sector could not by itself be treated as the determinative criterion for creamy layer exclusion.

The status and category of the parent's post, along with the prescribed income and wealth test, were to be considered in accordance with the 1993 office memorandum. The government, while stating that it is bound by the Supreme Court's ruling, has said that applying the judgment mechanically to CSE-2025 could result in unequal treatment of candidates who were similarly placed but acted differently based on the legal position prevailing when the examination was conducted. According to the

application, the CSE-2025 notification was issued on January 22, 2025, the preliminary examination was held on May 25, 2025 and the main examination was conducted from August 22 to 31.

The UPSC declared the final result on March 6, 2026, recommending 958 candidates for appointment to the IAS, IFS, IPS and other central services. The top court delivered the Rohith Nathan judgment just five days later, on March 11. The Centre has pointed out that candidates whose parents were employed in public sector units (PSUs) or the private sector and whose income exceeded the prescribed ceiling could, under the interpretation prevailing at the time, have considered themselves ineligible for OBC (non-creamy layer) benefits.

UP tops pendency list across fast-track courts; Delhi has 7,385 pending cases: RTI

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Uttar Pradesh accounts for nearly 78 per cent cases pending before Fast Track Courts (FTCs) across the country, with more than 13.74 lakh cases awaiting disposal, according to data obtained under the Right to Information (RTI) Act from the Department of Justice.

Over 17.5 lakh matters are pending across the country, going by the data until June 30. According to the reply, Fast Track Courts (FTCs) are set up by the states and UTs



in consultation with the respective high courts for expeditious trial of specific categories of cases.

The data has been shared

by the Department of Justice in a reply on August 10 this year to a query filed under the Right to Information (RTI) Act by Noida-based social activist Amit Gupta.

It said, "As per information received from the high courts, 884 FTCs are functional across 21 State/UTs as on June 30, 2026. No central assistance to the States is being provided for the setting up of these FTCs." Analysis of the state-wise data shows that Uttar Pradesh tops the pendency list with over 13.74 lakh pending cases across 373 functional FTCs.

Gauhati HC admits PIL alleging Govt negligence behind Upper Assam floods

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Guwahati

The Gauhati High Court on Wednesday admitted a PIL filed by senior Congress leader Debabrata Saikia against the state government, alleging negligence led to the devastating floods in several Upper Assam districts in July.

Chief Justice Ashutosh Kumar heard the petitioner's counsel KN Chowdhury and directed all listed parties to file their replies by November 3. The floods in Sivasagar, Charaideo, Jorhat and Golaghat districts claimed 105 lives, displaced lakhs of people and destroyed the livelihoods of thousands of families, according to the petition. Saikia alleged that the floods were not a natural

calamity but a "man-made disaster". "I had been warning the government and the authorities since 2018. I had earlier approached the Gauhati High Court twice, and it had issued clear directions in 2019 and again in 2022 to stop illegal mining in the Dikhow riverbed and to constitute a Task Force Battalion," Saikia said. "The government simply ignored those orders. Even the official report of the Water Resources Department dated January 12, 2022, clearly predicted that continued illegal excavation would change the river's course and cause devastation, which has now come true in the most tragic manner," he said.

The petitioner said he had filed two PILs in 2018 and 2019 before the high court, high-



lighting alleged rampant and unscientific mining of sand and stone from the Dikhow riverbed, particularly in the Assam-Nagaland border areas. The HC had directed the state to stop illegal mining and form a dedicated Mines and Minerals Task Force Battalion, he said.

In 2022, the court again reit-

erated its directions, but the BJP-led state government did nothing, he alleged.

"The government protected the mining mafia instead of protecting the people of Upper Assam. Night-time mining continued with impunity. I submitted repeated representations to the Deputy Commissioner, the

Superintendent of Police, the Chief Secretary and even to the Chief Justice but no action was taken," Saikia said. Saikia also alleged that illegal open-cast coal mining in Nagaland's Mon, Mokokchung and Wokha districts and the sudden release of water from the Doyang Hydro Electric Project without proper coordination further aggravated the situation.

The natural protective features of the river, including sand and gravel bars that once helped moderate floodwaters, were systematically destroyed by years of illegal mining, he alleged.

The petition sought an immediate and permanent halt to illegal riverbed mining in the Dikhow and its tributaries and full implementa-

tion of the HC's 2019 and 2022 orders, including the creation of the Task Force Battalion. It also sought the constitution of a high-powered monitoring committee headed by a retired judge, scientific assessment of the role of illegal mining and dam releases in the floods; full restorative compensation to the victims beyond the token ex gratia; registration of FIRs against those responsible for illegal mining and official negligence; and a real-time coordinated protocol for upstream dam releases to protect downstream communities in Assam.

Demanding accountability, Saikia said the state government must answer why it ignored judicial orders for eight years.

Allahabad HC seeks 5-year school-wise data on RTE beneficiaries in UP



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Prayagraj

The Allahabad High Court has directed the Uttar Pradesh government to furnish five-year, school-wise data on students admitted under the Right to Education (RTE) Act, including details of children whose admissions were denied or not acted upon by schools.

The court also sought details of complaints alleging collection of capitation fees or adoption of screening procedures in violation of the state's education policy, along with action taken on such complaints. Justice Vinod Diwakar passed the order recently while hearing a writ petition filed by St John's School, Babhanauti, Pachwal.

The court observed that it had been brought to its notice that certain private educational institutions recognised by the state were reluctant to admit children and forgo fees and other charges ordinarily levied by them. "The correctness of the allegation is a matter upon which no opinion is expressed at this

stage and the affidavit called for hereinafter will enable the position to be ascertained," the court said. The bench directed the state government counsel to file an affidavit by September 15, the next date of hearing. It also directed schools affiliated to the CBSE, CISCE and other boards to cooperate with the Basic Shiksha Adhikari and District Inspector of Schools concerned in furnishing the required information.

The court clarified that the data was being sought only to obtain a complete picture and that no opinion had been expressed on the conduct of any school.

"Nothing herein shall be acted upon to the prejudice of any institution save after notice and in accordance with law," Justice Diwakar said. The high court had previously clarified that private schools in Uttar Pradesh affiliated with CBSE or ICSE are not exempt from the RTE Act, 2009, which guarantees free and compulsory education to children aged six to 14 years under Article 21A of the Constitution.



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Sensex falls 183 points, Nifty drops to 24,207.75



Market benchmark indices Sensex and Nifty drifted lower on Wednesday, giving up intraday gains, dragged by Reliance Industries and IT stocks.

The 30-share BSE Sensex settled at the intraday low of 77,472.94, down 183.15 points, or 0.24 per cent. During the session, the benchmark gained as much as 330.75 points to hit a high of 77,986.84.

The 50-share NSE Nifty was down 126.80 points, or 0.52 per cent, to end at 24,207.75. Among the 30 Sensex firms, Infosys, Bharti Airtel, Larsen & Toubro, Power Grid, Tech Mahindra, NTPC, Mahindra & Mahindra and Reliance Industries were the major laggards.

Kotak Mahindra Bank, UltraTech Cement, Axis Bank and Tata Steel were among the winners.

Gabriel India to buy stake in HL Klemove India for ₹935 crore



Gabriel India Ltd, the listed flagship of auto-component maker ANAND Group, will acquire a 30 per cent less one share stake in HL Klemove India Pvt Ltd for \$98.44 million, or about ₹935 crore, as it expands into advanced driver-assistance systems (ADAS) and automotive electronics. The investment will be made through a strategic joint venture with South Korea-based HL Klemove, a developer and manufacturer of autonomous-driving technologies and automotive electronic products. Gabriel India said the partnership would position it in a fast-growing segment as Indian vehicle makers increasingly adopt safety, connectivity and automated-driving features.

HL Klemove India will develop, manufacture and sell products including radars, front cameras, lidar systems, automated-driving and parking control units with embedded ADAS software. Its automotive-electronics portfolio will include brake and steering electronic control units, chassis-control units and torque sensors. Jaish Singh, vice-chairman of ANAND Group, said the venture was part of Gabriel India's plan to build scale, improve competitiveness and widen its presence in high-growth automotive segments.

Anjali Singh, executive chairperson of ANAND Group and Gabriel India, said the partnership would help diversify the company's product portfolio while strengthening its role in emerging mobility technologies. Gabriel India has been broadening beyond its established automotive-component operations through joint ventures in segments such as sunroofs, lubricants, EV fluids and precision fasteners. The HL Klemove partnership adds ADAS and electronics capabilities to that strategy, potentially enabling closer engagement with vehicle manufacturers as demand rises for safer and more software-defined vehicles.

Hoping to work towards further expanding scope of India-Japan trade pact: Goyal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ngoya

Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal on Wednesday said he discussed reviewing the current trade pact with his Japanese counterpart, and both hope to work towards further expanding its scope.

The two countries implemented a Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) in August 2011. The CEPA review is a long-pending demand of India to balance the bilateral trade.

Prime Ministers of both countries, during summit-level talks in New Delhi last month, announced that since it has been 15 years since the signing of CEPA, the two sides should discuss the pact and make it more contemporary. "I have also discussed it with my counterpart minister, and we are hoping to work towards further expanding the scope and providing new opportunities for this relationship to grow," Goyal told reporters here.

Goyal is on a four-day official visit to Japan from August 24. He is leading a large busi-



ness delegation of over 200 representatives from different sectors.

"We haven't got down to work on terms of reference, but I think once the teams have discussed, we will be open to expanding the scope, scale and the extent of the engagement because Japan today is one of our most strategic partners," he added. Both countries have big plans to strengthen the partnership, he said, adding that both sides have also discussed the importance of balanced trade.

The two-way commerce between the countries grew 9.18 per cent to \$27.47 billion (exports of \$6.03 billion and

The monk who runs state finances

Yogi Adityanath's Uttar Pradesh is rewriting its economic story through fiscal discipline, infrastructure investment and improved law and order, emerging as a major economic force while challenging the long-held belief that fiscal prudence belongs mainly to India's southern and western States



In Indian politics, Yogi Adityanath is filed under a single heading: law and order. The saffron robes, the bulldozers, the pursuit of criminal syndicates that at their peak rivalled terror outfits in menace. It is a caricature that suits admirers and critics alike, and it obscures the more consequential story unfolding in Uttar Pradesh. Over nearly a decade in office, the monk has quietly become one of the country's most disciplined managers of public money.

Start with the scale of the turnaround. In 2016-17, the last year of the Akhilesh Yadav government, Uttar Pradesh was widely written off as an economic laggard, a giant that punched far below its weight. Its output that year was about ₹13.3 lakh crore. By 2024-25 it had reached ₹29.78 lakh crore, more than doubling in under a decade. In absolute terms the state has added roughly ₹16.5 lakh crore to its economy, more than one and a half times the entire output of Bihar.

That growth has carried UP to the front rank of Indian states. At ₹29.78 lakh crore, it is now the third-largest economy in the country, behind only Maharashtra (₹ 45.32 lakh crore) and Tamil Nadu (₹31.19 lakh crore), and it has moved ahead of both Karnataka (₹28.84 lakh crore) and Gujarat (about ₹27 lakh crore). It now towers over the states it was long bracketed with: West



Bengal (₹18.15 lakh crore), Rajasthan (₹17.04 lakh crore), Telangana (₹16.41 lakh crore) and Andhra Pradesh (₹15.93 lakh crore). UP's economy today is three times the size of Bihar's, roughly the combined output of West Bengal and Haryana, and within touching distance of Tamil Nadu for second place.

What makes the achievement striking is how it was managed. Growth in UP has not been purchased with the usual instruments of political economy, the freebie, the loan waiver, the off-budget borrowing that flatters one year and haunts the next. It has come instead from fiscal fundamentals: revenue that is actually collected, spending that leans towards capital rather than consumption, and a deficit kept within its guardrails. This is not an

economy on steroids or subsidies, and it has managed the feat despite one of the lowest per capita incomes among the large states.

The comparison that should give the southern commentariat pause is with Tamil Nadu. UP has now drawn almost level with the coastal state in the sheer size of its economy, and on the fiscal scorecard in this data it comes out ahead on every one of the ten standard measures by which states are judged. It is one thing for a rich, long-industrialised economy to keep its books tidy; wealth is forgiving. It is quite another for a state with UP's income levels, its population and its history to match Tamil Nadu in output and outscore it on discipline. And because UP's per capita income is still a fraction of the

southern average, the room left to grow is enormous.

Here the law-and-order reputation and the fiscal record turn out to be the same story told twice. Capital does not flow to places where contracts are settled by the strongest local strongman. By dismantling the syndicates that once ran extortion across the state, the government did more than improve the crime statistics; it rewrote the risk calculus for anyone thinking of building a factory or a warehouse in UP. Law and order, in this sense, is an enabler for the economy. Had Yogi not made so many powerful people uncomfortable, few would have trusted the state with their money. The bulldozer is not the opposite of the balance sheet. It is its precondition.

Geography will do much of the rest. A large slice of UP sits within reach of the National Capital Region, and the state has been shrewd in turning that proximity into expressways, industrial corridors and warehousing rather than leaving it as an accident of the map. Tamil Nadu has a manufacturing heritage on its side; UP has the NCR on its doorstep and a domestic market of 240 million people at home.

None of this makes UP a finished project, and honesty requires saying so. Per capita income remains low, and averages hide the distance still to be travelled in the poorer east. On current trends the state should touch the trillion-dollar mark sometime in the early 2040s, and even that is a conservative estimate. But a model built on sustained investment is only as durable as the political stability underwriting it, and investors quietly price in the risk that a decade of discipline could be undone by a change of guard.

Still, the direction is unmistakable, and it should unsettle a few settled assumptions: that fiscal virtue is the preserve of the south and the west, that the Hindi heartland is destined to drag on the national economy, and that a leader defined by his cultural politics cannot also be a competent custodian of a treasury. UP under Adityanath is falsifying all three. The man the country files under law and order has been running his state's finances with an eye any chief financial officer would recognise: collect what you are owed, spend on what lasts, and never mortgage tomorrow for today's headline. It is unglamorous work. It is also the work that decides whether a state of 240 million people rises or stalls.

The author is a political analyst and the founding editor of poltypolicy.com

JSW-MG Motor launches Hector Tomahawk as EV and PHEV

KUSHAN MITRA ■ Mumbai

JSW-MG Motor, the joint-venture between SAIC and JSW Group has major expansion plans in the coming few months as they launched the first vehicle from their new ADAPT platform, the MG Hector Tomahawk.

The new electric vehicle has a starting price of ₹13.99 lakh for the battery as a service (BaaS) and between ₹19.49 lakh and ₹22.99 lakh and is available in both a 5 and 7 seat versions.

The vehicle features a 69 kilowatt-hour battery and claimed range of 517 kilometers with a 201 horsepower motor. A Plug-In Hybrid EV version was also launched with a claimed range of over 1100 kilometers on a single tank and full charge on its 20.5 kilowatt-hour battery.

A BaaS package starts at ₹21.79 lakh and outright purchase prices are between

25.69 and 27.79 lakh.

Speaking with the media at the launch event in Mumbai, Parth Jindal, Director, JSW-MG Motor India said that the company is planning a major expansion at the plant in Halol, Gujarat from around 110,000 units currently to 160,000 units by March 2027 to 220,000 units by January 2018 and if demand is sustained a potential increase to 400,000 units.

"Our production has been achieving record numbers every single year since we established this joint-venture", Jindal said while highlighting the potential of the new Hector Tomahawk which was launched both as an electric vehicle (EV) and a plug-in hybrid electric vehicle (PHEV). While Jindal was bullish on PHEV and said this was the first PHEV to be made in India he did highlight the potential for more growth if the government adjusts tax



rates. "In China, EVs, PHEVs and Range Extended EV (EREV) are all taxed at a similar rate which has spurred adoption of such vehicles; however, we believe that the government will encourage such vehicles in India as well.

Particularly EREV where the battery powers the wheels",

he said and added that while their new ADAPT platform supports EREV they will wait to see consumer interest before a potential launch.

Additionally, he highlighted the massive increase in demand for electric vehicles in India and said that while EV sales stood at eight percent of the market today, h3

expected EV sales to jump to 9-10 percent of the market by the end of the year as JSW-MG and other manufacturers all launch more EVs and support the building out of charger infrastructure.

"This platform has been developed keeping in mind a simple fact that an electric vehicle is not for everyone", Anurag Mehrotra, Managing Director, JSW-MG Motor India said adding that the additional cost of the PHEV is only due to taxation reasons but all 'New Energy Vehicles' serve the purpose of reducing fuel consumption.

On the JSW Group's other automotive plans, Jindal gave few insights into the talks with the Volkswagen Group which have been rumoured but said that the plans to launch JSW's own automotive brand remained on track for later this year where it is expected that products from Chinese carmaker Chery's

Jetour brand will be brought to India. He also said that the plans for JSW to establish a cell plant in Odisha is currently on hold as China is "keeping LFP manufacturing technology close to their chest." Jindal also said that while the JSW Group is in talks with SAIC for further investments in JSW-MG Motor he believed that the current relaxation in Press Note 3 norms that restricted investments by Chinese companies in India was a good sign.

"Our current investment plans of ₹3500 crore are on track and comprise a significant chunk of our investment in the partnership and the rest will use a combination of debt and equity." He did not mention if SAIC (MG Motor) will be selling any more of their current 49 percent stake to JSW which currently holds 35 percent of the company.

BSE, NSE impose over ₹59 lakh penalty on NTPC, SJVN, REC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Stock exchanges BSE and NSE together imposed penalties totalling ₹59.14 lakh on public sector power companies NTPC, REC and SJVN for breach of norms. NTPC, in a regulatory filing, said the company has received notices from BSE and NSE with each imposing a penalty of ₹5.36,900 (inclusive of GST) on account of non-compliance with Regulation 17(1) of the listing regulations.

In its reply to the exchanges, NTPC said it is a government company and "as per the Articles of Association of the Company, the power to appoint or remove directors vests with the President of India through its administrative ministry, i.e., the Ministry of Power.

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the fines imposed, the power giant said.

SJVN said that both BSE and NSE have separately imposed a fine of ₹13,44,020 for non-compliance of certain SEBI listing regulations.

The company said that it will submit a request to both the exchanges for a waiver, as the power to appoint or remove directors vests with the President of India acting through the Ministry of Power.

India, France launch desibel to boost AVGC-XR sector

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

India and France are strengthening their partnership with the introduction of 'Desibel', a multi-year initiative aimed at elevating India's AVGC-XR (Animation, Visual Effects, Gaming, and Comics and Immersive Content) industry on the global stage.

The initiative has been introduced by the Embassy of France in India, the French Institute in India (IFI), along with support from the French Ministry for Europe and Foreign Affairs.

Thierry Mathou, Ambassador of France to India, stated, "France has emerged as a pioneering partner in building cooperation with India in



the AVGC-XR industry. The talented Indian creators involved in the Desibel project are true Passeurs of culture, carrying stories, ideas, and

innovation across borders. France is honoured to contribute to showcasing and amplifying their work on the international stage."

Backed by a two-year grant, the Desibel programme brings together some of India's leading cultural organisations, spanning community libraries, publishing, and the animation and XR industry, reflecting the diversity and depth of India's visual storytelling ecosystem.

Desibel is anchored in four values. These include access: ensuring visual storytelling reaches communities beyond major cities; capacity-building: equipping librarians, artists, and creators with new skills; preservation: documenting India's visual storytelling heritage; and international exchange: building sustainable pathways between Indian creators and the global, especially French, creative ecosystem.

Who has the right to set the rules of global trade?

Sanctions on Iran: When economic power becomes a tool of political subjugation



DR WAIEL
AWWAD

What is happening today between the United States and Iran goes far beyond the dispute over Tehran's nuclear programme or its regional behavior. At its core, we are witnessing a broader confrontation over who has the right to determine the rules of economic engagement in the international system, and to what extent a single power can use its financial superiority to impose its choices on other sovereign States.

In recent days, Washington has escalated what it describes as a broad economic campaign against Iran, targeting dozens of individuals, entities and vessels, while expanding pressure to include the oil, shipping, technology, gold and cryptocurrency sectors. At the same time, Washington has threatened Iran's trading partners with secondary sanctions if they continue doing business with Tehran. This is precisely where the problem begins to go beyond Iran.

The United States, like any other country, has the right to take measures against entities under its jurisdiction or those it considers a threat to its national security. But the question becomes fundamentally different when Washington tells a third country that is not subject to US law: "If you do business with Iran, we will punish you too."

At that point, sanctions cease to be merely an American instrument directed at Iran and become a mechanism for forcing third parties to adopt American policy. This is the essence of what are known as secondary or extraterritorial sanctions. Their real power does not come solely from the size of the American economy, but from Washington's ability to control access

to the dollar, the international financial system and US markets.

The message then becomes clear: "You may be a sovereign state, but you cannot make an independent economic decision if it conflicts with American policy." The question, therefore, is no longer simply: Does Iran deserve sanctions or not? The more important question is: Can one power make its foreign policy a binding standard for the rest of the world?

The position here must be clear. Rejecting unilateral sanctions does not mean endorsing Iranian policy, just as rejecting Iranian threats against neighboring states does not mean accepting American coercion.

The 2017 Qatar crisis provides an important example of how geography and economics can be used in regional conflicts. When Qatar was subjected to a blockade by Saudi Arabia, the UAE, Bahrain and Egypt, Iran did not join the blockade. Instead, it opened its airspace to Qatari aircraft and helped provide alternative routes for supplies and trade, taking advantage of its geographic position. At the same time, the crisis encouraged Doha to diversify its economic and political relationships with Turkey, Iran and others.

What Washington wants has become increasingly clear. The issue is no longer limited to using sanctions to force Iran to abandon its political, regional and economic choices. It goes further, turning sanctions into a tool for creating a chronic regional crisis by pushing neighboring states, directly or indirectly, to participate in pressure against Tehran and confront it.

Thus, we move from the stated objective of preventing nuclear proliferation to a broader attempt to reshape the behavior of an entire State—and even to redesign the regional environment surrounding it—by using economic power as an instrument of political subjugation. The United States does not necessar-



ily need to deploy military forces everywhere to impose its will. The power of the dollar, the banking system, American markets, insurance and shipping networks, and technology gives Washington enormous influence over the decisions of countries far beyond its borders. The financial system itself therefore becomes an instrument of foreign policy. This also explains why American sanctions on Iran have become an issue extending far beyond Washington and Tehran. China, the largest buyer of Iranian oil, is at the centre of the equation, while companies and entities across Asia and the West Asia face increasing pressure.

The real question for the future, therefore, is not simply whether Iran will withstand the pressure. It is: How long will the world accept the transformation of American financial power into a global licensing system determining who is allowed to trade with whom?

And this is where the importance of multipolarity becomes evident.

China has emerged as a major economic power. India is pursuing a policy

of strategic autonomy. Russia is seeking to reduce its dependence on the Western financial system. Gulf States are diversifying their partnerships, while countries across the Global South are looking for payment and trading mechanisms less vulnerable to external sanctions. This does not mean that the dollar will lose its dominant position anytime soon, nor does it mean that the United States will lose its influence.

But the excessive use of economic power may produce the opposite result: encouraging States to search for alternatives.

Sanctions therefore become a double-edged sword. They may weaken the targeted state in the short term, but at the same time they may encourage the creation of alternative trade and financial networks in the long term.

India has no interest in joining a policy of "either you are with us or against us."

India needs stable relations with the United States, but it also needs Iran, the Gulf and Central Asia. It has strategic interests in Chabahar and in connectivity, trade and energy corridors.

Therefore, the most balanced Indian position should rest on three principles: compliance with legally binding international sanctions; rejection of unilateral sanctions with extraterritorial effects; and preservation of India's independent decision-making in trade, energy and regional connectivity.

This is neither a policy in support of Iran nor a policy against America. It is a policy of defending Indian strategic autonomy.

The problem is that both Washington and Tehran fall into the same trap, but through different instruments. Washington tells countries: "Do not help Iran, or you will pay the price."

Tehran tells countries: "Do not help America suffocate Iran, or you will pay the price." The neighborhood therefore finds itself caught between two forms of coercion: American economic coercion and Iranian security coercion. This is not a recipe for stability. It is a recipe for expanding the circle of conflict.

The solution is not for countries to choose between Washington and Tehran. It lies in restoring a simple principle that is too often ignored in international politics:

A sovereign state has the right to choose its political and commercial partners, unless it is bound by legally binding international obligations that prohibit such engagement.

If the United States wants to prevent Iran from developing military nuclear capabilities, it should use diplomacy, international monitoring and guarantees. If Iran wants its neighbors to refrain from participating in American sanctions, it should use trade, diplomacy and incentives—not threats.

Turning the economy into a weapon, geography into an instrument of blackmail, and sovereignty into a bargaining chip will not produce a stable regional order.

Our rejection of unilateral American policy does not mean support for Iran.

Likewise, our rejection of Iranian threats against neighboring States does not mean justification for American sanctions. The principle must be the same: economic power should not be transformed into an instrument for forcing sovereign states to adopt another country's policy.

If Washington wants to confront Iran, it should do so through international law and negotiation, not by forcing countries around the world to choose between trading with Iran and retaining access to the American financial system.

Iran, for its part, cannot demand that its neighbours respect its sovereignty and then threaten them when they make decisions it dislikes.

The objective is not to choose a side, but to defend sovereignty and reject coercion from whichever side it comes.

The BRICS Test

As we await the outcome of next month's BRICS summit in New Delhi, a gathering of strategic rivals, the grouping will face a genuine test of its ability to build common ground for a multipolar international order. The central question will be: Will multipolarity simply mean a transition from the dominance of one power to a world of multiple powers capable of imposing their will or will it create a more balanced system that protects the right of states to choose their own political and economic paths without being punished or threatened simply because they have chosen a different one?

The success of BRICS will not be measured by its ability to confront Washington, nor by its proximity to Tehran, Beijing or Moscow. It will be measured by its ability to demonstrate that multipolarity means multiple centers of decision-making—not multiple centers of coercion. Let us wait and watch.

The author is a senior journalist and West Asia strategist

India, US discuss ways to strengthen civil nuclear cooperation

SAGAR KULKARNI ■ Washington

Top officials from India and the US on Wednesday discussed developments in bilateral civil nuclear space and ways to further strengthen cooperation in the area.

Atomic Energy Commission Chairman Ajit Kumar Mohanty held discussions with US Energy Secretary Chris Wright here ahead of the ministerial launch of IAEA's Atomic Technologies Licensed for Applications at Sea (ATLAS) initiative.

Mohanty, who is also Secretary, Department of Atomic Energy, is in the US for the launch of an initiative of the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) to explore the use of small modular reactors to power civilian ships. "The discussions focused on the ongoing



Atomic Energy Commission Chairman Ajit Kumar Mohanty

developments in bilateral civil nuclear space and policy mea-

sures to further strengthen India-US Civil Nuclear Cooperation for

mutual benefit of both the sides," the Department of Atomic Energy said in a post on X. The meeting comes against the backdrop of India opening up its civil nuclear energy sector for private players as it eyes to build 100 GW of nuclear power capacity by 2047.

Several US firms in the nuclear energy sector have evinced interest in the Indian market and are exploring avenues for investments and partnerships.

The ATLAS initiative of the IAEA will support the maritime industry's exploration of small modular reactors (SMRs) to power civilian ships and to provide offshore energy, as operators consider alternative fuels and seek to strengthen long-term energy security. he ATLAS Launch Event is expected to

establish strong momentum and visibility for the initiative by securing high-level political endorsement and fostering engagement across the nuclear and maritime sectors, the IAEA said.

The discussions are expected to deliver a shared understanding and validation of priority actions related to legal and regulatory frameworks, safety, security, safeguards and liability, while strengthening collaboration between the nuclear and maritime sectors.

The event is also expected to enhance alignment between nuclear and maritime stakeholders by identifying key challenges, gaps and areas requiring harmonisation. Collectively, this will underpin the development of a clear, actionable and broadly supported roadmap for ATLAS. (PTI)

Prince Harry, Meghan move back to UK

ADITI KHANNA ■ London

Prince Harry and his wife Meghan Markle arrived in the UK on Wednesday in time for their children, Archie and Lilibet, to start school next month, according to British media reports.

The non-working royals are believed to have flown into Birmingham Airport privately from California and are expected to base their family at a private property outside of London, in the picturesque Cotswolds area. A spokesperson for the Duke and Duchess of Sussex, Harry and Meghan, told the BBC that "this is not something we would comment on".

The couple are expected to bring their dogs, Mia and Pula, with them, but are keeping the chickens from their farm in the US back in Montecito, California.

"How long will they stay? I don't know, but it will be for an extended period. Whether that's six months, a year, two years... who knows," a source was quoted as saying to 'The Daily Telegraph'.

The newspaper claims the couple plan to live as an "international" family, keeping their homes in the US and Portugal. (PTI)



Zelenskyy awards Musk Ukraine's order of freedom for Starlink role

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Kyiv

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy on Wednesday awarded Elon Musk the Order of Freedom, one of Ukraine's highest state honours, for his "outstanding personal merits" in protecting human life and freedom and strengthening ties between Ukraine and the United States.

Musk, the founder of SpaceX, has become one of the most influential and contentious private sector figures in Ukraine's war effort. His decision to provide Ukraine with access to Starlink, SpaceX's satellite internet network, was critical. It remains a communications lifeline for Ukrainian forces and civilians after Russia's full-scale invasion in 2022.

Starlink has become deeply embedded in Ukraine's military operations, with commanders and soldiers relying on satellite connec-



tivity to communicate and coordinate operations. That dependence has given Musk influence over Ukraine's military capabilities, a source of concern.

Musk's decision-making could shape Ukraine's future military capabilities. Ukraine's president is hoping he will reconsider allowing Starlink to operate over Russian ter-

ritory so Ukrainian forces can maintain satellite connectivity for longer-range drone attacks targeting Russia's military and economic infrastructure.

There was no immediate Musk comment on the award, which was announced by presidential decree.

The technology has been integrated into Ukraine's drone operations, helping operators maintain links with drones and navigate them over longer distances. Ukraine's access to Starlink is the main reason its middle-strike drone campaign, which caught Russian forces off guard and undermined their logistics lines earlier this year, reported early successes.

Musk has allowed the Ukrainians to use Starlink inside their own territory, including in Ukrainian regions occupied by the Russians, but has restricted use of the satellite system inside Russia.

SpaceX's decision earlier this year to accept Kyiv's pleas and block unauthorised Starlink terminals being used by Russian forces in occupied territory also strengthened Ukraine's position.

The campaign has put pressure on Russian logistics in Crimea, giving Ukrainian forces a degree of battlefield momentum that Kyiv has not enjoyed since its successful counteroffensives around Kherson and Kharkiv in late 2022.

Musk is both a crucial partner for Kyiv and a potential source of vulnerability and dependence. As Starlink has become embedded in Ukraine's wartime communications, Musk and SpaceX have significant influence over how the technology can be used. Musk's decisions can have direct consequences for Ukraine's military capabilities, making it important that Kyiv preserve a positive relationship.

Mamdani opposes RSS chief Bhagwat's Madison Square Garden event

YOSHITA SINGH ■ New York

New York City Mayor Zohran Mamdani has said he does not support the planned event at Madison Square Garden featuring RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat, who is scheduled to address the Indian diaspora later this week.

Mamdani, however, noted that the city may not have jurisdiction to cancel the "private" event.

Bhagwat, who arrived in the US on Tuesday, is visiting the country as part of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh's (RSS) centenary-year global outreach programme. His outreach tour also includes Canada and the UK.



New York City Mayor Zohran Mamdani

In the US, he is scheduled to address a gathering of around 5,000 people at the iconic Madison Square Garden (MSG) on August 29. The planned appearance has drawn criticism from several civil rights organisations.

"I don't support the rally, but I don't know if the city has any jurisdiction on cancelling a private event," Mamdani said at a press conference here on Tuesday, responding to a question on the RSS chief's planned event and protests against it.

The Indian-origin mayor was asked whether the MSG event should be cancelled.

Mamdani, who described himself as the first Indian-American mayor in New York

City's (NYC) history, said his mother's family is still in India.

He said the vision of India he was taught by his family and grew up familiar with was that of "a pluralistic society" and "a secular republic" that believed in the belonging of each and every person from India.

The 34-year-old NYC mayor said it had been "incredibly troubling" to see the rise of a movement based on an "exclusionary vision", without specifically elaborating on the context of his observation.

He said he was in "deep opposition" to it both as an Indian-American and as mayor of a city that believes

deeply in the belonging of every person, regardless of their colour, creed, religion, faith or where they are from.

Mamdani is the son of Indian-origin filmmaker Mira Nair and Ugandan academic Mahmood Mamdani. He took charge as New York City mayor in January.

Several interfaith and civil rights organisations - which include Hindus for Human Rights, Indian American Muslim Council and Interfaith Centre of New York, among others - have opposed Bhagwat's planned appearance at the MSG and urged the iconic venue to cancel the event.

AHEAD Forum, a public policy and research trust, is

hosting Bhagwat in the US, with its planned programmes under the banner of "Universal Oneness Celebration". It said in a social media post that the RSS chief's visit "carries a timeless and universal message: The world is one family", as it called upon people to look beyond "artificial divisions and differences".

Bhagwat's ongoing foreign visit is aimed at presenting a "factual and positive perspective on India, Hindu society and the RSS", the organisation's joint general secretary CR Mukunda said in a press conference in Visakhapatnam last week. (PTI)

Need to scale up lending to MSMEs in rural, semi-urban areas: DFS Secretary

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Department of Financial Services (DFS) Secretary Sanjay Lohiya has underscored the need to scale up lending to MSMEs in rural and semi-urban areas given the importance of the sector in the economy.

Speaking at a conclave organised by the Small Industries Development Bank of India (SIDBI) on Tuesday, Lohiya said RRBs will also be able to achieve their goal of diversifying their loan portfolios by focusing on MSME lending, and rule engine-based underwriting is also expected to help them maintain good asset quality. The conclave attended by Chairmen of all 28 Regional Rural Banks (RRBs), SIDBI CMD Manoj Mittal and other senior officials focused on expanding the SIDBI-RRB MSME Co-Lending arrangement, the finance ministry said in a statement on Wednesday.

During the conclave, the Secretary emphasised the importance of scaling up MSME lending in rural and



Department of Financial Services Secretary Sanjay Lohiya

semi-urban areas.

The proposed arrangement synergises the strengths of SIDBI, which understands the credit needs of MSMEs, and RRBs, which have an excellent reach across the smaller towns and villages of the country, he said.

DFS Additional Secretary Debasish Prusty, while addressing the conclave, indicated the importance of MSME cluster data for a focused approach to reaching out to a large number of

MSMEs. RRBs should contribute towards making the country a next-generation manufacturing hub and also take an active part in Rozgar Melas conducted by state governments to disseminate financial awareness among MSMEs, he said.

He also suggested that RRBs make MSME lending through this co-lending arrangement an important target for branches.

Speaking at the event, SIDBI Chairman and Managing Director also urged

the RRBs to come forward and make the arrangement a success.

The Co-Lending Origination Platform developed by SIDBI is an end-to-end digital platform providing a faster and paperless credit journey, resulting in the quick sanction and disbursement of loans, it said.

Loan applicants will be informed of their in-principle sanctions within a very short turnaround time once all the details are provided through the application portal, it said.

The digital documentation and disbursement process also ensures that customers receive loan disbursements directly into their accounts without the need to visit branches at any stage of the process, it said.

With encouraging outcomes from the pilot implementation at three RRBs, the proposed expansion of this Co-Lending programme to more RRBs is expected to significantly address the credit needs of borrowers, especially in the Micro and Small segments, in rural and semi-urban areas, it added.

Home loan portfolio set to cross ₹10 lakh cr milestone this quarter, says SBI Chairman

KUMAR DIPANKAR
■ New Delhi

Highlighting the leadership position of SBI in the housing finance segment, its Chairman CS Setty said the mortgage portfolio is set to cross an important milestone of ₹10 lakh crore in the current quarter on the back of robust demand.

The country's largest lender had surpassed ₹9 lakh crore home loan portfolio during the last financial year.

"We should be reaching the 10 trillion mark, hopefully in this quarter itself," Setty told PTI in an interview.

SBI has a market share of nearly 28 per cent in the home loan segment, he said, adding that the bank has focused on making home loans accessible across the country. The lender has more than 460 home loan processing centres across India, increasing accessibility of its housing finance products.

Setty said transparency in pricing and customer trust in the bank's processes, including documentation and due diligence of builders, are among the key factors driving customers to the



State Bank of India Chairman Challa Sreenivasulu Setty

lender for home loans.

"People trust SBI the most when it comes to taking a home loan... that paperwork is properly done, including the due diligence on the builder," he said. He also emphasised that home loans should not be viewed merely as a standalone banking product, given their wider contribution to economic activity and multiplier effect on many allied industries.

"Home loan as a segment is very important for the economy," he said, noting that more than 200 industries depend on commercial and residential real estate. "In a way, home loan

should not be seen as a standalone product. It is to be seen as an integral part of India's economic growth," he said.

About securitisation of home loans, Setty said the outstanding pool at the industry level is more than ₹30 lakh crore, but the assets remain relatively illiquid, limiting banks' ability to recycle capital and expand lending. Globally, he said, the mortgage book is more liquid, while in India, it is mostly illiquid, with a few securitisation here and there happening but not in a big way.

"We are also looking at how we can bring securitisation structures into the

market. However, for these structures to work effectively, there has to be adequate participation from the non-bank sector. We are, therefore, consciously working to develop and enable such structures, with the objective of strengthening funding capabilities and deepening the overall ecosystem," he said.

"We are working with the investors with regard to the structure and tenure of paper. We are working out the nitty-gritty. This year, we are keen to do one transaction in the space," he said.

This would help the bank further expand its lending capacity, he added.

As RBI's concessional swap window draws to a close this month-end, Setty expressed confidence that the bank would garner about USD 10 billion from non-resident Indians and foreign investors.

Earlier this month, the Reserve Bank of India advanced the closure of the Foreign Currency Non-Resident Bank (FCNR-B) deposits swap window by a month to August 31 from the earlier cut-off date of September 30.

Govt mobilises about ₹3,000 cr from Hindustan Copper OFS

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The government has realised nearly ₹3,000 crore from share sale of Hindustan Copper with the closure of OFS on Wednesday. The offer for sale (OFS) for Hindustan Copper Ltd closed successfully with an enthusiastic response from retail investors, Department of Investment and Public Asset Management (DIPAM) Secretary Arunish Chawla said on X.

"The issue was oversubscribed on both days, and the Government decided to exercise its entire greenshoe option. We thank all investors for their participation and depositing their faith in us," he said. The OFS comprised of 5.8 crore shares with base offer size 29,01,073 shares and oversubscription option of 29,01,073 shares.

Against 5,802,146 shares for sale, 41,566,840 crore (provisional) bids came at the end of



last day of the OFS, as per data available on the exchanges.

The government proposed to sell a little over 5.8 crore shares, or up to 6 per cent (including 3 per cent greenshoe option) stake in Hindustan Copper, through a two-day OFS at a floor price of ₹514 apiece.

The floor price was set at a 10.38 per cent discount over Monday's closing share price.

Shares of Hindustan Copper on Tuesday closed at ₹556.55, up 4.38 per cent a piece on the BSE.

The government currently has a 66.14 per cent equity

holding in Hindustan Copper. So far in the current fiscal year, the government has mopped up ₹52,716 crore via PSU disinvestment through OFS in eight PSUs and remittances from SUUTI.

With the realisation of Hindustan Copper Ltd, the collection under the disinvestment head would rise to about ₹55,700 crore with minority stake sale in nine PSUs.

For the full FY27 financial year, the Budget has set a target of ₹80,000 crore to be raised from disinvestment and asset monetisation.

Adani Energy Solutions bags ₹4,700 cr transmission project in Maharashtra

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Adani Energy Solutions Ltd. (AESL) on Wednesday said it has secured a transmission project worth ₹4,700 crore in Maharashtra for the evacuation of 4,500 MW of renewable energy and storage power.

The project "Network Expansion Scheme in Western Region to Cater to Pumped Storage Potential near Satara (up to 4500 MW) - Part A", was awarded to AESL through the Tariff Based Competitive Bidding (TBCB) process, a company statement said.

AESL, a private transmission and distribution company and part of the globally diversified Adani portfolio, has won a key transmission project for the evacuation of renewable energy generated in Karnataka to major load centres in Maharashtra, according to the statement.



The project, which entails an estimated capital expenditure of ₹4,700 crore, will also support the growing pumped storage ecosystem in the Satara, Pune and Mumbai Metropolitan Region (MMR), it stated.

Housed under the Special Purpose Vehicle (SPV) Satara Power Transmission Ltd., the project is scheduled to be completed within 36 months. It will add 562 circuit kilometres (ckm) of transmission lines and 9,000 MVA of transformation capacity to AESL's portfolio, taking its cumulative transmission network to 29,739 ckm and its transformation capacity

to 1,43,425 MVA.

"The Satara transmission project will create a vital transmission backbone to support both renewable energy evacuation and energy storage deployment, strengthening power flows between Southern and Western India," said Kandarp Patel, CEO, AESL in the statement.

The project includes establishment of a 765/400 kV substation at Satara, Kolhapur-Satara 765 kV double-circuit transmission line, and augmentation of the Kolhapur pooling station along with associated transmission infrastructure.

Outstation teams shine at Patna Mind Fest

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Patna

The team called 'Happy Eid', comprising Calvin, Gokul, and Ankur, on Wednesday won the General Quiz contest on the opening day of the two-day Patna Mind Fest (PMF). 'Patna Ke Presleys', comprising Sanabway Baherjee, Shashank Tyagi, and Jayakanth R, won the 1st Runner-up position.

'Endu Cutlets', the team from Mumbai comprising Rajiv Rai, Vibhendu Tiwari, and Brajendu Bhaskar, earned the 2nd Runner-up spot.

Earlier, the India Quiz saw 'Endu Cutlets' clinching the 1st position. The 1st Runner-up position went to 'Patna Ke Presleys' and the 2nd Runner-up position to Saswata, Nikhil, and Arunodayo who called their team 'Smells Like Team

than 300 participants from all walks of life, but mostly schoolchildren, showcasing their writing skills. The results will be announced tomorrow.

Earlier in the day, the event was inaugurated by Anjani Kumar Singh, Director-General, Bihar Museum. Also present on the dais were Vivek Kumar Singh, Chairman, RERA Bihar; Ms Rachana Patil, IAS, Secretary, Department of Finance, Bihar; Sanjay Kumar, IAS, Additional Secretary, Governor Secretariat; Abhay Jha, IAS, Additional Secretary, Rural Works Department; and Prof Rana Singh, Director, CIMP.

The 8th edition of the PMF is being held at the Chandragupta Institute of Management Patna. An annual event organized by the Bihar IAS Officers'



Vedanta group firms surge; Vedanta Resources denies reports of stake sale in group cos

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Shares of Vedanta group firms were in demand on Wednesday, with Vedanta Oil and Gas, Vedanta Iron And Steel and Vedanta Aluminium Metal rallying sharply, defying a bearish trend in equities.

Meanwhile, Vedanta Resources on Wednesday denied recent media speculation regarding a purported sale of its shareholding in Vedanta Ltd, Vedanta Aluminium, or any other Vedanta group company.

Shares of Vedanta Oil and Gas surged 5.57 per cent, Vedanta Iron And Steel rallied 4.98 per cent, Vedanta jumped 4.31 per cent, Vedanta Aluminium Metal climbed 3.32 per cent and Vedanta Power was up 1.57 per cent on the BSE.

"Vedanta Resources Limited denies the recent media speculation regarding a purported sale of its shareholding in Vedanta Limited, Vedanta

Aluminium, or any other Vedanta group company, and confirms that there is currently no such plan," a Vedanta spokesperson said.

The company remains focused on growth and full value unlock — anchored in its landmark merger into five focused world-class companies, an ambitious growth capex pipeline, a strong deleveraging track record and consistent shareholder returns — as it continues its journey to build "five Vedantas" and transform for good, the spokesperson added.

Vedanta group's demerged entities — Vedanta Aluminium Metal, Vedanta Power, Vedanta Oil and Gas and Vedanta Iron And Steel — made their stock market debut on June 15 this year.

In the equity market, the 30-share BSE Sensex declined 183.15 points, or 0.24 per cent, to settle at 77,472.94. The 50-share NSE Nifty was down 126.80 points, or 0.52 per cent, to end at 24,207.75.



chairman of Vedanta Resources Limited Anil Agarwal

DAILY SUDOKU

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.

SOLUTION (26.8.26)

DOUBLE CROSSWORD

THURSDAY | AUGUST 27, 2026

ACROSS

DOWN

1. Writ-es

2. Th-OM-as

3. S-Lay

4. Cosh-b-oy

5. Lass-o

6. S-even

7. Lay-out

8. Ed-en

9. Set

10. S-limey

11. Chaste

12. Are

13. T-will

14. Gat

15. Ye-L-L-s

16. Brown

17. Teas

18. DEF-oe

19. Belay

20. Den

21. Base-men

22. Met

23. S-av-our

24. Ed-en

25. Lay-out

26. Whiff

27. D-all-y

28. Tie

29. Lids

1. Oust tenants from the east side of Victoria? (5)

2. He could play a wild Croat (5)

3. But it could be one to play (4)

4. The fruits of one's studies of history? (5)

5. Go around to an ancient city (4)

6. In business, a swell thing to do (6)

7. Narrate in unoriginal style (6)

8. 11 Such recruits are unfamiliar with war (3)

9. Figure it as a mark on one's head (5)

10. A growing source of flavouring for gin (7)

11. The little that sank in (3)

12. Pieces arranged for piano recitals (9)

13. Carry to Acton central by car (4)

14. Dad figures it's something handy (4)

15. 26 Man of tomorrow? (3)

16. 27 Possessing nothing, he'd worked on the land (4)

17. 29 A low-key state of mind (4)

18. 32 Turn up with a growl - a beastly noise? (3)

19. 33 A vessel to push, roughly? (5)

20. 34 Is unlikely to be broken (especially if vinyl) (6)

21. 35 Historic battle of marginal prominence (4)

22. 36 Was he burning to write Dracula? (6) exclamation(4)

16 Too much talk of breaking asunder (3)

18 Ben Hur's brother? (6)

20 She's a treasure to mum (5)

21 Show a profit on a piece of land from Paisley (3)

22 Arcadian rotter? (3)

23 Convincing information in bed (6)

25 Barker, it seems, can figure to go up (3)

28 Neatness in using a word erroneously? (5)

30 All round, it's less than exorbitant (5)

31 Gave the players a hand (5)

32 Such pies can be deceptive (4)

33 Buzzers at Brentford (4)

 BRIEFLY

Puligilla, Sherif set for WRC3 challenge at Rally del Paraguay



Indian rally driver Naveen Puligilla and co-driver Musa Sherif will compete in the WRC3 category at Rally del Paraguay, the 11th round of the FIA World Rally Championship, here from August 27 to 30.

The Team Duran Racing duo, driving a Ford Fiesta Rally3 prepared by MRU Motorsport, head into the event after winning the ARC3 class at last month's Rwanda Mountain Gorilla Rally.

They will also compete in the next WRC round in Chile. The rally features 22 red-gravel special stages covering 357.64 km.

Puligilla, the reigning 2025 Indian National Rally Champion in the 3T class, said the high-speed stages and changing grip would demand precision.

"What makes Paraguay unique is the combination of high-speed stages, changing grip and very tight margins. We have to be precise with our braking and lines," Puligilla said.

(PTI)

Mayank, Pratitee triumph in Asian junior chess title



Mayank Chakraborty and Pratitee Bordoloi clinched the Open and Girls titles as India completed a memorable double at the Asian Junior Classical Chess Championship here on Wednesday.

Top seed Mayank lived up to his billing by finishing the nine-round Open Championship with 7.5 points to claim the gold medal. Russia's Artem Pingin secured the silver with seven points, while India's Daksh Goyal produced an impressive performance to take the bronze with 6.5 points.

Pratitee completed the hosts' golden double by winning the Girls title with 7.5 points from nine rounds. Kazakhstan's Mariya Kholiyavko finished just half a point behind to take the silver, while Nivedita V C secured the bronze with 6.5 points. The championship also proved highly rewarding for several players who earned coveted FIDE titles and norms.

Open champion Mayank, who is already GM-elect, added another Grandmaster norm through his title-winning performance. Bronze medallist Daksh Goyal earned the FIDE Master title as well as an International Master norm.

Girls champion Pratitee earned the Woman International Master title and also secured a Woman Grandmaster norm. Silver medallist Mariya earned a WIM norm, while bronze medallist Nivedita also secured a WIM norm.

India's dominance was reflected in the overall medal tally, with the hosts capturing four of the six medals on offer in the Classical Championships -- two gold and two bronze.

(PTI)

India's para hockey players discover a world of confidence



MONA PARTHSARATHI
■ Amstelveen

While India's hockey teams chased a World Cup medal, 10 youngsters from the country were discovering something equally valuable away from the spotlight of the Wagener Stadium — the confidence to dream bigger.

For the players who represented India at the Para Hockey World Cup, the thrill of boarding an aeroplane for the first time, travelling abroad, meeting players from different countries and simply enjoying the game often mattered more than the result.

India finished sixth in the tournament, with Italy emerging champions, but for the members of the Indian contingent, the experience was about much more than their final position.

"This has been a life-changing experience for the kids, not only in sports but also as individuals. They are meeting people from different countries, which is helping build their confidence and character," said Pratiek Talukdar, head of the Indian contingent, said.

(PTI)

Sachin's greatness aside, Joe Root's appetite for runs is laudable



SHAKYA MITRA

Five years ago, if someone had asked which Test batter had the best chance of overtaking Sachin Tendulkar's world-record tally of 15,921 runs, Joe Root would probably not have been the answer. At the time, Root was still behind his great contemporaries Steve Smith, Virat Kohli and Kane Williamson when it came to centuries and overall consistency. Yet cricket has a habit of making yesterday's improbable tomorrow's possibility, and Root has now emerged as the only realistic challenger to Tendulkar's record with 14180 runs in 167 Tests.

The transformation has been remarkable. Root, who was England captain until the 2021-22 Ashes and has now returned to the role, appeared at one point to be almost an awkward fit for Bazball. The aggressive philosophy associated with Ben Stokes and Brendon McCullum seemed, at least in theory, at odds with the classical, technically correct batter Root represented. Instead, the opposite happened. Root has enjoyed an extraordinary late-career resurgence, scoring 21 Test centuries from the summer of 2021 to now. Sixteen of those have come since Stokes and McCullum took over in

the summer of 2022. His contemporaries have in the meanwhile fallen away from the race. Kohli has retired from Test cricket, while Williamson has retired from international cricket altogether.

Smith as of now remains active in Tests, but at 37 he is a year older than Root and is behind him by more than 3000 runs. Suddenly, the record that once appeared virtually untouchable has a plausible challenger.

Yet this is where the discussion becomes more complicated than simple numbers.

Tendulkar has an almost God-like status in cricket, much as Sir Don Bradman did before him. His numbers are extraordinary, but his contribution to the game goes far beyond them. When Tendulkar retired after his 200th Test, the scale of his achievements made his records appear almost impossible to approach. He remains the leading run-scorer in Test history, the holder of the record for Test centuries and the player with the most appearances. More importantly, he first played for India as a 16-year-old, carried the country's batting through significant portions of his career and lived under an almost unimaginable level of scrutiny and expectation.

Root cannot have Tendulkar's story because he has not had Tendulkar's story. But he can have his own, built on the sheer weight of performance.

There is also an important question about whether we should be



actively celebrating the possibility of an individual record being overtaken when cricket is, fundamentally, a team sport. Root is now England's Test captain again, making that question even more pertinent. Has he spoken about chasing Tendulkar? In his own words while the conversation is impossible to ignore, he has preferred to focus on his own batting. The remarkable thing about Root is that the milestones have appeared to follow him rather than the other way around. He has let the runs do the talking for him.

The mathematics, however, make the possibility real. If Root sustains an average of around 50, slightly below his career average, he would need roughly another 35 innings to pass Tendulkar. That equates to a minimum of 18 Test matches,

assuming he bats twice in each.

Age may not be a factor for 36-year-old Root, England has frequently let some of their finest players carry on provided they are good enough to be selected. James Anderson played international cricket until he was 42, while Graham Gooch, Geoffrey Boycott and Alec Stewart all played into their 40s. If Root continues producing runs, age alone is unlikely to close the door.

But perhaps there is something fitting about Tendulkar retaining the record. It is not merely an Indian record; it belongs, in a sense, to the wider cricketing world. A recent incident involving South African all-rounder Wiaan Mulder offered an interesting parallel. Mulder was unbeaten on 367 against Zimbabwe, just 33 short of Brian Lara's world-

Women Hockey WC: India eye historic fifth place finish against higher ranked Germany

MONA PARTHSARATHI
■ Amstelveen

India will look to put the disappointment of missing out on a semifinal spot behind them and sign off from the Women's Hockey World Cup with a win when they face higher-ranked Germany in the fifth-place playoff here on Wednesday.

For India, the contest is not just about finishing fifth but also about carrying the confidence of an impressive World Cup campaign into next month's Asian Games, where a gold medal would bring direct qualification for the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics.

India have lost just one match in the tournament and, irrespective of the result against the two-time champions, are assured of their



best World Cup finish since their fourth-place effort in the inaugural edition in 1974.

India, featuring 11 World Cup debutants, will face a stern test against a side that has already beaten it twice in practice matches before the tournament.

India's semifinal hopes were dashed on Sunday after

a goalless draw against Australia in their final second-round pool match, where they needed a win to progress.

The three-day break, however, has given Sjoerd Marijne's side time to recover from the disappointment and refocus on the final challenge.

"This rest was crucial to recover from the setback in the previous match. Now, the team will play against Germany with renewed vigour and freshness," Marijne said.

"The team has overcome the disappointment of not reaching the semifinals and is now fully focused on defeating Germany and leaving the tournament with a win. We want to improve our game and perform better for the Asian Games."

India began their campaign with a 2-2 draw against Olympic silver medallists China before thrashing South Africa 6-1, with six different players finding the net.

A goalless draw in their final Pool D match against England took them into the second round.

(PTI)

Mirabai Chanu bracing for Asian Games next month



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Ace Indian weightlifter and Olympic medallist Mirabai Chanu is bracing for an Olympic-level battle at the Asian Games in Aichi-Nagoya, with powerhouse nations China, North Korea and Thailand expected to bring their strongest lifters to the continental showpiece.

Mirabai, 32, has won every medal that has to be won in the world, including an Olympic silver in the 2020 Tokyo Games, but an Asian Games podium has eluded her during an illustrious career despite her best efforts.

She recently clinched gold at the Commonwealth Games in Glasgow for her third top-podium finish at the quadrennial event, but insists the Asian Games is a different beast altogether, with the competition set to be far more intense than at the Commonwealth level. "To be honest, the competition in the Commonwealth Games was not tough for me. I did not have to put in a lot of effort at Glasgow. The real test lies ahead," Mirabai told SAI Media, ahead of her Asian Games beginning on September 19.

"I want to see how far I can go in Japan. The Asian Games have been the toughest for me. You will probably see the 'Olympics' at the Asian Games this time because the strongest lifters in our weight category are from Asia," said

Mirabai, underlining the sheer scale of the challenge awaiting her at the continental showpiece.

Mirabai's best Asian Games finish came in Hangzhou in 2023, where she was placed fourth in the 49kg category. A hip and thigh injury hampered her performance and denied her a place on the podium. In the 2018 edition in Jakarta, she was ruled out with a severe back injury.

The Indian star knows there is no room for complacency as she hunts the one major medal missing from her cabinet. With staying injury-free her top priority, Mirabai is following the regimen laid down by long-time coach Vijay Sharma and American strength and conditioning coach Dr Aaron Horschig, while putting herself through a gruelling training grind for her elusive Asian Games breakthrough.

"We have a video call every Thursday with him and we discuss everything about training, recovery and the next steps. Everything is reviewed to the finest detail and since Dr Horschig was a weightlifter himself, he knows every muscle in the body. "This constant review has kept me in shape," said Mirabai, whose association with Dr Horschig goes back to 2020.

Such is Mirabai's hunger for the elusive Asian Games medal that she barely had time to savour her Glasgow Commonwealth Games gold.

India names squad for AFC U20 Asian Cup Qualifiers

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India on Wednesday named a 23-member squad for the upcoming AFC U20 Asian Cup Qualifiers in Tashkent, after omitting eight players who were called for the national camp.

The qualifying tournament will be held in the Uzbek capital from August 31 to September 6.

The main tournament will be held in China next year.

From the previously announced 30-player squad ahead of the Singapore friendlies earlier this month, eight players were released for either technical or injury-related considerations, the All India Football Federation (AIFF) said. They are Shuhaid Koya Thangal PS, Arshvir Singh, Ashik Adhikari, Dallalmuon Gangte, Levis Zangminlu, Agastya Bhat, Nirupam Gowda H and Yohaana Benjamin.

Meanwhile, Daniyal



Makakmayum has joined the squad.

More than a hundred players were assessed since the trials began in Bengaluru in June, before the final 23 were selected.

Mahesh Gawali's side played four friendly matches earlier this month,

defeating Singapore twice (3-0 and 1-0), drawing 0-0 with Yemen, and securing a 1-0 victory in the second match against the West Asians.

The Blue Colts will arrive in Tashkent on Thursday. They will face Syria on August 31, hosts Uzbekistan

on September 3 and conclude their Group B campaign against Bangladesh on September 6.

The group winners and the seven best runners-up across all eight groups will qualify for the AFC U20 Asian Cup China 2027.

The Squad:

Goalkeepers: Jaskaran Dub, Pranav Sundarraman, Suraj Singh Aheibam. Defenders: Asher Rebello, Bungson Singh Takhellambam, Karish Soram, Malemngamba Singh Thokchom, Sumit Sharma Brahmacharimayum, Yaipharemba Chingakhram.

Midfielders: Aniket Yadav, Danny Meitei Laishram, Md Arbash, Rishi Singh Ningthoukhongjam, Rishikanta Meitei Laishram, Samson Ahongshangbam, Shami Singamayum.

Forwards: Daniyal Makakmayum, Gunleiba Wangkheirakpam, Hateem Ali, Omang Dodum, Prashan Jajo, Rohen Singh Chaphamayum, Vishal Yadav.

Amid space crunch in Japan, OCA tells NOCs, including India, not to seek late additions

POONAM MEHRA
■ New Delhi

With Japan expressing its inability to accommodate anything more than 15,000 participants at the upcoming Asian Games, the Olympic Council of Asia (OCA) has sent out an advisory asking national bodies, including that of India, to not seek late additions and keep their contingent sizes to prescribed limits.

India have cleared 492 athletes to compete in the September 19 to October 4 Games in Aichi-Nagoya, Japan. The support staff contingent is yet to be unveiled

as deliberations are still on to finalise the number.

The OCA said it has already accommodated several "daily requests" from a number of member nations to allow late additions to the athletes' contingent despite the deadline for nominations ending last month.

However, with the local organisers making it clear that the 15,000 threshold cannot be breached, it would not accept anymore requests and would only allow replacements due to accommodation being limited.

"The support staff is still being worked out because some federations have not



named any sports science experts in their recommendations. The list has been

sent back to the Indian Olympic Association (IOA) and it will take a few more

days. But yes, an advisory has also come which mandates that the contingent sizes not exceed the prescribed limit," a Sports Authority of India (SAI) source told PTI.

"The cap on support staff cannot be exceeded and though federations would want several to go with even small squads, they have been asked to cut the numbers and ensure that there is adequate medical staff to assist athletes," the source added.

The rules cap the size of support staff at 33 per cent of the contingent size.

Going by the current size of their athletes' contingent, India would have to limit the

support staff at not more than 162 unless the OCA relaxes the threshold.

But the advisory makes it clear that it would not be done because of the limited accommodation on offer at Aichi-Nagoya.

After the OCA admitted that the current number of athletes and officials "significantly" exceeds the 15,000 mark, the organisers publicly expressed their inability to handle more than the originally envisioned number.

"We cannot accommodate this. We have made arrangements and budgets based on the host city contract's capacity of 15,000 people, so we

cannot accommodate more than that. There is no physical place for them to stay, so I wonder what they will do," Governor of Aichi Prefecture, Hideaki Omura, was quoted as saying by 'inside-thegames.com'.

Nagoya is the capital of Aichi prefecture and the fourth largest city in Japan.

The region will be hosting events in 43 disciplines, including cricket, aquatics, hockey, wrestling and archery among others.

India's participation will be in 35 disciplines with athletics getting the largest representation of 73 in the contingent.

(PTI)

2nd Test: India on verge of series win despite Sooriyabandara, Mendis fight

G UNNIKRISHNAN
■ Colombo

Sri Lankan batters were defiant in phases but the Indian bowlers made a timely intervention to reduce the hosts to 229 for six in their second innings on day four of the second and final Test here on Wednesday.

Sonal Dinusha (7) and Keshara Nuwantha (3) were in the middle at stumps when the now customary evening rain and bad light stopped play. But India will be eager to end Lanka's last vestige of hope and wrap the match and series on day five.

Before Indian bowlers established their domination, the 115-run third wicket alliance between Pasindu Sooriyabandara (92) and Kamindu Mendis (55) was the primary source of Lankan fight-back. Sooriyabandara and Mendis joined forces when Lanka were wobbling at 63 for two, but resisted the Indian bowlers for the next 110 minutes.

The pair bridged the heavy 213-run innings deficit that forced them to follow-on.

However, Sri Lanka's effort in that period was a marked improvement from their first dig in which they were bundled out for 290, which was a mere 13 runs shy of the follow-on mark.

That total was constructed around the highly-impressive



Dinusha's 103, his second hundred of the series.

But the Sooriyabandara-Mendis partnership in the ongoing innings was the reason behind the match getting extended to its final day after they lost openers Lahiru Udara and Kamil Mishara early in the second essay. It is easy to imagine their stand as an obdurate one considering the situation in which Sri Lanka found themselves in.

But Sooriyabandara and Mendis played with freedom and were never hesitant to take the attack to the bowlers. Mendis creamed Manav Suthar for two sixes, and did not allow the left-arm spinner to settle into a consistent rhythm.

Later, Sooriyabandara too slog-swept Suthar for a six as the young twacker struggled for an impact for the first time in this series.

Mendis reached his fifty off

87 balls with a flourish, pulling Prasidh Krishna for a six and soon Sooriyabandara too joined his teammate with a 78-ball fifty.

However, Prasidh broke the swelling stand with a short-pitched ball which cramped Mendis for room, and Shubman Gill completed a fine running catch to give marching orders to the Lankan batter. The host went into tea at a rather comfortable position of 199 for three, needing just 14 runs more to overhaul the ignominy of an innings defeat.

However, the final session of the day redrew the complexion of the match as India picked up three wickets.

Skipper Dhananjaya de Silva was the first to depart, inside edging Suthar to Devdutt Padikkal in the cordon. Sooriyabandara looked primed for his maiden Test

hundred but a moment of madness snapped his stay. Till then batting with composure, the right-hander gave a charge to Suthar. The Indian twacker detected the charge very early and fired a delivery wide of Sooriyabandara and Rishabh Pant just had the job of whipping the balls.

Saransh Jain, who generated considerable turn, trapped Nirosan Dickwella in front of stumps as the home side slumped to 218 for six.

With nearly an hour remaining on the day, India tried to pull curtains down on Lanka innings but the skies opened up with a vengeance to halt the play at 4.37 pm.

Sri Lanka had another little moment of joy too earlier in the first segment of the day when Dinusha, who was overnight 85, compiled his hundred. Dinusha raced to 90s with a six, a slog sweep, and four, again whacked to the on-side, off Jain.

The right-hander reached the coveted three-figure with a thunderous pull off Prasidh, a moment he celebrated with pride and gusto. But his effort was not enough to save his side from the follow-on.

However, India had a moment of worry as pacer Mohammad Siraj hurt himself while diving for a catch. The pacer had to go out to get medical attention but was back on the field after some time. (PTI)

Test, ODI and T20 can co-exist, players need to find a balanced technique: SL legend Dias

G UNNIKRISHNAN
■ Colombo

Former Sri Lankan batter and veteran coach Roy Dias said that the relevance of Test and ODI formats have not shrunk amid the onslaught of T20, and advised young cricketers to develop proper technique to excel in all three versions of the game. Dias believed the old-school virtues like patience and innings-building has a place in fast-paced modern-day cricket.

"In our days, the move from Test to ODIs was a bit easier because even that format started with 60 overs and then became 50 overs. But now, we have a lot of T20 matches and leagues, and the young batsmen need to find the balance very quickly," Dias told PTI. "They need to treat T20, ODI and Test differently and the players need to train

accordingly. You cannot ignore T20 now, because it is here to stay. With T20, they need to play only three-and-a-half-hours or so and bowl a maximum of four overs. Batters need to try and hit even good balls for fours or sixes.

"So if you train only for that format, it will be tough to play other formats which are played over a longer duration. So, get your basics right in the longer format, and having a good base will only help you in ODIs and T20s," he said.

But how tough is it for Test and ODI cricket to survive when the world's priority is gradually shifting to T20, particularly as an expansion tool?

Dias felt that the older versions can co-exist with the newborn. "For me, Test cricket will always be the best format. Nothing tests your skills against bowlers and conditions like it. There is a place for



all formats, and each format demands different skill sets, and appeals to different audiences," he said.

Unlike in the 70s or 80s or even in the 90s, the sub-continent batters have been struggling to negate spinners of late.

Does he think the art of playing spin has gone down in modern times?

"See, when I started a lot of quality spinners were around. Our coaches told us to play spin very late, wait for the turn and then play it with soft hands. You know, (late West Indian legend) Sir Gary Sobers was coaching us in the 80s, and his tips were very helpful as he was a master technician against spin," he said. (PTI)

Duleep Trophy: North set-up semis date with South Zone

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bengaluru

Left-arm spinners Abid Mushtaq and Nishant Sindhu took exactly 6.3 overs to polish off the West Zone tail as North Zone entered the Duleep Trophy semi-final with an impressive 52-run win duly completed here in the first hour of the final day. Chasing a tough target of 287 on a track that offered grip and turn, West started the final day at 220 for 7 with Urvil Patel (25) and the dependable Tanush Kotian (0) at the crease but were bowled out for 234 in 57.3 overs.

It was Mushtaq (4/60 in 22 overs), who cleaned up Kotian quickly to set the ball



rolling and followed it up with the wicket of Tushar Deshpande (5), who resisted for 18 balls before being caught by Abdul Samad.

Mushtaq however was unlucky not to get his second five-wicket haul in the game as Sindhu found Urvil plumb in-front to finish off the pro-

ceedings in style.

Fittingly, the 29-year-old Mushtaq was adjudged player-of the match for his match figures of 9/99.

The turning point of this game certainly will be West Zone skipper Ruturaj Gaikwad's (66 off 70 balls) run-out after a comfortable

111-run stand with Musheer Khan (96). At that stage, West were cruising along at 195/3 in pursuit of 287 and it seemed like a cakewalk.

West lost four wickets including Gaikwad and Musheer in less than seven overs for an addition of 25 runs and were pushed to wall by the end of the third day's play. On a wicket where lot of deliveries kept low, scoring 67 with just three wickets in hand on the final day was akin to scoring more than '150' if degree of difficulty had to be factored in.

North will now play South Zone, while East will take on Central in the semifinals starting at the COE from August 30. While the East versus NorthEast was predictable

Spinners bowling no-ball a concern, introducing free-hit will reduce its percentage: Bahutule

G UNNIKRISHNAN
■ Colombo

Spin bowling coach Sairaj Bahutule on Wednesday offered a unique measure to curb the menace of no-balls that has been plaguing Indian spinners in the ongoing second Test against Sri Lanka — suggesting to introduce free-hit in the longest format.

The Indian spin unit was guilty of overstepping 10 times so far in the second Test against Sri Lanka here.

It's the most no-balls bowled by a spin attack since 2021 whereas Afghanistan top the chart with 14 illegal deliveries.

"It is something which we have been working on. It is definitely a concern at times. But when the bowler is putting in that effort and gets a wicket in situations where



wickets are not coming, he has a tendency to push himself, but that is not an excuse," said Bahutule in the post-day press conference.

"But a lot of work has been put in with (Ravindra) Jadeja, with Saransh (Jain), about where the take-off point is. But sometimes, the effort they put in for that particular delivery is a bit more

and they tend to overstep. I am sure they will rectify it and get better," he added.

However, Bahutule offered a rather unexpected solution — copy free-hits into Test cricket from white ball formats. Of course, the suggestion was more in half-jest. "I am no guardian of the rules but if a free-hit comes, obviously, no-balls will definitely be reduced. No

team would want to bowl those no-balls and give that extra ball and give those extra runs.

"Obviously, the take-off point is talked about. They understand what is happening and definitely a process will be put forward in terms of minimising," he said.

But how serious the bowlers and support staff are at nets in correcting the no-ball issue?

"I think the reminders are given during nets also. It is similar to a match situation. We take every session seriously and it is monitored from the side.

"Sometimes, I stay as an umpire and sometimes the other coaches stand as umpires. We are monitoring spinners and fast bowlers. So, we definitely give importance to it and work in progress," he said. (PTI)

UP Warriorz need to rework combinations, says Neetu David

DEVARCHIT VARMA
■ Mumbai

UP Warriorz will need to rework their combinations and not repeat the mistakes of the past as they look to turn their fortunes around in the Women's Premier League, said chief scout Neetu David here on Wednesday.

Neetu, a former India spinner who was also the chairperson of the senior women's selection committee, has been appointed as the chief scout of the franchise which finished at the bottom in the points table in the last two seasons.

"I am very happy that I have joined UP Warriorz; this is my team because I am also from UP. I will try to select the best players for the tournament according to my conversations with (head coach) Abhishek (Nayar)," Neetu told PTI in an interaction organised by the franchise.

"I won't say there is any extra pressure," she said when asked about her transition from being the chairperson of Indian selectors to UPW's chief scout.

"...But the mistakes that we have made in the last two or three years, we will try not to make those mistakes and try to rectify



them." "As far as selection is concerned, we are trying to have a look at our combinations whether it is batting or bowling. We have been talking about this for a long time and keeping this in mind I am looking at the other aspects, be it our domestic cricket or about players from around the world," Neetu said.

UPW, who had Australia legend Alyssa Healy at the leadership helm and behind the wickets in the first two seasons of WPL, went into last edition without any frontline wicketkeeper.

"We are paying attention to wicketkeeping as well. Plus, we are also looking at spin bowlers, someone who takes the ball away, we are in search for that," Neetu said.

The former left-arm

spinner said she has had productive discussions with head coach Nayar in order to take the team in the right direction, adding that there is no specific pressure on her.

"I can't say how much my role will benefit or not. But it is important for us to not repeat the mistakes which is what we will work on, not just in the coming season but in years to come. We will need to play the right combination," Neetu said.

"Abhishek is very sorted and all the conversations that I have had with him, this year he is very clear how he has to take the team ahead. (Team mentor) Lisa (Sthalekar) has also helped a lot so we hope that UP Warriorz will do a lot better in coming time," Neetu added. (PTI)

Pak team has already lost lot of fans: Ramiz Raja's warning to players

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Karachi

Former Pakistan cricketer Ramiz Raja has warned that the team is losing its fan base due to poor performances, urging players to give their diehard supporters something to cheer about. The former Pakistan Cricket Board (PCB) chairman said fans do not expect Pakistan to win every match, but they do expect a fighting spirit, positive body language and the willingness to compete.

Pakistan suffered a heavy defeat against England in the first Test at Leeds, losing by an innings and 103 runs. The second Test begins at Lord's on Thursday, with skipper Babar Azam's fitness still a concern after he missed the opener through injury. "Social media is after them (Pakistan team). They've already lost a lot of fans. So it's become a norm when you lose a Test match, it's become another loss and it means another lot (of fans) withdrawing from cricket," said Ramiz on a cricket podcast with former England captains Alastair Cook and Michael Vaughan, highlighting the growing disinterest among Pakistan's fans.

The former Pakistan skipper said that, during his tenure as PCB chairman, he placed strong emphasis on building Pakistan cricket's fan base and brand, warning that losing fan support can become a serious problem for any team.

Manjrekar slams ICC, BCCI for going soft on disciplinary violations by youngsters

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Former India batter Sanjay Manjrekar has criticised the ICC and the BCCI for their handling of recent disciplinary violations by young players Vaibhav Sooryavanshi and Yashasvi Jaiswal, saying that the two bodies are "training" them to repeat such behaviour by letting them get away with it.

Both Jaiswal and Sooryavanshi have been involved in heated on-field confrontations with the former even defending his actions in the face of criticism.

"Dear @icc & @bcci Vaibhav for Ind A recently & now Jaiswal... if you keep letting them get away with such behaviour, you train them to repeat such behaviour. It's not good for the sport & crucially their own future too," Manjrekar wrote on 'X'.

Jaiswal and Sri Lanka seamer Asitha Fernando were fined 25 per cent of their match fee for an on-field altercation on day one of the second Test in Colombo. The duo was also handed a demerit point each.

They were involved in a showdown after Fernando dismissed Jaiswal in the 17th



over of India's first innings.

Jaiswal walked towards Fernando and the two exchanged words, following which Fernando moved his head towards Jaiswal. In response, Jaiswal leant in, resulting in their heads making contact.

Before start of play on day two, Jaiswal defended his actions saying "If you don't know what he said then please don't make your judgment if anyone cross the line we need to let them know this India will fight and reply".

In June, 15-year-old batting sensation Sooryavanshi was involved in a heated argument that almost led to a physical confrontation with a Sri Lanka A player after an

ill-tempered end to a one-day tri-series which India A lost following a Super Over.

Needing 17 to win in the Super Over, India managed only nine runs against slinger Kaguthas Mathulan. Sooryavanshi, who faced the last three deliveries from Mathulan, managed only six runs including a boundary.

Once the match got over, the Lankan team indulged in slightly exuberant celebrations as Sooryavanshi and his partner Suryansh Shedge walked back towards the pavilion.

TV cameras then caught Sooryavanshi angrily charging towards Mathulan before one of his teammates Vishen Halambage came in between.

Starc replaces Bumrah as top-ranked Test bowler

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Dubai

Australia fast bowler Mitchell Starc has attained the No. 1 position in the ICC Test rankings for the first time in his career after his 10-wicket haul in MacKay helped win the second match of their ICC World Test Championship series against Bangladesh.

The 36-year-old left-armers grabbed six for 12 and four for 39 to star in the innings and 51 runs victory, overtaking



Matt Henry and Jasprit Bumrah, whom he leads by 10 rating points.

Starc, whose previous best position was second that he first achieved after the Boxing Day Test last year, was named the Player of the Match and the Player of the Series. Bumrah's latest reign at the top lasted just two months but he has a combined 697 days as number one, which is the most by an India bowler and the 14th-most ever. He was ruled out

of the ongoing series against Sri Lanka due to an injury.

England seam bowler Ollie Robinson is another major gainer, his hauls of five for 51 and three for 39 helping him win the Player of the Match award in an innings and 103 runs victory over Pakistan in the first of three Tests in Leeds and lifted him 15 spots to 11th among bowlers.

Josh Tongue, who also grabbed eight wickets at Headingley, has progressed 16 places to 17th.